

Namo Bharat hits 1.25 lakh passengers in single day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut Nam0 Bharat corridor recorded its highest-ever single-day ridership on Monday, with around 1.25 lakh passengers using the service, the National Capital Region Transport Corporation (NCRTC) said in a statement on Tuesday.

The transit agency said approximately 1,25,500 commuters travelled on the corridor on Monday, surpassing previous ridership figures. On average, around one lakh passengers are using the service daily, it said.

NCRTC attributed the growing ridership to reduced travel time, reliability of train operations and prevailing heatwave conditions, saying that the service is increasingly being used by office-goers, students and other daily commuters

travelling between Delhi, Ghaziabad and Meerut.

According to the corporation, train operations on the corridor are maintaining nearly 99 per cent punctuality, helping passengers reach their destinations on time while avoiding road traffic congestion. Among the busiest stations on the corridor are Sarai Kale Khan, New Ashok Nagar and Anand Vihar in Delhi, along with Ghaziabad and Begumpul stations in Uttar Pradesh.

NCRTC said these stations account for more than 40 per cent of the total ridership due to their connectivity with Metro services, railways, inter-state bus terminals and city bus networks.

The corporation also highlighted the role of the local Metro services operating on the same infrastructure in Meerut, saying that the arrangement has improved intra-



city mobility and enabled seamless travel for commuters. The increase in ridership comes amid prevailing heatwave conditions across Delhi-NCR, where temperatures have remained above 40 degrees Celsius in recent days, it said. The NCRTC said the fully air-conditioned trains have provided a comfortable travel option during the summer months.

To cater to rising demands, the corporation recently introduced 18 additional train trips during the peak hours between Sarai Kale Khan and Meerut South stations. The additional services operate in the morning and evening peak periods, it said.

The NCRTC said the continued rise in passenger numbers indicates that the Nam0 Bharat service is becoming an increasingly important mode of public transport for daily commuters in the National Capital Region.

Crackdown on encroachments, illegal parking in Delhi

ANUSHKA DAS ■ New Delhi

The Delhi Traffic Police, in coordination with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), carried out a city-wide anti-encroachment and unauthorised parking operation across the national Capital. More than 1,000 encroachments were cleared, and over 3,000 vehicles were towed to improve traffic flow and pedestrian safety.

The four-day operation, carried out from June 3 to June 6 under the direction of Manish Aggarwal, the Special Commissioner of Police, Traffic Management Division, covered all traffic circles and ranges in Delhi. Enforcement teams targeted major arterial roads, market stretches, footpaths, service lanes, designated parking areas and other traffic-sensitive locations where encroachments and illegal parking were causing congestion and safety concerns.

According to official figures, action was taken at 144 locations across Delhi between June 1 and June 7. During the drive, authorities removed 1,264 rehi *patri* encroachments from roads and footpaths. They cleared 1,015 unauthorised structures, including temporary kiosks, illegal commercial extensions, obstructive displays, and other obstructions that affected public movement.

The campaign also led to the impounding or towing of 3,123 vehicles found abandoned, illegally parked or obstructing roads and footpaths. In addition, the Delhi Traffic Police issued 55,532 challans against motorists and other violators whose



In the first phase, the focused drive covered six identified locations: Spark Mall in Kamla Nagar, M-Block Market in Greater Kailash-I, Hauz Khas, Qutub Road, Nizamuddin Basti and Parade Ground.

The second phase will target additional locations, including Max Saket, Church Mission Road, Pushp Vihar Road, Max Shalimar Bagh, Yousuf Sarai, Alaknanda Commercial Complex, areas near the Community Centre and Sabzi Mandi in Geeta Colony, Car Bazar in Laxmi Nagar, the Geeta Colony boundary wall and areas around Karkardooma Courts.

Officials emphasised that encroachments and unauthorised parking are not merely civic violations but also serious road safety concerns.

DABUR ACCELERATES DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION WITH STRATEGIC GLOBAL CAPABILITY CENTERS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Dabur India Ltd has announced the establishment and expansion of strategic Global Capability Centers (GCCs) to strengthen its digital transformation journey and build a future-ready, globally integrated enterprise.

The IT GCC will serve as a strategic hub driving enterprise technology, data, cybersecurity, cloud infrastructure, analytics, Generative AI and business transformation initiatives. Complementing this,

the Digital Marketing GCC will leverage AI, data, automation and advanced MarTech capabilities to enhance consumer engagement, marketing effectiveness and ROI. “Creating these GCCs is about building a more agile, intelligent and consumer-centric organisation that can scale innovation and remain future-ready,” said Dabur Global CEO Mohit Malhotra.

Global CIO Manas Mehra said the GCCs will combine technology, data and creativity to drive efficiency, and consumer engagement.

DU student held with ₹20 lakh marijuana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 22-year-old Delhi University student pursuing a Bachelor of Arts degree at Satyawati College has been arrested from Vijay Nagar in north Delhi with 195 grams of hydroponic marijuana, commonly known as OG, with an estimated international market value of approximately ₹20 lakh, which he had been supplying to fellow students and other contacts to fund what police describe as a lavish lifestyle.

The accused has been identified as Jaseem Siyadul Farsan MP, a resident of Vijay Nagar Double Storey and originally from Kozhikode in Kerala. He is currently in the eighth semester of his BA programme at Satyawati College.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Northwest, Akansha Yadav, confirmed the arrest at a press conference on Tuesday. “Jaseem is a student of Satyawati College, Delhi University, and is currently pursuing a BA degree in the eighth semester,” she said.

Acting on specific intelligence about the sale of hydroponic marijuana near a park in Vijay Nagar Double Storey, a police team conducted a raid and apprehended the accused. During the operation, 195 grams of hydroponic marijuana were recovered from his possession.

Govt to offer travel allowance incentive to employees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To encourage greater use of Delhi Metro and DTC buses, the Delhi government is offering an incentive to its employees on travel allowance if they use the common mobility card. The initiative comes as part of the Delhi Government's efforts to promote public transport amid concerns over fuel conservation linked to the West Asia crisis.

“In view of considering the need for prudent utilisation of fuel resources arising due to the ongoing situation and further, in continuation of the government's efforts towards conservation of fuel, reduction in pollution and promotion of public transport, it has been decided to introduce an incentive scheme for the employees of GNCTD (Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi) utilising metro and public transport services for commuting purposes,” an order said.

According to the order of the finance department, Scheme shall come into effect from the date of issue of this Office Memorandum. Scheme is optional for all employees of GNCTD. Officers/officials may inform their Head of Department, if they are not willing to opt this scheme and, in this case, they will be entitled



for their usual Transport Allowance, without any incentive. If an employee utilises at least 25% of their monthly Transport Allowance, excluding Dearness Allowance (DA), towards the purchase/recharge of a valid Common Mobility Card of DTC, the employee shall be eligible for an incentive @ 10% of admissible Transport Allowance (excluding DA).

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last month launched the 90-day ‘Mera Bharat, Mera Yogan’ fuel-saving campaign, stipulating two-day work-from-home for all Delhi government employees and the use of public transport.

Last month, the DTC also announced that it will run special buses for Delhi Government employees from their residences to the nearest metro station and then to the Delhi Secretariat.

DDA intensifies drain desilting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has completed nearly 70 per cent of its large-scale desilting work on stormwater drains across the Capital ahead of the monsoon season, with Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu directing officials to finish the remaining work by June 15.

According to the DDA, desilting operations are being carried out in mission mode in Narela and Dwarka to improve rainwater drainage, reduce waterlogging, and prevent traffic disruption during heavy rainfall. Officials said the exercise was launched in advance on the directions of Lieutenant Governor Sandhu, who has been closely monitoring preparedness measures related to monsoon management in Delhi.

The authority is currently cleaning around 69 kilometres of stormwater drains in Narela and 192 kilometres of drains in Dwarka. The work includes the removal of accumulated silt, garbage, weeds, debris, and other blockages that obstruct the natural flow of rainwater during the rainy season.

Officials said the drive aims to strengthen drainage efficiency across major residential and public areas under DDA jurisdiction. The



work is also expected to help reduce flooding on roads, ease traffic congestion, and improve sanitation conditions during the monsoon months.

The Lieutenant Governor reviewed the progress of the desilting campaign and instructed officials to ensure that all pending work is completed before the onset of heavy rainfall. He stressed that monsoon preparedness should remain a priority and directed agencies to maintain strict monitoring of field operations.

According to officials, the desilting campaign is being monitored regularly through inspections by senior DDA officers. Authorities said teams have been deployed to supervise quality standards and ensure that drainage channels remain functional before the monsoon intensifies.

The DDA stated that the operation forms part of a broader effort to improve urban infrastructure and

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, ARUN SEGHAL S/o SHRI CHANDER PARKASH, R/o 17, KIRAN VIHAR, DELHI-110092 do hereby solemnly affirm and inform that my father Shri Chander Parkash Seghal executed a WILL on dated 08.07.2018, and bequeathed the Immovable property and Assets as given below-Immovable Freehold Property bearing No. 17, Situated at KIRAN VIHAR, DELHI-110092 and bequeathed the same in favour of following beneficiaries:1/3rd Share in favour of Brig. Arun Seghal (Elder Son) 1/3rd Share in favour of Mr. Ajay Seghal (Younger Son)1/3rd Share in favour of Mr. Akshay Seghal and Mr. Abhishek Seghal equally Both sons of Brig. Arun Seghal. My father Late Sh. Chander Parkash Seghal expired on 19.07.2025 (Death Certificate No. MCDOLIR-022501260721573367). Now I wish to register the above said WILL after death on the basis of Two marginal Witnesses in the office of Sub-Registrar VIII Geeta Colony (East District) Delhi. I have produced the aforesaid Will before Sub-Registrar VIII Geeta Colony, Delhi for registration.If any person have any objection, claim, litigation in respect of aforesaid WILL then same can be file an objection in Sub-Registrar VIII Geeta Colony East District Delhi and/or before me i.e. Shri Arun Seghal #17, Kiran Vihar, Delhi-110092 within 03 days from today.

For and on behalf of
Lingaya's Society
Registration Number: S-20388
16-A, Central Drive, DLF Farms,
Chattarpur, New Delhi 110074
Date: 17th November, 2025
Place: New Delhi

FORM NO. URC-2
(Pursuant to rule 30 the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014)
BEFORE THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT
REGIONAL DIRECTOR, WESTERN REGION 100, EVEREST, MARINE DRIVE MUMBAI-400002, MAHARASHTRA

In the matter of sub-section 4 of section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 and clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Rule 30 Of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014
AND
In the matter of My Personal Health Record Express (India) Private Limited having its registered office at Regus, Level 4 Dynasty, A Wing, Andheri-Kurla Road, J.B. Nagar, Mumbai, Maharashtra, India, 400059.
..... Applicant
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the Company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Annual General Meeting / Extra ordinary general meeting held on February 12th, 2026 to enable the company to change its Registered office from "State of Maharashtra" to "State of Haryana".
Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change, may deliver either on MCA portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filling investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Regional director Western Region (Maharashtra) Everest Building, 5th Floor, 100, Marine Drive, Mumbai-400002, Maharashtra, India **WITHIN FOURTEEN DAYS** from the date of publication of this notice with a copy of the applicant company at its registered office at the address mentioned below:

/Intentionally Left Blank//
Regd Office: Regus, Level 4 Dynasty, A Wing, Andheri-Kurla Road, J.B. Nagar, Mumbai, Maharashtra, India, 400059, CIN: U72300MH2010PTC209491
mphrx info@mphrx.com www.mphrx.com
Company Registered Address: Regus, Level 4 Dynasty, A Wing, Andheri-Kurla Road, J.B. Nagar, Mumbai, Maharashtra, India, 400059.
Certified to be true

For and on behalf of the Applicant
MY PERSONAL HEALTH RECORD EXPRESS (INDIA) PRIVATE LIMITED
VARUN ANAND
Director DIN: 06571754

PUBLICATION
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
(Area of Jurisdiction- Part of Uttar Pradesh)
600/1, University Road, Near Hanuman Setu Mandir, Lucknow- 226007
DRC NO. 1105/2024
Notice under rule 2 of the second schedule to the Income Tax Act, 1961 read with Section 29 of the Recovery of debt due to Banks and Financial Institutions Act, 1993
ICICI Bank Ltd.
Vs.
Vikas Babbar & Others
To,
1. Vikas Babbar
S/o Sushil Chandra Babbar
R/o House No. 111, 1st Floor Chaman Vihar, Dehradun- 248001. Also at: Flat No. 2001, 19th Floor, Tower-A1, Victory Ace Pkt 2, Plot No. G/ 02, Sec- 143, Noida- 201301, U.P.
2. Shikha Babbar
R/o House No. 111, 1st Floor Chaman, Vihar Dehradun- 248001.
3. Dream Procon Private Limited Corporate Office: D1, Sector-3, Noida, U.P.- 201301. ...Defendants
1. This is to notify you that a sum of Rs. 53,86,515/- (Rs. Fifty Three Lacs Eighty Six Thousand, Five Hundred and Fifteen Only) together with pendent lite and future interest @ 09% per annum with monthly rest from the date of filing the original application, i.e. 29.07.2022 till full realisation is made, jointly and severally, has become due from you as per the Certificate bearing No. 772/2024 dated 29.04.2024 in Original Application No. 1073/2022 passed against you by the D.R.T., Lucknow.
2. You are hereby directed to pay the sum within 15 days of the receipt of this Notice, failing which the recovery shall be made in accordance with the Recovery of Debts Due to Bank and Financial Institution Act, 1993.
3. You are hereby ordered to declare on Affidavit the particulars of the asset on or before 08/07/2026.
4. You are hereby ordered to appear before the undersigned on 08/07/2026 at 10:30 A.M.
In addition to the sum aforesaid, you will also be liable to pay the following costs:-
Application fee Rs. 29,010/-
Counsel fees & Clerkage Rs. NIL/
Publication charges Rs. NIL/
Miscellaneous Expenses Rs. NIL/
Clerical Charges Rs. NIL/
Given under my hand and seal at Lucknow this 06 day of April, 2026.

Recovery Officer-II
Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
(Area of Jurisdiction-Part of Uttar Pradesh)
600/1, University Road, Near Hanuman Setu Mandir, Lucknow- 226007
DRC NO. 772/2024
NOTICE UNDER RULE 2 OF THE SECOND SCHEDULE TO THE INCOME TAX ACT, 1961 READ WITH SECTION 29 OF THE RECOVERY OF DEBT DUE TO BANKS AND FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS ACT, 1993
ICICI BANK LIMITED
Vs.
MOHIT & OTHERS
To,
1. MOHIT S/O SURYA PRAKASH R/O H-804, Princess Park, Sector- 86, Old Faridabad, Faridabad- 121002 Also at- Flat No.2201, Floor-22, Tower-B, Ajnara Le Garden Plot, Sector-16, Greater Noida-201307.
2. ROSHI GULATI W/O MOHIT R/O H-804, Princess Park, Sector- 86, Old Faridabad, Faridabad- 121002
3. AJANARA REALTECH LIMITED Corporate Office At D-247/26, Sector-63, Noida, UP. ...Defendants
1. This is to notify you that a sum of Rs 26,49,691/- (Rs. Twenty-Six Lac Forty-Nine Thousand, Six Hundred and Ninety-One Only) together with pendent lite and future interest @ 09% per annum with monthly rest from the date of filing the original application, i.e. 29.07.2022 till full realisation is made, jointly and severally, has become due from you as per the Certificate bearing No. 772/2024 dated 29.04.2024 in Original Application No. 784/2022 passed against you by the D.R.T., Lucknow.
2. You are hereby directed to pay the sum within 15 days of the receipt of this Notice, failing which the recovery shall be made in accordance with the Recovery of Debts Due to Bank and Financial Institution Act, 1993.
3. You are hereby ordered to declare on Affidavit the particulars of the asset on or before 08/07/2026.
4. You are hereby ordered to appear before the undersigned on 08/07/2026 at 10:30 A.M.
In addition to the sum aforesaid, you will also be liable to pay the following costs:-
Application fee Rs. 29,010/-
Counsel fees & Clerkage Rs. NIL/
Publication charges Rs. NIL/
Miscellaneous Expenses Rs. NIL/
Clerical Charges Rs. NIL/
Given under my hand and seal at Lucknow this 06 day of April, 2026.

Recovery Officer-II
Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

FORM NO. 1
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
600/1, University Road, Hanuman Setu Mandir, Lucknow
(Area of Jurisdiction, Part of Uttar Pradesh)
DRC NO. 1307 OF 2024
Notice under Rule-2 of the IIInd Schedule of Income Tax Act, 1961 read with Section 29 of the Recovery of Debts and Bankruptcy Act, 1993
ICICI BANK LIMITED
Vs.
DEEPAK RANA AND ANOTHER
To,
J.D. No. 1. Deepak Rana S/o- Sri Prithvi Rana, R/o-House No. 1433, Maruti Kunj, Sonha Road, Near DRS School, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122010
J.D. No. 2. Neelam Kumari Rajput W/o Sri Deepak Rana R/o-House No. 1433, Maruti Kunj, Sonha Road, Near DRS School Gurgaon, Haryana- 122010
J.D. No. 3. M/s Antriksh Engineers Private Limited, Registered Office- At 34/C, Sector-8, Rohini, New Delhi- 110085- Through its Authorized Signatory
1. This is to notify a sum of Rs. 36,04,547/- (Rupees Thirty Six Lakh Four Thousand Five Hundred Forty Seven Only) together with interest @ 12% per annum with monthly rest from the date of filing of the original application i.e. 15.12.2022 till the loan is fully liquidated jointly and severally in its realization with costs from the certificate debtors 1 to 3, as per Certificate Bearing No. 1307 of 2024 dated 19.12.2023 in O.A. No. 1234 of 2022 passed against you by Hon'ble DRT, Lucknow.
B. You are hereby directed to pay the sum within 15 days of receipt of this notice, failing which the recovery shall be made in accordance with the Recovery of Debts and Bankruptcy Act, 1993.
C. You are hereby ordered that declare on affidavit the particulars of assets on or before 01/10/2026.
D. You are hereby ordered to appear before the undersigned on 01/10/2026 at 11:00 A.M.
E. In addition to the sum aforesaid, you will also be liable to pay the following:-
Application fees Rs. 41,000/-
Advocate fees Rs. NIL/
Publication charges Rs. NIL/
Miscellaneous expenses Rs. NIL/
Clerkage Rs. NIL/
Total Rs. 41,000/-
Given under my hand and seal at Lucknow on 15.05.2026.

Recovery Officer-I
Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is hereby informed to the General Public, Banks, Financial Institutions, Money Lenders, business entities and all concerned persons on behalf of my client Mrs. Diksha Agarwal w/o Sh. Gautam Ghosh R/o H.No. D-3/58, Second Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089 that her husband Mr. Gautam Ghosh s/o Sh. Neelam Ghosh has been raising loans, entering into financial transactions & unlawful activities without her knowledge, consent or authorization. My client hereby notified that she shall not be responsible or liable in any manner whatsoever for any loan, debt, liability, guarantee, mortgage, financial commitment, account transactions or any other unauthorised transactions undertaken by her husband in his individual capacity. Any Person, institution or entity dealing with him shall do so at its own risk, cost & consequences. If anyone deals with him, he/she may do so at their own risk, cost & consequences. My client shall not be responsible to anybody for any of the acts, deeds & misdeeds of her above named husband. Besides the liability arising out of any such transaction shall be binding upon my client or her assets, movable or immovable.
CHIRANJEEV CHAUHAN (Advocate)
C.No.- 371, Western Wing, The Hazrat Gurdwara, Delhi-54

FORM NO. 5
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
600/1, University Road, Hanuman Setu Mandir, Lucknow- 226007
(Area of Jurisdiction-Part of Uttar Pradesh)
Summons for filing reply & Appearance by Publication
O.A. No. 1489/2025
Dated: 23.04.2026
[Summons to defendants under Section 19(3) of the Recovery of Debts due to Banks and Financial Institution Act, 1993 read with Rules 12 and 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure) Rules, 1993]
Original Application No. 1488 of 2025
ICICI Bank Limited ...Applicant
Versus
Motowise Logistics India Pvt. Ltd. & Others ...Defendants
To,
1. Motowise Logistics India Pvt. Ltd. (Through its Director Mayank Suri) having its address at: 1st Floor Plot No. 1, 103, KS Complex, Sec-1, Sun Valley International School, U.P.- 201019
2. Mayank Suri S/o Anil Kumar Suri (Adult), R/o Plot No. 77, 2nd Floor, PKT-1, Ramprastha, Greens Gate No. 4, Vaishali IE Sohlabad, Ghaziabad, U.P.- 201010
3. Motowise Propriety (Through its Proprietor Mayank Suri) having its address at: 1st Floor 11/103, KS Complex Plot No. 1, Sec-1, Vaishali, Ghaziabad- 201010, U.P.
In the above noted Original application you are required to file reply in Paper Book form in two sets along with documents and affidavits (if any) personally or through your duly authorised agent or legal practitioner in this Tribunal, after serving copy of the same on the applicant or his counsel/duly authorised agent after publication of the summons and thereafter to appear before the Tribunal on 21.08.2026 at 10:30 A.M. failing which the application shall be heard and decided in your absence.

Registrar
Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

Public Notice
It is for general information that I Salony Bhaskaran Daughter of Lt Col S P Bhaskaran residing at B-201, Brindavan Garden Apartment, Plot -10, Sector - 12 New Delhi - 110078 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Saloni Natasha in my Father's Pension Scheme Document Dated 10th December 1993 with PPO No. 101199400365 The actual name of mine Salony Bhaskaran respectively, which may be amended accordingly. It is certified that I have complied with other legal requirements in this connection.

FORM NO. 5
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL
600/1, University Road, Hanuman Setu Mandir, Lucknow
SUMMONS FOR FILING REPLY & APPEARANCE BY PUBLICATION
Dated: 14/05/2026
Summons to defendants under Section 19(3) of the Recovery of Debts due to Banks and Financial Institution Act, 1993 read with Rules 12 and 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure) Rules, 1993
Original Application No. 1334 of 2025
ICICI Bank Ltd.
Vs/
JNB Trading Company & Others
To,
1. JNB Trading Company
2. Through its Proprietor- Mr. Pushpendra Nagar
Address- Imallyaka, Post Office- Kasana, Greater Noida, 5 Gautam Bhudh Nagar- 201301. ...Defendant No. 01
2. Pushpendra Nagar S/o Mr. Jagan Singh R/o Imallyaka, Post Office- Kasana, Greater Noida, Gautam Bhudh Nagar- 201301. ...Defendant No. 2
3. Geeta, W/o Mr. Pushpendra Singh R/o Imallyaka, Post Office- Kasana, Greater Noida, Gautam Bhudh Nagar- 201301. ...Defendant No. 3
In the above noted Original application you are required to file reply in Paper Book form in two sets along with documents and affidavits (if any) personally or through your duly authorised agent or legal practitioner in this Tribunal, after serving copy of the same on the applicant or his counsel/ duly authorised agent after publication of the summons and thereafter to appear before the Tribunal on 28/08/2026 at 10:30 A.M. failing which the application shall be heard and decided in your absence.

Registrar
Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client (SME's India Credit Co. Ltd.) that Mrs. Sahi san is claiming to be the owner of Residential Plot No. 23-A, measuring 90 sq.yds, out of Kharsa No.39/95, Khatouni No. 142, situated at Nehru Garden, Village- Khora Colony, District-Ghaziabad, U.P. vide a Gift Deed dt.27.05.2008 executed by Mr. Tahir ulais Mr.Tahir Hussain in favour of his wife Mrs. Rahsan, duly regd. with Document No. 6471, Volume No.13260, Pages-357-368, dt. 27.05.2008 (SRO-Ghaziabad-V). Mr. Tahir Hussain was the GPA holder of Mr. Brj Anand Prasad vide a Regd. GPA dt.20.10.1994. All persons are hereby informed that above owner (through M/s. Almix Enterprises) wants to mortgage the said property & is obtaining a loan from our client (SME's India Credit Co. Ltd.) against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owners over the said property, its mortgage/ litigation & any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, Ind Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N.Delhi-15
Ph: 011-43112527-28
legal@kmalga.com

PUBLIC NOTICE
To be known to all that, my client Mr. Sanjeev Vijay, son of Mr. P.B. Vijay is the owner of Flat No. 193, Ground Floor, Sector-A, Pocket-C, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070 and intended to sell the same to Mr. Jyotie Sharma, wife of Shri Priyank Sharma.
Original DDA Allotment cum Demand Letter vide File No. 942686/SFSC/III dated 13.04.2026 in Possession Slip, NOC for electric and water connection issued by DDA in favour of Mr. Sanjeev Vijay in respect of the above said flat have been lost/misplaced by my client. NCR/IR LR No. 230687/2026 dated 13/04/2026 to this effect have been lodged. If any person including banks, financial institutions or any other person representing, organization, company firm or government authority has any right, title, claim or interest whatsoever into or upon above referred flat is hereby make the same known in writing, with documentary evidence to the undersign within 5 days. In the event of no response to this notice, the purpose of this notice shall be completed.
MANSOOR ANSARI (Advocate)
B-43A, Kalkaji, New Delhi-19 Mob. 97111 77423

No demolition of existing homes in O-Zone colonies: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday assured residents living in colonies located in the O-Zone area that no demolition action would be taken against existing constructions. Chairing a high-level meeting at the Delhi Secretariat, the Chief Minister said the Delhi Development Authority had already been informed of the Delhi High Court's position that action should apply only to new or ongoing construction activities in the area.

The meeting was attended by North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari, South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Trans Yamuna Area Development Board Chairman and MLA Arvinder Singh Lovely, Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khairwar, senior DDA officials, and representatives from other departments.

Officials informed the meeting that nearly 91 unauthorised colonies and around 12 old villages fall within the O-Zone area. An estimated 15 lakh people live in these settlements. Concerns among residents have grown in recent weeks after authorities installed signboards warning against illegal construction and violations in the area.

Public representatives told the



Chief Minister that, after reviewing court orders and official records, they found that completed structures were not under threat. According to them, the High Court's observations were directed only at preventing fresh or ongoing construction in the Yamuna floodplain region.

The representatives also raised objections to the wording displayed on notice boards installed by authorities in O-Zone colonies. They said the language used on these boards was creating panic among residents and leading many families to fear possible demolition of their homes.

They further claimed that some groups were using the prevailing confusion to intimidate residents

while simultaneously carrying out illegal construction activities themselves. Public representatives demanded stricter monitoring to stop fresh encroachments and unauthorised building activity in the floodplain area. At the same time, they said they supported a complete ban on any new construction in the O-Zone region in order to protect the Yamuna floodplain and prevent further environmental damage.

During the meeting, the Chief Minister sought detailed clarification from senior DDA officials regarding the High Court's directions and the present status of enforcement measures in the area.

The Chief Minister said the court

had not issued observations against constructions that had already been completed.

Instead, she said, the concern was related to ongoing construction activity and future violations in environmentally sensitive zones. She stated that since the High Court had already communicated its position to the DDA, the authority should ensure that its actions remain fully in line with those directions. She also instructed officials to prevent unnecessary fear among residents.

The Chief Minister directed DDA authorities to revise the wording used on the signboards installed across O-Zone colonies. She said the language should clearly reflect the High Court's observations so that people are not misled or subjected to avoidable anxiety. She also announced that she would soon meet Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal, along with public representatives, to discuss issues related to O-Zone colonies and the concerns of residents living there.

The issue of O-Zone settlements has remained sensitive for years because of restrictions linked to the Yamuna floodplain and environmental regulations. Residents have repeatedly sought clarity regarding the legal status of their homes and future civic development in these colonies.

92 colonies to get relief from O-Zone tag: BJP MPs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP MPs Manoj Tiwari and Ramvir Singh Bidhuri on Tuesday said the process has begun to rectify an error that placed 92 colonies and dozens of villages in the O-Zone, the eco-sensitive areas along the River Yamuna, bringing relief to people there.

Construction is strictly prohibited in the O-Zone, which covers the environmentally sensitive Yamuna riverbed and floodplain. Bidhuri, the South Delhi MP, assured that no old settlements will be touched in these colonies and villages erroneously placed in the O-Zone, though no new construction will be allowed there.

Bidhuri thanked Chief Minister Rekha Gupta for convening the high-level meeting, noting that nearly 1.5 million residents living in the O-Zone have been deeply concerned following the High Court's order. He said that the situation has become much clearer after today's meeting.

He further stated that the Chief Minister was informed during the meeting that these colonies had already been regularised on March 24, 2008, at a time when they fell under the F-Zone rather



than the O-Zone. However, on August 10, 2010, the Congress Governments at the Centre and in Delhi placed these areas within the Yamuna O-Zone.

Following public objections, the DDA issued a draft notification on September 28, 2013, proposing to shift these colonies back from the O-Zone to the F-Zone. The draft notification had received approval from the then Union Urban Development Minister, but the final notification has still not been issued. He added that both the Government's Principal Committee and the DDA had already completed physical demarcation, while an expert

committee had concluded that these villages and colonies do not adversely affect the river's flow or ecological quality.

However, after the intervention of an NGO, the National Green Tribunal later stayed the move, and the issue has remained unresolved since then, he added.

Former Delhi BJP President and North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari stated that the process to rectify the erroneous inclusion of certain areas in the O-Zone has already begun. He thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi for removing the stigma of "unauthorised" from Delhi's unauthorised colonies.

LG, CM Rekha review heat wave action plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday reviewed the implementation of the Heatwave Action Plan 2026 at a Delhi Disaster Management Authority meeting and directed departments to significantly increase the number of mobile relief vans and cooling centres, pointing out that one mobile relief van per district is insufficient for a city of Delhi's size, and placing special focus on areas with high concentrations of vendors, labourers, and homeless persons.

The LG Sandhu emphasised that the massive heat-relief effort must continue as a fully coordinated operation spanning the Revenue Department, Transport & DTC, DDA, Labour Department and other agencies.

The meeting was attended by Ministers Ashish Sood



and Parvesh Verma, the Chief Secretary, Commissioner of Police, MCD Commissioner, NDMC Chairperson, Vice Chairman of DDA, and heads of all concerned departments.

The LG underlined that this was the first time, following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call last year, that Delhi had deployed a substantial and coordinated heat wave relief plan spanning multiple departments across all 13 districts. He also highlighted Modi's direction

to address the Urban Heat Island effect through long-term urban cooling solutions to create lasting relief for the Capital.

Both the LG and the CM directed that mobile relief vans and cooling centres be increased in number and deployed specifically in areas with a heavier presence of vendors, labourers, homeless persons, and people on the streets for livelihood reasons, as well as in markets with heavy footfall. The Chief Minister directed

officials to ensure continuity of service during shift changes at cooling centres so that operations remain uninterrupted. She also instructed that water pots, coolers, and containers must be refilled immediately at all times so that no citizen finds them empty.

The LG directed all agencies to function as a single team without jurisdictional divisions, emphasising that citizens are concerned only with actual work on the ground and not with which department or authority is responsible for any particular area.

The meeting reviewed the performance figures achieved so far. Mobile Heat Relief Units have served 4,73,358 beneficiaries, distributing 1,86,413 litres of water, 2,44,002 ORS packets, 67,593 cotton towels, and 49,666 protective caps across the city.

Among the fixed cooling zones, the North East site at GTB Hospital Gate 3 has served 62,900 people and

distributed 47,975 litres of water. The Old Delhi site at Jama Masjid Metro Gate 3 has served 35,470 people with 30,800 litres of water. The Central North zone at Shalimar Chowk has served 20,100 citizens with 7,066 litres of water. The South East site at Kalkaji and Lotus Temple has provided 3,000 litres of water to 7,900 people.

At public transit points, free water camps have been set up daily at 500 bus stops from 10 am to 5 pm, with active water coolers and 10,000 ORS packets kept ready at major Inter-State Bus Terminals.

The Delhi Jal Board has deployed 940 water tankers, making 6,359 trips daily to serve water-scarce neighbourhoods. Major hospitals have been placed on high alert with dedicated ten-bed heat wave wards equipped with cooling infrastructure, with a maximum patient waiting time of 15 minutes.

Senior IAS officer Sajjan Singh Yadav appointed as CEO of DJB

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior IAS officer Dr Sajjan Singh Yadav, has been appointed as Additional Chief Secretary and Chief Executive Officer of Delhi Jal Board (DJB) with additional charge of Additional Chief Secretary (Industries) and Chairperson (DSIIDC). He has replaced D Vaidya from the additional charge of Principal Secretary (Industries) and Chairperson (DSIIDC). According to the order issued by the services department, Yadav will replace former CEO Kaushal Raj Sharma, a 2006 AGMUT cadre officer, in the Jal Board, who was posted as Secretary to the Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu in April this year.

Yadav, a 1995-batch officer of the Arunachal Pradesh, Goa, Mizoram and Union Territory (AGMUT) cadre, has held several roles in the national



Capital in the past, including that of DJB CEO. He had served as the CEO of DJB in 2015.

Yadav was recently empanelled to hold the post of Secretary/Equivalent in the Government of India and was elevated as Special Secretary, Department of Expenditure in the Ministry of Finance on March 31, 2026. He

was repatriated to his home cadre on June 3, 2026.

On April 18, senior IAS officer Kaushal Raj Sharma, who was working as Chief Executive Officer of DJB, was appointed as secretary to Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, and the post has been vacant since then.

Sharma, earlier served as DM in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's parliamentary constituency, Varanasi. His appointment last year was seen as a significant step to bring much-needed improvements to the water and sewer management infrastructure of the national Capital, but he was transferred to the LG Secretariat after a few months.

Railway veteran Rakesh Kumar Sharma earns Grand Master honour

GYANVI SHARMA
■ New Delhi

Retired New Delhi Railway Station Manager Rakesh Kumar Sharma has earned national and international recognition after successfully resolving 1,975 lost-and-found cases and safely returning passengers' belongings worth more than Rs 5 crore during and after his railway service, creating a remarkable record in Indian Railways.

For his contribution to passenger service, he has been honoured with the prestigious 'Grand Master' title, and his name has been recorded in both the India Book of Records and the Asia Book of Records.

According to railway officials, Sharma resolved 1,963 lost-and-found cases between 6 April 2016 and 31 January 2026 while serving with Indian Railways. Even after retirement, he continued assisting passengers and resolved 12 additional cases, taking the total to 1,975.

The recovered belongings included mobile phones, laptops, passports, foreign currency, jewellery, cash, important documents and several other valuable items. Officials said the estimated value of the recovered articles exceeded ₹5 crore.

A notable aspect of the achievement was the safe return of belongings belonging to 42 foreign nationals. Railway authorities said international passengers appreciated the transparency, promptness and service standards maintained during the recovery and return process, strengthening the image of Indian Railways globally.

He came to New Delhi in 1998 and became known for assisting passengers facing difficulties due to lost or stolen belongings during railway journeys. Railway officials said he often extended help beyond official responsibilities and, in several instances, personally purchased railway tickets from his own pocket for stranded passengers to help them continue their journey or return home safely.

Senior railway officers stated that Sharma's work inspired railway employees and contractual staff members to treat lost-and-found cases not merely as administrative work but as an important public responsibility, contributing towards making Indian Railways more responsive, compassionate and passenger-centric.



In addition to the India Book of Records and Asia Book of Records recognition, Sharma has received several prestigious honours during his railway career including the Vishisht Rail Seva Award (2023) presented by the Railway Minister, a cash award from the Minister of State for Railways, recognition from Railway Board Member Traffic and Railway Board Member Staff, multiple honours from GM/Northern Railway, appreciation from AGM/Northern Railway and PCOM/Northern Railway, and several awards and commendation certificates from DRM/Delhi Division and the Station Director of New Delhi Railway Station.

He has also been honoured with the National Gaurav Honour (2025), Samaj Ratna Award, Asia Book of Records recognition and the 'Grand Master' title and many more.

Senior Delhi Division and New Delhi Railway Station officials, including Divisional Railway Manager Pushpesh Raman Tripathi, Senior Divisional Commercial Manager Lakshmi Kant Bansal, Senior Divisional Operations Manager Vikas Vats, Senior Divisional Operations Manager/Coaching Rehan Raza Rizvi, Senior Divisional Finance Manager Neha Prakash, Station Director Sagar Chahar, Sanjay Jain, PK Shukla, Lokesh Kumar, Narendra Mahour and Narayan Sharma, congratulated Rakesh Kumar Sharma on the achievement and described it as a proud moment for Indian Railways.



New Okhla Industrial Development Authority

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida G.B Nagar, (U.P.)
Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender are invited from firms / contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened / downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on NOIDA Authority's official website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes / amendments & corrigendum etc.

(A)

- 23/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Construction of Fountain in Sector-93B Noida. Cost Rs. 48.01 Lacs.
- 19/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27**, Annual Operation & Maintenance of UFA Musical Fountain System, Water Screen Laser, Video Projector etc. (Multimedia Show) at YRF Park Sector-15A, Noida. Cost Rs. 60.71 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: - 23.06.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: - 24.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

(B)

- 04/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Annual Maintenance of Street Light, High Mast Light & Repair of Transformer in Sector-101, 106, Hosiery Complex, Main Road form Metro to kent Ro, DSC road form NSEZ to Kuleshra road, Main Road from DSC to Samsung and Phase-II, Noida. Cost Rs. 69.73 Lacs.
- 05/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Providing Lighting arrangement in Water tank T-Point to Advent Road Sector-142, Noida. Cost Rs. 48.53 Lacs.
- 07/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Providing Lighting arrangement in Front of Shanti Niketan Road Sector-143 B, Noida. Cost Rs. 43.13 Lacs.
- 08/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Providing Lighting arrangement in 5% Abadi plot in Sector-141, Noida. Cost Rs. 33.14 Lacs.
- 10/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Providing Decorative pole in sector-93B, Noida. Cost Rs. 43.71 Lacs.
- 11/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Providing Lighting Arrangement in Village-Nalgarha, Noida. Cost Rs. 97.58 Lacs.
- 12/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27**, External Electrification work & Providing Street light Work in Newly Developed 5% Abadi Plots Sector-144 Noida. Cost Rs. 70.00 Lacs.
- 04/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27**, S/I/T/C of 02 Nos CNG Furnace in CNG Crimination at Antim Niwas Sector-94, Noida. Cost Rs. 99.84 Lacs.
- 05/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27**, Noida Traffic Cell (Supply of Ertiga/Bolero, Hydra Crane and Ambulance on Hire Basis at Noida-Greater Noida Expressway to the help of Traffic Police Inview to Traffic and Public security) Noida. Cost Rs. 68.75 Lacs.
- 15/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27**, Internal Electrification of SPCA Building (Animal Shelter) Newly Constructed by WC-9, Sector-94, Noida. Cost Rs. 97.88 Lacs.
- 33/GM(E/M)/Sr.M(E/M)-IV72025-26**, Annual Operation and maintenance of 3-D projection mapping of Gautam buddha statue at Noida gate sec 14 A Noida. Cost Rs. 31.61 Lacs.

Which can be uploaded by date: - 16.06.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: - 17.06.2026 at 11.00 AM.

General Manager (E&M)
NOIDA

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA



GAIL Gas Limited

[A wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited]

NOTICE FOR HIRING OF CONTRACTORS FOR CGD PROJECT

GAIL Gas Limited intends to engage experienced contractors/agencies through an On-the-Spot Walk-In Selection Process for execution of MDPE Laying Works in the Dhanbad-Giridih (Jharkhand) Geographical Area (GA).

The Walk-In Selection Process shall be conducted as per the schedule given below:

Geographical Area (GA)	Scope of Work	Date & Time
Dhanbad-Giridih (Jharkhand)	MDPE Laying Works	11.06.2026, 12.06.2026 & 15.06.2026, 10:00 AM to 5:30 PM

Venue:
Conference Room, 3rd Floor, GAIL Gas Limited, GAIL Jubilee Tower, B-35/36, Sector-1, Noida - 201301 (U.P.)

However, interested bidders shall also have the option to submit their documents at:

3rd Floor, Crossroads Building, Above Westside, Dhanbad-Govindpur Road, Near Ozone Galleria Mall, Saraidihela, Dhanbad - 828127 (Jharkhand).

Eligibility & Documents Required

Interested bidders are required to submit relevant supporting documents, including but not limited to, Work Experience Certificates/Completion Certificate, Registration Certificate, PAN Card, PF Registration Certificate (wherever applicable), ESI Registration Certificate (wherever applicable, Details of available manpower, machinery, and equipment required for execution of the works.

The bidder shall submit a copy of at least one work order awarded during the last seven (07) years as proof of experience in execution of PNG connection/pipeline-related works in the gas, water supply, drainage, telecom, or any other utility sector for GAIL/GAIL Gas and/or their Group Companies, or for any other company.

The Walk-In Selection Process is scheduled to be conducted over the above-mentioned three days. However, the process may be concluded earlier if the required number of eligible vendors are identified and selected before the scheduled closing date.

Detailed Terms & Conditions Detailed Terms & Conditions are available at:
<https://gailgas.com/eoi/expression-interest>

Contact Persons:

- Mr. Arnab Samanta - arnab.samanta@gail.co.in | Mob.: 7055515333
- Mr. Sandeep Sharma - sandeep.sharma1@gail.co.in | Mob.: 9599477955
- Mr. Saksham Gupta - saksham.gupta@gail.co.in | Mob.: 9988092246
- Mr. Anil Kumar - anil.kumar1@gail.co.in | Mob.: 7763807378

Important Note: Any corrigendum, addendum, clarification, or amendment to this Notice shall be hosted only on the GAIL Gas website. Interested bidders are therefore advised to visit the website regularly for updates.

Corporate Identification Number : U40200DL20080H78614

80-yr-old dies days after hotel blaze kills his kin

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

The devastating Malviya Nagar hotel fire that wiped out eight members of a Gurugram-based family last week claimed its ninth victim on Tuesday with the death of 80-year-old Radhe Shyam Aggarwal, the family patriarch whose illness had brought his relatives to Delhi and inadvertently placed them in the path of tragedy. Aggarwal, who had been undergoing treatment for a lung-related ailment at Max Hospital in Saket, died days after the June 4 blaze at the Flourish Inn bed-and-breakfast hotel. With his death, the entire Aggarwal family has been wiped out, leaving no immediate survivors.

Family members who perished in the fire were identified as Vivek Aggarwal, his wife Tarjani, their daughters Jeevisha and Waria, Vivek's mother Premlata, his uncle Ashok Goyal, aunt Kamala Goyal and another relative, Jhimri Aggarwal.

According to relatives, the family had checked into the hotel only a day or two before the fire to avoid the daily commute between Gurugram and Delhi while attending to Radhe Shyam Aggarwal's medical needs. "They had taken two rooms in the last one or two days to beat the Gurugram-Delhi distance," a relative had told *The Pioneer*.

Sources told *The Pioneer* that the family was allegedly in the hotel's basement area when the fire broke



Radhe Shyam Aggarwal

out and rapidly engulfed the building, trapping occupants amid dense smoke.

In a particularly poignant detail, Jeevisha, a student in Bengaluru, had been called to Delhi just a day before the tragedy so she could meet her ailing grandfather.

Sources said Radhe Shyam Aggarwal remained admitted to the Saket hospital after the fire and was largely unaware of the catastrophe that had unfolded barely a few hundred metres away, *NDTV* reported. He reportedly kept asking about the absence of his family members, not knowing they had all died in the blaze.

The scale of the tragedy became evident during a

visit to the Hauz Rani neighbourhood a day after the fire, where Vivek Aggarwal's white Audi remained parked outside the charred hotel. Looking at the vehicle, a resident remarked sorrowfully, "Who will drive this now? *Jiski thi vo toh chalogaya.*"

The fire, one of Delhi's deadliest hotel blazes in recent years, has sparked questions over fire safety compliance and emergency preparedness in commercial establishments across the Capital.

Authorities are continuing their investigation into the circumstances that led to the tragedy. So far, the fire has claimed 22 lives, including foreign nationals.

Israel plans Shivaji Maharaj statue to strengthen India ties

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

Israel is planning to install a statue of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj in one of its major cities as part of efforts to deepen cultural and historical ties with India, Israeli Consul General to Mumbai Yaniv Revach announced on the Maratha king's Coronation Day.

Speaking on the occasion, Revach revealed that the proposal has already been discussed with Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who has expressed support for the initiative.

"We approached Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis to seek his advice regarding the partnership. He immediately gave us his blessing and assured us of all the support we may need," Revach said. According to the diplo-

mat, the proposed statue is envisioned as a long-term project and a gesture of goodwill from Israel towards the people of India. He explained that the idea emerged after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's historic visit to Jerusalem, which inspired both nations to explore new avenues for strengthening bilateral relations.

"Following Prime Minister Modi's visit to Jerusalem, we decided to deepen the ties between Israel and India in different aspects. One of those aspects was the history of our two nations," Revach told. Rather than undertaking a large project in India, Israel decided to honor the legacy of Shivaji Maharaj by installing a statue in Israel, he said.

Revach highlighted similarities between the historical experiences of India and



Israel, particularly the struggles both nations faced in securing and preserving their homelands.

"When I came to India a few months ago, I learned about the similarities between India and Israel. Both nations had to fight for their land and identity over many decades," he said.

The consul general noted that Israel has been making

MCD cracks down on illegal buildings, fire safety violations after inspections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Tuesday demolished 16 properties and sealed 29 establishments as part of its ongoing crackdown against illegal constructions and buildings over bye-law violations.

The civic body also issued show-cause notices to 21 unauthorised constructions, 57 sealing show-cause notices, and 22 demolition orders during the day. According to the Revenue Department's daily inspection report, authorities inspected 452 sites across

Delhi between June 5 and June 9. On June 9 alone, inspections were carried out in multiple districts, including West, South, North East, South West, East, and Central Delhi. Action taken included show cause notices, restraining orders, sealing of buildings, demolitions, and eviction notices.

The West district recorded the highest number of inspections with 80 sites visited, followed by South district with 65 and North district with 45. In the South district, officials issued four show cause notices, sealed one property, and initiated demolition action at another site.

Inspection reports from Patel Nagar in the Central district identified several violations in hotels and commercial establishments. At Deventure Hotel in West Patel Nagar, officials found missing fire safety display boards, unauthorised rooms built on top floor beyond sanctioned plan.

A show-cause notice was issued. At Hotel Dev Palace in the same area, authorities found that the building had 20 rooms despite approval for only 18 rooms. Officials also reported malfunctioning fire alarms, absence of emergency signage, and missing public address systems.

PM speaks with Amir of Kuwait on West Asia

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday spoke with the Amir of Kuwait, His Highness Sheikh Meshal Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al-Sabah, as tensions continue to rise in West Asia.

According to a statement issued by the Ministry of External Affairs, the two leaders "exchanged views on the evolving security situation in West Asia."

The MEA said the Prime Minister "expressed deep concern over the escalation of tensions" and reaffirmed India's "strong condemnation of attacks on Kuwait's sovereignty and

territorial integrity."

During the conversation, Modi also reiterated India's longstanding position that the crisis should be resolved through diplomatic means. The statement said he "reiterated the call for de-escalation, dialogue and diplomacy for earliest restoration of peace and stability."

The Prime Minister also thanked the Kuwaiti leadership for its support to the Indian community in the Gulf nation. According to the MEA, Modi "thanked His Highness the Amir for his personal attention to the continued well-being and the safety of the large Indian community in Kuwait."

NDA hunts majority as Opposition splinters

With the fractured TMC likely to come on board with NDA, the tally will cross the 300 mark. Sources said the Government is also taking advantage of fissures in the Congress-DMK and that talks are underway to secure conditional support from MK Stalin's party, which has 22 Lok Sabha MPs. The DMK recently lost the Tamil Nadu polls, which it fought with its oldest ally, Congress. The latter joined hands with Vijay-led TVK post polls to the government in the State last month.

The NDA is also nearing a two-thirds majority in the Rajya Sabha, and the June 18 biennial elections would further add to its tally, which is 150 plus currently. While seven of the 10 MPs of the AAP in Rajya Sabha have already joined the BJP, TMC has 13 MPs in Rajya Sabha and Sukhendu Sekhar Roy has already resigned, who is likely to make it in the upper house again, representing the BJP.

Further, if their leadership decides to extend conditional support to NDA at the Centre and in Parliament, then the eight DMK MPs in the Rajya Sabha could also extend their support. The threshold for a two-thirds majority in the Upper House is 164.

BJP, Congress clash over RS nominations

Congress questioned the role of Election Commission which gave an audience to BJP backed candidate Nathwani while immediately rejecting Natarajan's candidature. Congress has sought time from the poll watchdog to protest on Wednesday.

The Congress MLAs of Madhya Pradesh , who had been waiting to take a flight to Bengaluru, meanwhile, were called back when Natarajan's nomination was rejected. Sources said the flight was recalled from the runway.

The development came after BJP leaders lodged a formal objection before the Returning Officer, seeking cancellation of Natarajan's candidature. The BJP alleged that the Congress leader had failed to disclose details of a pending court case in Telangana in her election affidavit, a mandatory document that candidates are required to submit while filing nominations. The objection was raised by BJP candidate Mahesh Kewat, who is contesting the third Rajya Sabha seat.

Congress's attempts to protest against the Returning officer's move on late Monday evening fell flat when a delegation led by senior party leader KC Venugopal reached the poll office. Sources said that most officials at Commission had left after 6 pm. Though Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was in the office, the Congress had not sought an appointment, sources said.

Natarajan alleged that the BJP is "muzzling democracy and the Constitution," saying that what was earlier limited to "vote theft" has now become "seat theft." She said, "When the number of members was not adequate, and the BJP fielded third candidate, it all started from there, and we started to understand that they are doing the politics of muzzling the democracy, constitution."

A high drama ensued at the Election Commission office late in the night, when top Congress leaders rushed there to hand over a petition against the rejection, but were denied entry. The security refused the Congress leaders, including Jairam Ramesh, to enter the EC office,

saying they had not taken permission from the poll body. Congress leaders K C Venugopal, Sachin Pilot, Bhupesh Baghel and Ramesh staged a dharna outside the EC office.

Meanwhile, Madhya Pradesh chief minister Mohan Yadav hailed the decision and called on the Congress party to "introspect."

PM reviews 12 years in office

Prime Minister of Papua New Guinea, James Marape, in a personal video message, described Prime Minister Modi as "a role model and an example of leadership". He also stated – "Lifting over 200 million people out of poverty to good life today is an amazing feat."

Marape expressed Papua New Guinea's warm friendship and its desire to further consolidate bilateral ties. Prime Minister of Trinidad and Tobago Kamla Persad-Bissessar also congratulated Modi on this occasion, noting that "under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, India has evolved as a leading voice on global matters."

All constituents of the ruling NDA besides the top leadership of the BJP, including Prime Minister Modi, are expected to attend the crucial meeting. Modi becomes the longest continuously serving elected prime minister of India, breaking the record of the first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru.

A resolution hailing Prime Minister Modi for this feat is likely to be adopted at the meeting of the NDA partners, sources said. On June 10, Modi will cross the record of Nehru's 4,399 days in power as an elected PM following the 1952 general elections. Nehru's stint from 1947 to 1952 was as head of an interim government as elections were not held till 1952.

Former prime minister Indira Gandhi had a tenure of 14 years, more than that of Modi, but her prime ministership was not uninterrupted. By surpassing Nehru's 4,399-day record, Modi becomes the longest continuously serving elected prime minister of India, the sources said. On May 26, 2014, Modi took charge as India's prime minister with a landslide victory. He got re-elected with a bigger mandate in 2019 and his second term began on May 30 of the same year. His third consecutive term started on June 9, 2024.

The NDA meeting, to be held at Bharat Mandapam, will be attended by chief ministers and deputy chief ministers of all 22 NDA governed states and Union Territories besides the leaders of all alliance constituents.

Modi breaks Nehru record

"This milestone is a testament not only to your years in office, but also to the trust and confidence that the people of the world's largest democracy have repeatedly placed in your leadership." The message from the Sri Lankan President said. The President also highlighted India's remarkable economic and social transformation and noted that Prime Minister Modi's vision has inspired many beyond India's borders, including Sri Lanka. 2022.

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India deployed nuclear warheads, claims SIPRI

The countries are the US, Russia, the UK, France, China, India, Pakistan, North Korea, and Israel.

The annual report said that 2,100-2,200 of the deployed warheads were kept in a state of high operational alert on ballistic missiles.

"Nearly all of these warheads belonged to Russia or the USA, and, to a lesser extent, France and the UK, but China and India may now occasionally deploy a small number of warheads mounted on missiles during peacetime," it said.

As of January 2026, India had deployed 12 nuclear warheads while China had 34. In the case of China, it was an increase from 24 in 2025.

While the US has deployed 1,770 warheads, Russia has 1,796. France comes third, having deployed 280 warheads. The UK has deployed 120 warheads.

"India is believed to have once again slightly expanded its nuclear arsenal in 2025," said SIPRI. The think tank said India also "continued development of new types of nuclear delivery systems".

India is focused on developing long-range weapons capable of reaching targets throughout China, it said, adding that Pakistan, too, was in the focus of military developments.

On its part, Pakistan was accumulating fissile material in 2025, indicating that it might expand its nuclear arsenal in the coming decade, according to SIPRI analysis.

"The brief armed conflict between India and Pakistan in May 2025 saw India attacking Pakistani air- and missile bases that are likely to have nuclear-related roles, but both sides took steps to avoid escalation," it noted.

The world's top arms-tracking organisation, in its latest report reveals a massive departure from decades of New Delhi's policy where nuclear warheads and delivery systems were

kept in separate storage.

The report claimed this is the first time India's arsenal has been classified as operationally deployed, rather than stockpiled.

The SIPRI report further stated that India's nuclear weapons stockpile saw a small spike in the last year, while deploying a small number of warheads on a ballistic missile submarine (SSBN) and conducting deterrence patrols.

"India was estimated to have a growing stockpile of about 190 nuclear weapons as of January 2026-a small increase from the previous year. These weapons were assigned to a maturing nuclear triad of aircraft, land-based missiles and SSBNs," the SIPRI report said.

"It has long been assumed that India stores its nuclear warheads separate from its deployed launchers during peacetime. However, the country's recent moves towards placing missiles in canisters and conducting sea-based deterrence patrols suggest that India could be shifting in the direction of mating some of its warheads with their launchers in peacetime," the report said.

India follows the "no first use" policy when it comes to nuclear weapons. India commits to not being the first to initiate a nuclear strike. Nuclear weapons will only be used in retaliation against a nuclear attack on Indian territory or on Indian forces anywhere. India maintains a limited but effective nuclear arsenal. The capability is designed purely to deter potential aggressors rather than engage in an arms race.

Through avalanches and adversity, India breaks...

Once completed, it is set to slash travel time across the treacherous Zojila Pass from nearly three-and-a-half hours to just 20 minutes, improving connectivity, boosting economic activity and strengthening access to the border region.

The historic milestone was greeted with spontaneous celebrations by the team of engineers and workforce. Addressing the media, Gadkari said the project is a lifeline for the people of Ladakh and Jammu and Kashmir. He said 80 per cent of the workforce belongs to the region, and added that the project will provide all-weather connectivity to people of Ladakh region to Srinagar.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah congratulated the people of Ladakh for getting closer to the realisation of the dream of all-weather connectivity. He added that while one dream of the people of Ladakh is close to getting fulfilled, another – that of direct and regular air connectivity to Kargil – is yet to take shape and urged the Union Minister to use his influence to help fulfil the aspiration.

Megha Engineering and Infrastructure Limited (MEIL), the agency executing the project, used the New Austrian Tunnelling Method (NATM) to pierce through the Himalayas and navigate the fragile geology.

The entire project is 31 km long, including the approach road and bridges, stretching from Sonmarg to Minimarg.

MEIL won the project from the NHIDCL and began constructing the tunnel in October 2020. Speaking further, Gadkari said that multiple rounds of bids were invited for the project. In the fifth round, the estimation for the project was delivered around ₹12,000 crore but "we are building it at around ₹7,000 crore. So we saved ₹5,000 crore."

MEIL is aiming to complete the project by 2028. However, it will continue to operate and maintain the tunnel for a period of five years after com-

missioning, officials said.

Besides being the longest tunnel project in Asia, Zojila is also among the world's highest tunnel projects, the officials said.

Over the last five years, the site has witnessed five avalanche incidents, including a severe one in January 2023 when 172 workers stranded in the area were rescued by the Indian Army. Despite these challenges, the project has achieved 10 million safe man-hours, MEIL said.

Interacting with the media, an Iranian engineer, Yusuf, who represented ICT AIAPL, said, "I am from Iran. I am proud of it. I can say I am proud that about 80% of the project is already finished; the remaining 20% might take another two years or so to complete fully. Regardless, the breakthrough is a major event for the tunnel, and we are happy that, under the current system, we have managed to execute this project effectively. It will take roughly another two and a half years for the tunnel to become operational. However, in a dire emergency, especially if the Army needed to use it, it might be possible to utilise the tunnel for a short period, although under normal circumstances, it is not feasible to use it yet..."

CID enters Mamata's residence in MLA...

A purported resolution dated May 6, bearing signatures of about 70 TMC MLAs, was submitted to the Assembly Secretariat around May 20.

On May 27, two TMC MLAs, Ritabrata Banerjee and Sandipan Saha, told Speaker Rathindra Bose that there was no meeting or resolution on May 6. They said they were only asked to sign a book on May 19. They also pointed out that at least 14 signatures were written in block letters rather than real cursive handwriting, calling the document "manufactured and fabricated."

The Assembly Secretariat filed an FIR at the Hare Street police station for forgery, cheating, and criminal conspiracy. The case was handed over to the CID, which set up a special investigation team. Officials have taken statements from 13 TMC MLAs, and at least three lawmakers have said the signatures linked to them are not real. Handwriting experts are involved, and the court has allowed more signature samples to be collected.

The CID has called Abhishek Banerjee to appear three times, but he has not appeared, citing health problems from an earlier incident and seeking protection from coercive action from the Calcutta High Court. The TMC has expelled the two whistle-blower MLAs for "anti-party activities". Party leaders have called the probe a "political vendetta" by the BJP-led government.

Senior TMC leaders, including Leader of the Opposition Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay, have been questioned. The party says the resolution showed a united decision by its lawmakers. Some members who disagree say many MLAs initially supported a different candidate for the LoP post, citing disagreements following the party's worst election results in over ten years.

The CID's visit to Mamata Banerjee's home is a major step in the investigation. Officials are expected to keep checking documents and taking statements in the coming days. The results could have a significant impact on the TMC's already-tense internal unity as it adjusts to opposition. Both the BJP and the TMC have accused each other, with the BJP saying the probe protects legislative integrity and the TMC calling it harassment of the opposition. The Calcutta High Court will hear Abhishek Banerjee's petition on Thursday.

PM hails 12 years of governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday stated that the past 12 years of the government have been dedicated to trust, development, and public welfare. He noted that with the blessings of 140 crore countrymen and the spirit of the Nation First, no stone has been left unturned in empowering the youth, women, and farmer brothers and sisters. Several Union ministers hailed his leadership.

Modi observed that it is the result of relentless efforts that today the country has gained a new identity across the world, from infrastructure to the digital revolution. To realize the resolution of a Viksit Bharat, the Prime Minister affirmed that the government will continue to move forward on this path of service, good governance, and prosperity in a social media post.



Several union ministers hailed Prime Minister Modi's leadership as his government completed 12 years on Tuesday. Union Home Minister Amit Shah said the country has witnessed the simultaneous realisation of welfare for the poor and unprecedented development.

In a post on social media, he said Modi had served the nation and its citizens tirelessly and highlighted a range of welfare and infrastruc-

ture initiatives undertaken during his tenure.

"Under Modi ji's leadership, over these 12 years, the country has witnessed for the first time the parallel realization of poor welfare and unprecedented development," Shah said.

The home minister cited measures such as free ration for 80 crore people, pucca houses for more than four crore poor families, health insurance cover of Rs 5 lakh for 50 crore people and LPG

connections for over 10 crore households.

He also referred to the launch of more than 90 airports and over 140 Vande Bharat trains, besides the construction of 1.45 lakh km of roads and 3,000 km of modern expressways.

Referring to India's economic growth, Shah said the country had become the world's fastest-growing major economy under Modi's leadership.

"Modi ji has served the nation and its citizens tirelessly through these 12 years without taking even a single day off," he said.

Shah said such transformation was possible only when leadership's intent was pure, goals were in the national interest and dedication was complete.

Modi was sworn in as prime minister for the third consecutive time on June 9, 2024, following another decisive victory in the 2024 Parliamentary elections.

Nabin marks 12 years of NDA Government



BJP National President Nitin Nabin visits an exhibition, marking completion of 12 years of the NDA Government at party headquarters in New Delhi on Tuesday

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Celebrating completion of 12 years of the NDA Government under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, BJP President Nitin Nabin on Tuesday said that the period represented not merely a change in governance but a historic reclaiming of India's self-confidence.

Joined by the party's senior members and the full Cabinet of the Narendra Modi government, Nabin noted that Modi is set to become the country's longest-serving democratically elected Prime Minister when he surpasses the first PM Jawaharlal Nehru's tenure on Wednesday.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Health Minister JP Nadda, Home Minister Amit Shah, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, and Railways and Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw were also present at an event organised for an interaction with senior journalists at Bharat Mandapam.

Nabin said the era of Bharatiyata is here. "There was a time when we did not take pride in Indian-ness," he said. The BJP chief cited the abrogation of Article 370, the eradication of Naxalism, and a policy of zero tolerance towards terrorism as defining

features of the BJP-led NDA dispensation. He also said that basic facilities that had eluded people for years, from toilets and schools to cooking gas cylinders and health services, had been delivered to their doorsteps.

BJP also presented its 12-year report card under the banner "Viksit Bharat ka Sankalp: 12 Varsh, 12 Badi Uplabdhiyan" (Resolve of a Developed India: 12 Years, 12 Major Achievements), listing what it described as transformational outcomes across welfare, economy, security, and infrastructure.

The achievements cited include more than 25 crore people lifted out of poverty, over four crore families given permanent housing, and more than 60 crore people brought under the Ayushman Bharat health scheme. The party also cited more than three crore women becoming self-sufficient through the Lakhpati Didi initiative, over 57 crore Mudra loans disbursed to support self-employment, and more than 12 crore toilets built to ensure dignity for women.

On the economy, the party claimed record exports of ₹79 lakh crore and record defence exports of ₹38,400 crore. Social security coverage has tripled, it said. UPI transactions have grown 12,000 times, with digital transactions reaching ₹314 lakh crore.

States Focus



CM HELPLINE 1076 LAUNCHED IN CHHATTISGARH

A toll-free Chief Minister helpline, where people from Chhattisgarh can register their grievances, get them addressed from government authorities, and also submit suggestions for development policies, was launched on Tuesday. Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai launched the much-awaited CM Helpline 1076 in Raipur and also unveiled its logo, a government official said. Speaking on the occasion, Sai affirmed his government is committed to ensure that every citizen's grievance is heard, resolved within a stipulated time frame and addressed through an accountable administrative system. He noted that complaints, suggestions and feedbacks received during the 'Sushasan Tihar' campaign (Good Governance Festival) highlighted the need for an effective, robust and permanent public engagement mechanism.



RAHUL SLAMS GOVT OVER CUT IN UJJWALA SUBSIDISED REFILLS

In a scathing attack on the Government, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday said 12 years of "anti-poor" economic policies and a "compromised" foreign policy have pushed the country into such a dire situation that lakhs of poor families and women have been forced to bear the "poisonous smoke of firewood stoves". Gandhi's criticism of the government came over its reduction of the number of subsidised refills of LPG gas cylinders under the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana. (PTI)

Returning Officer rejects Congress candidate Meenakshi's nomination for Rajya Sabha election

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The Madhya Pradesh Congress suffered a major setback in the Rajya Sabha election process on Tuesday after the Returning Officer rejected the nomination of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan following objections raised by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

The BJP had challenged Natarajan's nomination, alleging that she failed to disclose details of a case pending before a court in Telangana in her election affidavit. The party argued that the omission amounted to concealment of material facts and sought cancellation of her nomination.

Representing the BJP, advocate Sanket Gupta submitted a formal objection before the Returning Officer, contending that Supreme Court rulings and Election Commission guidelines require candidates to disclose all relevant cases



Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan speaks to media at PCC headquarters in Bhopal Madhya Pradesh

in their affidavits. He maintained that the alleged non-disclosure made the nomination liable for rejection.

The issue triggered intense political activity inside the Madhya Pradesh Assembly complex throughout the day. Senior leaders from both the Congress and the BJP gathered outside the Returning Officer's chamber as arguments were presented by both sides.

Before the decision was announced, Leader of Opposition Umang Singhar strongly defended Natarajan and termed the BJP's objection baseless. He argued that no criminal case had been registered against the Congress candidate and that the matter involved only a court notice.

According to Singhar, Election Commission rules require disclosure of registered criminal cases, not merely notices issued by courts.

He accused the BJP of raising the objection for political reasons and said Natarajan's legal team had submitted a detailed response before the Returning Officer.

The number that could split Trinamool Congress

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar's 19-MP Gamble Against Mamata Banerjee. Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar keeps returning to the same figure: nearly 20 MPs stand with her in open revolt against Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee. The number that actually decides the rebels' fate, however, is 19. On June 8, the four-time Barasat MP and former TMC chief whip led a dramatic breakaway in the Lok Sabha.

She claimed that 20 TMC MPs, including herself, had signed a letter to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking recognition as a separate parliamentary bloc. The group declared it would extend support to the BJP-led NDA while remaining formally outside it, citing lawlessness, misgovernance and unemployment in West Bengal. Eighteen MPs signed physically; two did so online. The rebels have resigned from all party posts and insist they are not defecting but reforming from within to "work for Bengal's development in conjunction with



the Centre and State Government."

The arithmetic is everything in the lower house of the parliament. TMC holds 28 seats in the Lok Sabha (one vacancy after the death of a sitting MP). Under the anti-defection law's 10th Schedule, a breakaway faction needs the support of at least two-thirds of the party's strength in the House to merge with another party or function as a separate group without facing disqualification. For 28 MPs, the threshold is at least 19. Fall short, and the rebels lose their seats. If they muster the numbers, cross it, and keep both their mandates and their leverage.

The rebellion is the sharpest challenge to the

TMC chief Mamata Banerjee has ever faced in the party's 28-year history. It unfolded barely a month after TMC's crushing defeat in the May 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections, where the party was reduced to just 80 seats against the BJP's landslide majority of 207 seats.

A parallel revolt is already underway in the state legislature, led by expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee. In Delhi, at least 14 rebel MPs were seen meeting Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav and West Bengal BJP Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari. Dastidar, a doctor-turned-politician and once one of Mamata's most trusted lieutenants, has framed the uprising as ideological rather than personal.

TMC LEADERS CRITICISE REBEL PARTY MPS

New Delhi: On Tuesday, Trinamool Congress leaders Kalyan Banerjee and Kirti Azad criticised rebel party MPs, accusing them of lacking political ethics, keeping ties with the BJP, and abandoning party workers facing harassment and political attacks.

Banerjee said the TMC called the meeting after dissident MPs claimed support from most Lok Sabha members and planned to be recognised as a separate group. He asked why they were not joining the BJP if they had the support they claimed to have, adding that the BJP would not accept them.

On Monday, Lok Sabha MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, a leader of a rebel group, said they planned to write to Speaker Om Birla to express support for the NDA. She claimed 20 party MPs had agreed to write. Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Sekhar Roy resigned from the Upper House after making allegations against the party. Banerjee said rebel MPs should do the same if

they had grievances.

Banerjee said Sukhendu Sekhar Roy had resigned from the Rajya Sabha after making allegations against the party, and urged others making similar allegations to resign as MPs and show political morality. He questioned whether a letter from the dissident group was genuine, noting that such an important document had not been shared publicly. He asked why it was not made public or given to the press, alleging the exercise lacked transparency.

Banerjee said the rebel leaders were working closely with the BJP.

The two leaders pointed out that rebel MPs met Union Minister Bhupendra Yadav, with West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari present, saying this showed they were with the BJP. On Monday, while TMC leader Mamata Banerjee, national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and several senior MPs attended a meeting of the INDIA bloc leaders. (PNS)

Disruptions in Houses a serious challenge to democracy: Om Birla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Second Conference of the Commonwealth Parliamentary Association (CPA) India Region Zone-II (North Zone) concluded on Tuesday with the valedictory address by the Governor of Haryana, Professor Asim Kumar Ghosh.

Addressing the valedictory ceremony, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla stated that frequent interruptions and disruptions in the Houses pose a serious challenge to democratic institutions. He underlined that the solution to this problem lies within the legislative institutions themselves by promoting conduct aligned with public expectations, dialogue, and meaningful discussion. Strengthening public trust is the greatest responsibility of all public representatives today. He called upon the public representatives to ensure that their conduct in legislative institutions is exemplary so that the welfare of the last person in



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla Addressing the Valedictory Session at the 2nd Annual Conference of the Zone-II, Commonwealth Parliamentary Association (CPA) India Region in Chandigarh

society can be secured.

Birla remarked, "Society is shaped by the conduct and behaviour of its leadership. The public has elected and sent us here, hence our conduct has a direct impact on society."

He hoped that all legislators would assimilate these resolutions in their respective states and institutions and move forward.

Expressing happiness over the successful organisation of the two-day conference,

Birla said that public representatives and policy-makers from various states shared their experiences, perspectives, and innovations here. He informed that the conference concluded with four important resolutions aimed at making legislative institutions more effective, accountable, and people-centric.

He said that the dream of a Developed India (Viksit Bharat) is anchored on strong parliamentary and legislative institutions.

Centre announces ₹95,692 cr interim allocation under VB-G RAM G

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Tuesday announced an interim allocation of ₹95,692 crore under the newly introduced VB-G RAM G scheme for a seamless transition, with Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan asserting that no state would face any reduction in funds.

Addressing a press conference after a meeting with the state rural development ministers, Chouhan said the interim allocation had been made as the draft rules of the new scheme were still being finalised and to ensure that rural employment and development activities continue uninter-



rupted after June 30.

"Without causing any inconvenience to workers, we are moving from the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) to the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Grameen) (VB-G RAM G). There will not be a gap of even a single day in the availability of work," he said.

Not a single worker should remain without work even for a day, he said.

Chouhan said the central government has already allocated ₹30,000 crore under MGNREGA. In addition, an interim allocation of ₹95,692 crore has been released today to states and Union territories, which brings the total allocation to over ₹1.25 lakh crore.

According to the Rural Development Ministry, Uttar Pradesh has been allotted the highest interim allocation of ₹9,721.48 crore, followed by West Bengal at ₹8,508 crore, Tamil Nadu at ₹7,585.49 crore, Rajasthan at ₹7,581.87 crore, Andhra Pradesh at ₹7,707.21 crore and Bihar at ₹6,715.83 crore.

In the national Capital on Tuesday, diplomacy and infrastructure converged through two parallel moves that underscore India's renewed focus on its 4,096-km eastern frontier with Bangladesh. As the 57th Director General-level Border Coordination Conference between the Border Security Force (BSF) and Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) enters its second day (June 8-11), Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurated the Land Port Management System (LPMS), a flagship digital platform designed to overhaul land border management at India's 13 operational land ports.

Official statements described the LPMS launch as a "step towards modern,



technology-enabled smart border management."

The system brings together real-time data analytics, automated clearance, and better surveillance to make trade smoother and address cross-border risks. This move fits with Shah's idea of a "smart border project" that uses drones, radars, sensors, and AI-driven monitoring in BSF-guarded areas. The goal is to make operations more

transparent, reduce manual work, and improve detection of smuggling, infiltration, and counterfeiting.

At BSF headquarters, DG Praveen Kumar (IPS) is leading the Indian team in talks with BGB chief Major General Mohammad Ashrafuzzaman Siddiqui. This four-day conference, which has been held twice a year since the two forces started working together, comes at a

sensitive moment. India wants stronger action against illegal migration, cattle smuggling, drug trafficking, arms movement, and gaps in the border fence, especially in West Bengal, where land issues have caused delays.

Bangladesh is expected to bring up concerns about alleged 'push-in' incidents and reported border deaths. These tensions have already appeared in local meetings, including recent standoffs with civilians at the Panchagarh-Thakurgaon sector.

The timing of these steps is important because they indicate a broader shift in how India manages its eastern border. By digitising port operations at places like Petrapole and Hili, the LPMS adds a digital layer of security and trade management to the existing physical barriers.

Security experts see these changes as part of a bigger strategy. The BSF is moving beyond traditional border guarding, incorporating civil administration and technology into its approach. Shah recently announced a 'quadrangular security grid' that is being tested along the Bangladesh border, where economic and security interests sometimes clash. If it works, the LPMS could cut clearance times by up to half, help legal trade, and disrupt smuggling networks, as long as Dhaka cooperates.

For India, these talks are a chance to agree on joint patrols, faster intelligence sharing, and a strong position against insurgents and traffickers. BSF officials say the agenda also covers updating procedures for fence repairs, the use of drones, and handling accidental crossings.

■ States Focus ■



REBEL SAD MLA MANPREET JOINS AMRITPAL'S PARTY

Rebel Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) MLA Manpreet Singh Ayali joined the Amritpal Singh-led Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) here on Tuesda. He joined the party in the presence of Amritpal's father Tarsem Singh and Faridkot MP Sarabjit Singh Khalsa. Ayali's joining came days after he quit the Shiromani Akali Dal (Punar Surjit), a breakaway faction of the Sukhbir Singh Badal-led SAD. A three-time MLA from the Dhaka seat in Ludhiana, Ayali had announced resignation from all posts of the SAD (Punar Surjit) on May 20. Following the joining, Ayali said he will raise various issues of Punjab, including the release of 'Bandi Singhs' (Sikh prisoners), unemployment and law and order. Replying to a question, he emphasised 'Panthic' unity. Khalsa said Ayali's joining will give a boost to the party, as he is an experienced leader and has a clean image. Amritpal's father Tarsem Singh said he welcomes Ayali into the party old. Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh is currently lodged in a jail in Assam

(PTI)



ARUNACHAL IS KEY TO INDIA'S CULTURAL HERITAGE: PABITRA

Describing Arunachal Pradesh as an integral part of India's cultural heritage, Union minister Pabitra Margherita on Tuesday praised the state's progress in infrastructure development and preservation of indigenous traditions, while crediting its MPs for helping bring key development and textile projects to the region. Addressing weavers, handicraft artisans and district officials during his visit to the Lower Subansiri district, Margherita, the Union Minister of State for external affairs and textiles said Arunachal Pradesh holds a special place in the country's cultural identity and reiterated the Centre's commitment to supporting traditional crafts and local livelihoods.

(PTI)

Congress scared of BJP-JD(S) tie-up for 2028 polls: HD Kumaraswamy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mandya

JD(S) leader HD Kumaraswamy on Tuesday said that the ruling Congress in Karnataka is worried about his party's alliance with the BJP and its implication in the 2028 Assembly polls and hence was attempting to create a divide by making sympathetic remarks regarding ex-PM HD Deve Gowda not getting a Rajya Sabha seat. The clarification came amid criticism from Congress leaders, who accused the BJP of denying Gowda a Rajya Sabha nomination. Congress empathises with Deve



Gowda now. Everyone knows how they treated Gowda in his 70 years of political life. I don't want to discuss it now. They are showing sympathy towards Deve Gowda because they are worried about the BJP-JD(S)

alliance; they realise what will happen in the 2028 Assembly polls, so they intend to create division in the alliance," Kumaraswamy said. Speaking to reporters, he asked, "Did JD(S) or Deve Gowda ask for a Rajya Sabha seat?" "It is not of our concern; the BJP has over 60 MLAs. If we ask for a Rajya Sabha seat, what will be the public opinion about Deve Gowda? Some are discussing that Deve Gowda would have raised Karnataka's voice there (in Parliament), which is a different matter. Whether he is in power or not, I can give multiple examples of him raising his voice for the

state," he added. Late on Sunday, the BJP announced Prof. M Nagaraja as its Rajya Sabha candidate from Karnataka, where the party can win one of the four seats going to polls on June 18, based on its current strength in the Assembly. The polls were necessary because the terms of four MPs, including Gowda, are concluding this month. The JD(S), an ally of the BJP, was reportedly hoping the latter would re-nominate its supreme to the Rajya Sabha. Clarifying that Gowda has never gone to the doors of others for the

sake of power, Kumaraswamy said that despite having the chance to serve as Prime Minister for a full five years, Gowda quit and came back, stating that he would not remain if his self-esteem were hurt. "Will he have to fight for a Rajya Sabha seat? He only needs good health from God," he added. The JD(S) leader also rejected the Congress party's claims that they had ensured Gowda's entry into the Rajya Sabha last time in June 2020. "Where and when did it happen? Where did Congress have the number to put another candidate?" he asked.

Zoji La tunnel a game changer for Ladakh: LG Saxena after historic breakthrough

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Leh

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Tuesday described the historic breakthrough of the Zoji La Tunnel as a "game changer" for the Union Territory, saying it will revolutionise connectivity and drive the region's development. Calling the project a dream initiative of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Lt Governor said the tunnel will provide year-round connectivity between Ladakh and the rest of India while significantly improving access to border areas. "The historic breakthrough of Zoji La Tunnel, a dream project of the prime



minister, will prove to be a game changer in the development journey of Ladakh. This would significantly strengthen connectivity in the border regions of Ladakh and provide year-round connectivity with the rest of India," Saxena said in a post on X. Responding to a post shared by Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, who described the breakthrough as an

important chapter in India's infrastructure development journey and all-weather connectivity between J&K and Ladakh, the Lt Governor thanked him for making the project possible and for supporting Ladakh with key road infrastructure projects. Saxena said enhanced connectivity would boost tourism, create new livelihood avenues and bolster the collective efforts for sustainable development in the high-altitude regions of Ladakh. J&K LG Manoj Sinha said that we are grateful to PM Modi and Union Minister Nitin Gadkari for making the historic Zojila Tunnel breakthrough a reality.

Zoji La breakthrough: Expert Janak Rathore hails 11,578-foot tunnel milestone

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Zojila Tunnel, Baltal

An ace geotechnical and tunnelling expert, Janak Singh Rathore, was on cloud nine on Tuesday after he witnessed Union Minister Nitin Gadkari performing the breakthrough blasting of the Zoji La tunnel being constructed at an altitude of 11,578 feet above sea level to provide all-weather connectivity between Kashmir and Ladakh. Hailing from the remote village of Sarthal in Kishtwar District, Janak Singh Rathore has come a long way in his

illustrious career spanning over three decades. He is one of the tunnelling experts who have been associated with four major strategic tunnel projects in Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh. An M Tech in Tunnelling and Underground Space Technology, Janak Singh Rathore transformed these academic achievements into practical engineering excellence, contributing significantly to some of India's most challenging and strategically important tunnel projects in the Himalayan region. As project director, he played an

active role in the construction of the 9 km long Chenani-Nashri Tunnel on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway. Later, Janak Singh Rathore became part of the core team of experts who supervised the work of the 6.5 km long Z-Morh Tunnel and successfully implemented the project. Previously, he worked tirelessly on another ambitious project, the 8.5 km long Qazigund-Banihal tunnel, which provided all-weather connectivity to the commuters travelling in the region. Speaking exclusively to The Pioneer, Janak Singh



(chargesheet) before an Ernakulam court in April 2025. The CMRL was caught in the crosshairs of central probe agencies following an Income Tax Department raid in January 2019, which unearthed alleged fake expenses to the tune of ₹130 crore. Court documents reveal that the company had "inflated" its expenditure by ₹133.82 crore by booking "bogus" cash expenses under the heads of 'transportation' and 'sludge handling' between the financial years 2012-13 and 2018-19 and generated cash that was used to make illegal payments to politicians, parties, media houses and public servants. The court papers State that the CMRL CFO and MD "admitted" before tax authorities that such cash payments were made to ensure smooth business operations, as they faced threats of closure of the business and environmental challenges.



Veena's now-defunct company Exalogic Solutions Private Limited. The ED is probing an allegation that CMRL made fraudulent payments worth ₹2.78 crore to Exalogic Solutions under the guise of 'IT consultancy services'. Another company named Empower India Capital Investment Private Limited, operated by Kartha, had also extended loans worth ₹50 lakh to Exalogic Solutions despite its failure to make timely repayments,

the officials said. They claimed that the CMRL management and Veena generated "proceeds of crime" in this process and that they want to understand the rationale behind these transactions from them. The PMLA case was filed in March 2024 after the ED took cognisance of a complaint registered by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), the investigation arm of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, which later filed a prosecution complaint

ED summons ex-Kerala CM's daughter in PMLA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kochi

The Enforcement Directorate has summoned former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan's daughter Veena T and officials of sand mining company Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) for questioning in a money laundering case. Officials said Veena has been asked to depose at the central agency's zonal office here on June 12. Her statement will be recorded under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). CMRL managing director Sasidharan Kartha and other company officials are among the nine others who have been summoned for questioning on different dates beginning this week, the officials said. The investigation pertains to alleged irregularities in CMRL's financial transactions and its links with

CPI(M) SEEKS TO DISTANCE ITSELF FROM VEENA VIJAYAN AFTER ED SUMMONS

Thiruvananthapuram: The ED summons to T Veena, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, in a money-laundering case triggered the political reactions on Tuesday, with CPI(M) leaders seeking to distance the party from the matter and saying that she would deal with it through legal channels. The remarks also came in the wake of criticism over a violent protest allegedly carried out by party workers following the recent ED raid at Veena's residence here in connection with the case. Reacting to the development, CPI(M) Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas said the law should take its own course in the matter. "Veena's case should proceed on its own merits. Let the investigation take its course," Brittas told

reporters in New Delhi. He said Veena had already furnished details before the Serious Fraud Investigation Office. Seeking an ED investigation into the donations made by a Kerala-based sand mining company named Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) to leaders of various political parties, Brittas called for a comprehensive probe into the company's political contributions. Claiming that certain political parties had acknowledged receiving funds from the company, Brittas said questions should also be raised regarding whether such contributions were duly disclosed to the Election Commission. "When viewed in that context, the disputes relating to Veena's case are comparatively small," he said. (PNS)

Tejashwi Yadav slams Bihar CM over Rabri's bungalow row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav on Tuesday hit out at the Bihar Government for allotting a bungalow occupied by his mother and former CM Rabri Devi to a minister and downgrading security cover for his parents, alleging that Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary was indulging in cheap politics. Yadav accused the BJP-led NDA dispensation of patronising corrupt officials and criminals and claimed that law and order has "completely collapsed" in the State. "Samrat Choudhary is playing cheap politics... What is the need for security? Those who are afraid have kept security. The people are with us... Although Samrat Choudhary has become chief minister, he is not a chief minister; he is a cheap minister," Yadav said while speaking to reporters. His comment comes after the building construction department, through a May 27 order, allotted the 10, Circular Road bungalow, which Rabri Devi has been occupying for two decades, to BJP leader and state



minister Nand Kishor Ram. The State Government also downgraded the security cover given to RJD supreme and former CM Lalu Prasad and his wife Rabri Devi. High drama was witnessed at the residence of Rabri Devi on June 6 when several RJD leaders stood guard, claiming their leader had "returned" her security cover in protest against "shabby" treatment from the NDA Government. Talking to reporters here, Yadav, the RJD national working president, said, "The NDA Government in the state is least bothered about the problems being faced by the people. Its leaders are busy patronising corrupt officials and criminals.

Odisha Cabinet approves two tourism schemes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhubaneswar

The Odisha cabinet approved two schemes with a total outlay of ₹2,000 crore over a period of five years to boost tourism in the State. During the cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, 10 proposals of five departments, including the two tourism-related schemes, were cleared. The Government approved a proposal to create a land bank for hospitality infrastructure with an aim to create a robust foundation for tourism-led economic growth and attract large-scale investments in the hospitality sector across the State, an official statement said. A major challenge in developing world-class tourism infrastructure has been the lack of readily available, contiguous, encroachment-free, and investment-ready land parcels. To address this gap, the cabinet has decided to establish a dedicated Tourism Land Bank under the Department of Tourism, the statement said. Under the scheme, approximately 5,500 acres of land, comprising both Government and private plots, will be identified and developed across major tourism destinations of Odisha. These



Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi

include Chilika, Konark, Puri (Shamuka), Dhauli, Hirakud, Satkosia, Similipal, Bhitarkanika, Daringbadi, Deomali, Buddhist Circuit, Jiranga, Talsari, and Tampara-Aryapalli, among others. The scheme will be implemented over a period of five years, from financial year 2026-27 to 2030-31, with an annual outlay of ₹300 crore, resulting in a total estimated financial implication of ₹1,500 crore, the Government said. The initiative is expected to encourage investments in hotels, resorts, convention centres, eco-tourism projects, wellness retreats, recreational facilities, and other tourism-related infrastructure, it said. Similarly, the state Government also decided to implement the Waterfront Development Scheme with a total outlay of ₹500 crore over a period of five years.

Mamata meets Sonia amid rebellion in TMC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A day after an opposition INDIA bloc meeting stressed unity and better coordination among the alliance partners, Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday met senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi at her 10, Janpath residence.

Sources said the two leaders are learnt to have discussed the strategy between the two parties going forward after the opposition bloc meeting, and following an exodus of Trinamool members after the party's defeat to the BJP in the recent Bengal polls.

The meeting followed after Gandhi, the chairperson of the Congress Parliamentary Party, and Banerjee met each other warmly with a hug at the opposition bloc's meeting here on Monday. The Congress



TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee departing from the residence of Congress MP Sonia Gandhi after a meeting in New Delhi

shared pictures of the bonhomie between the two leaders. The meeting comes in the wake of a rebellion within the Trinamool, with several party MPs deciding to form a separate group and align with the ruling NDA.

A majority of Trinamool's 80 MLAs have already formed a separate group led by

Ritabrata Banerjee as the leader of opposition in the State Assembly.

This was the first closed-door meeting between Banerjee and Gandhi after Trinamool's defeat in the polls, and alleged attacks on party workers and MP Abhishek Banerjee after the elections.

ED raids Sanjeev Arora over ₹100 crore GST scam

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday launched a fresh round of searches in a money-laundering investigation involving former Punjab minister Sanjeev Arora and several associates. The agency is probing an alleged ₹100 crore Goods and Services Tax (GST) fraud linked to the sale of mobile phones.

ED officials said they are searching about six locations at the same time in Jalandhar and Ludhiana in Punjab, and Bareilly and Noida in Uttar Pradesh. These include homes and business offices linked to people and companies under investigation. The main focus is Hampton Sky Realty Ltd., a company connected to Arora. Authorities believe money from the alleged GST evasion was routed through this real estate firm and other channels to hide the illegal funds.

This comes just weeks after Arora was arrested. The 62-year-old was taken into custody last month after a day-long search at his official home in Chandigarh and is now in judicial custody. Arora, who previously held important portfolios such



as Power, Industry, and Commerce in the AamAadmi Party Government led by Bhagwant Mann, had his duties quickly assigned to other ministers after his arrest to keep the Government running smoothly.

The case has caused a stir in Punjab's political scene. Arora's arrest and the ongoing raids have raised questions about possible financial wrongdoing within the state's ruling party.

The ED's searches across several states show the agency's efforts to trace the full path of the suspected fraud. Investigators are looking into how GST refunds and input tax credits from mobile phone sales may

have been misused to create fake revenue, which was then moved into businesses that appeared legitimate, including real estate.

People familiar with the investigation said the new searches are meant to collect more documents, find evidence, and question those linked to the companies involved. Carrying out searches in four cities at once shows that the alleged scheme crossed state lines, with mobile phone supply chains reportedly used to divert large amounts of tax money.

The GST fraud, estimated at ₹100 crore, is believed to involve a network of shell companies and

fake invoices used to evade taxes. The Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) authorises the ED to seize property and assets derived from these crimes. The raids on Tuesday are expected to provide important clues that could help uncover the larger scheme.

This situation has been a political challenge for the Punjab Government. Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's team quickly reassigned duties to demonstrate their commitment to maintaining stability. Still, the case has raised further questions about how the AAP runs the Government, especially in key areas such as industry and commerce.

As the searches continue, the ED has not shared details about what they have found or whether there will be more arrests.

Legal experts say the agency's careful approach shows that the case has been built step by step. Arora, who says he is innocent, will likely face a long legal process. These recent events have drawn attention to the connection between politics and financial crimes in India as the investigation moves forward. People in Punjab's business and political circles are paying close attention.

Operation Blue Star a ‘black day’: Maharashtra minister Girish Mahajan’s remark triggers row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Senior BJP leader and Maharashtra minister Girish Mahajan has kicked up a row by terming Operation Blue Star a “black day” and dubbing those killed in the military action “martyrs” while slamming the then prime minister Indira Gandhi.

He also likened the Army action to the invasion of the Golden Temple by Afghan ruler Ahmad Shah Abdali. Mahajan became the first representative of any state Government to attend the Operation Blue Star anniversary commemoration at the headquarters of Damdami Taksal in Amritsar district last Saturday. “For us, Operation Blue Star is a black day. Our brothers and sisters were martyred and killed,” he



Girish Mahajan

said while addressing the gathering in Amritsar.

Terming Operation Blue Star a “military attack” on the Sikh community's holy shrine, Mahajan alleged that then PM Indira Gandhi had forcibly sent the Army into Punjab and inside the sacred complex. “It was a military attack on our holy shrine. Indiraji forcibly sent them (the Army) to Punjab and into our sacred place,” he said. Drawing a parallel with Ahmad Shah Abdali's inva-

sion of the Golden Temple, Mahajan said the attack on the holy Sikh shrine in 1984 had caused deep pain to the community.

He further alleged that Sikhs were brutally killed and claimed that those responsible were never punished. “Such a major tragedy took place. I would not call it an accident, but a deliberate act in which so many of our brothers and sisters were killed. Even after that, nobody was punished,” Mahajan said.

Operation Blue Star was a military operation by armed forces conducted between June 1 and 10, 1984, with the stated objective of removing Damdami Taksal leader Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale.

The operation marked the beginning of the insurgency

in Punjab. The remarks triggered backlash from Congress and Shiv Sena (UBT), with senior leaders demanding Mahajan's sacking from the cabinet and BJP.

Maharashtra Congress president Harshwardhan Sapkal said the minister should apologise to the armed forces for insulting them with his “Abdali invasion” remark and the people of the country, accusing him of attempting to glorify Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale.

In a statement, Sapkal said Operation Blue Star was a necessary military action against armed Khalistani militants and was not directed against any religion.

He alleged that Mahajan's comments questioned the sacrifices made by those who acted to safeguard the country's unity and integrity.

Shaurya Chakra awards to two Manipur natives brought immense pride: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Tuesday said conferring the Shaurya Chakra on two defence personnel from the state brought immense pride to the people.

His remarks came after Major Leishangthem Deepak Singh of 11 Para (Special Forces) and Rifleman Manglem Sang Vaiphei of 3 Assam Rifles, both from Manipur, were awarded the Shaurya Chakra on Monday for displaying raw courage, unparalleled bravery and total disregard for personal safety in the line of duty.

President Droupadi Murmu conferred seven Kirti Chakras, 15 Vir Chakras, and 29 Shaurya Chakras to the personnel of the defence



forces, Central Armed Police Forces and State or Union Territory police forces.

The Shaurya Chakra is India's third-highest peacetime gallantry award.

Extending congratulations to Leishangthem, Singh, in a social media post, said, “His courage, professionalism, and unwavering dedication to duty bring immense pride to Manipur and serve as an inspiration to generations of

young Indians.” The CM saluted Leishangthem's valour and commitment to the nation.

He also extended congratulations to Vaiphei for “his exceptional courage, tactical acumen, and distinguished service during a counter-infiltration operation”.

Vaiphei hails from the Churachandpur district. In another post, Singh said, “His (Vaiphei) gallantry and

dedication to the nation bring immense pride to Manipur and inspire our youth to serve with honour, commitment, and patriotism.” BJP state president Adhikarimayum Sharda Devi, on behalf of the party, said the two brave sons of Manipur have displayed “extraordinary courage, unwavering dedication to duty, and selfless service to the nation”. “Their acts of gallantry in the face of grave danger embody the highest traditions of valour, sacrifice, and patriotism,” she said.

“The people of Manipur take immense pride in their remarkable achievements and salute their steadfast commitment to protecting innocent lives and safeguarding the sovereignty and security of our nation,” she added.

Conduct caste-based census immediately, PMK urges Tamil Nadu CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

PMK leader Dr Anbumani Ramadoss on Tuesday urged Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay to take immediate steps to conduct a caste-based census in Tamil Nadu.

Ramadoss met CM Vijay at the Secretariat and handed over a letter, a copy of which was later released to the media. In a letter addressed to Vijay, he said, “Tamil Nadu alone has gone beyond the usual 50 per cent cap and has



TN Chief Minister Joseph Vijay with Pattali Makkal Katchi MP Anbumani Ramadoss during a meeting at Chief Secretariat in Chennai

implemented a 69 per cent reservation, and it is the only state that sought to include this ceiling in the Ninth Schedule of the Constitution. However, the reservation is now under threat.”

He pointed out that in the case challenging the 69 per cent reservation, the Supreme Court's judgment dated 13 July 2010 upheld it and at the same time directed that a caste-based census be conducted within a year to determine the exact extent of reservation. Stating that

reservation was confirmed without conducting the caste census, some parties again filed cases in 2012 against the 69 per cent limit.

“When these cases came up for hearing on 27 May this year, although the Supreme Court dismissed certain connected petitions on the ground that some student petitioners had completed their studies, two principal cases remain pending”.

“Those cases can be listed for hearing in the Supreme Court at any time,” he said,

adding, “If Tamil Nadu cannot demonstrate through a caste census that the population proportion of reserved communities justifies a 69 per cent reservation, there is a real risk that the 69 per cent ceiling may be struck down and therefore, it is necessary to conduct a caste-based enumeration in Tamil Nadu—commonly called a Social Justice Survey—to protect the 69 per cent reservation,” the former union minister said.

Pointing out that a national caste-based enumeration

was scheduled to be included as part of the 2027 national census being conducted by the central Government, Anbumani said, “The data gathered at the national level will not be sufficient to meet Tamil Nadu's needs”.

“The central exercise will capture only certain macro indicators such as caste-wise population counts, which are inadequate for state-level decisions on quotas, livelihood improvements, and other social-justice actions,” he said.

Pradhan reviews re-NEET preparations



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Tuesday reviewed preparations for the June 21 NEET-UG re-test and assured candidates that measures have been put in place to ensure the examination is conducted smoothly, securely and without errors.

He also appealed to the candidates to focus on their studies, asserting that the government is taking extra precautions this time, from question paper setting to their delivery at the examination centres.

The minister assessed the readiness of the examination system and reviewed the measures being undertaken to ensure the smooth, secure and transparent conduct of the NEET-UG re-test.

During the review meeting at the headquarters of the National Testing Agency (NTA), Pradhan emphasised the importance of maintaining the highest standards of confidentiality and integrity throughout the examination process, sources said.

He said special attention has been given to safeguarding every stage of the process, from the preparation of question papers to the secure transportation and timely delivery of examination materials to centres across the country, they added.

Pradhan also said that meetings have been held under the Cabinet secretary, and all the states have been asked to cooperate with the re-examination process.

Bihar: 5 killed as tree falls on their house in Sitamarhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sitamarhi

Five members of a family, including three children and a newborn, died after a branch of a peepal tree fell on their house during a storm in Bihar's Sitamarhi district, officials said on Tuesday.

The incident occurred around 2 am in Rewasi village of the district, they said.

Confirming the incident, Sub Divisional Officer (Sitamarhi Sadar) Anand Kumar said, “A heavy branch of a peepal tree crashed onto the mud house of Sikandar Sahni during strong winds and rain early Tuesday. The occupants were trapped



under the debris.”

The deceased have been identified as Sikandar Sahni's wife, Pooja Devi (32) and the couple's four children, all aged under 10 years, including a newborn. Sikandar Sahni sustained injuries in the incident and has received medical treatment, officials said. Riga MLA Baidyanath Prasad visited the bereaved family and expressed condolences.

Punjab: Two linked to cross border terror module held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amritsar

The Punjab Police in coordination with central agencies arrested two men linked to cross-border handlers and recovered two hand grenades from their possession, officials said on Tuesday.

Those arrested have been identified as Davinder Singh and Rajwinder Singh, both from Tarn Taran. Police also impounded the car they were travelling in, which bore a Punjab registration number. Director General of Police (DGP) Punjab Gaurav Yadav said preliminary investigation has revealed that the accused were in direct contact with foreign-based handlers and were



acting on their instructions.

He said the recovery of hand grenades points to a larger conspiracy aimed at disturbing peace and public order in the border state. According to the DGP, further investigation is underway to trace both forward and backward link-

ages to identify other members of the network.

Sharing operational details, Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Amritsar Rural Kanwalpreet Singh Chahal said police received reliable intelligence that Davinder and Rajwinder had retrieved

a consignment of explosive material sent by their cross-border handlers and were planning to carry out a terror-related activity to disturb peace and harmony in the State.

Acting swiftly on the input, police teams under the supervision of Deputy Superintendent of Police (Investigation) Gurinderpal Singh Nagra and DSP Attari Yadwinder Singh launched an intelligence-based operation and intercepted the duo in the Khasa area of Amritsar, recovering two hand grenades during the search of their vehicle.

The SSP further said preliminary probe suggests the accused were waiting for instructions from their

foreign-based handlers to execute a planned activity.

Chahal also revealed that both accused were introduced to the foreign-based handler by Harwant Singh alias Harry, who is currently lodged in Amritsar Jail.

He said the two men had previously smuggled several weapons and explosives to associates linked to Harwant. Police have also recovered a mobile phone belonging to Harwant from within Amritsar Jail, and a separate case has been registered in this regard, the SSP said.

Further investigation is underway to establish the full extent of the network and identify all individuals involved, officials added.

Japanese PM likely to hold summit level talks with Modi in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is likely to arrive here on a three-day visit to Assam from July 1 to hold summit-level talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Tuesday.

The two Prime Ministers are expected to hold talks on varied issues, focusing on economic and infrastructure collaboration. Speaking at the launch of the pilot project of Blue Valley Cluster—Fragrances, Flavours and Ayush in collaboration with the European Union, the Chief Minister said that there is a possibility of summit-level talks between the



two Prime Ministers. “This will again strengthen Assam's role in India-Japan relationship,” he added.

The possibility of the summit being held here indicates Assam's growing importance as a key stakeholder in the ambit of the Act East Policy.

Kerala Govt rejects saffronisation charge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kottayam

Kerala Higher Education Minister Roji M John on Tuesday rejected allegations by the CPI(M) and its student wing SFI that the UDF Government was facilitating a BJP-friendly “power-sharing” arrangement in universities through appointments made by Governor and Chancellor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar.

Responding to reporters' questions on the allega-



Roji M John

tions, John said the Government remained firmly opposed to “saffronisation”. “This Government

does not agree, under any circumstances, with saffronisation. That is what we have said from the very beginning; we have said it earlier as well. That itself is our position, and there is no change in it,” he said.

The minister also turned the criticism back on the previous CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government, accusing it of allowing similar interventions in universities. “Those who are raising criticism now would do well to think

about what happened during their own period.

This practice of Chancellors or Governors intervening in the day-to-day functioning of universities in Kerala began during the period of the LDF Government,” he said.

John alleged that individuals linked to the BJP, RSS and a pro-Sangh Parivar newspaper had been appointed to university bodies, including the Mahatma Gandhi University, during the previous Government's tenure.



Editor's
TAKE

Nicobar island project: Development or ecocide

Nicobar, an island of immense ecological value, sits at the crossroads of strategic ambition and environmental recklessness

In the annals of India's development story, few projects have generated as much heat as the Great Nicobar Island Development Project. Conceived by NITI Aayog in 2021 and fast-tracked through environmental clearances the following year, the ₹81,000-crore mega-scheme promises a transshipment port, a dual-use military-civil airport, a township, and a power plant on one of the most ecologically sensitive islands on Earth. The government calls it holistic development. Critics call it something closer to ecocide.

The project's strategic logic is not without merit. Great Nicobar sits at one of the world's most consequential maritime chokepoints, near the Strait of Malacca, through which a staggering share of global trade passes daily. As the Indo-Pacific becomes an arena of intensifying great-power rivalry, New Delhi's desire to anchor a strategic and commercial presence here is understandable, even necessary. But strategy does not exempt a government from ecological accountability.

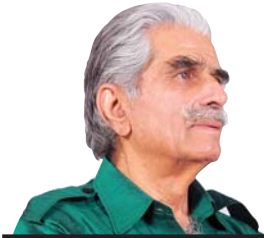
The environmental objections are not fringe concerns. More than seventy independent scientists and experts issued an open letter in late 2025 describing the project as an "exploitative commercial proposal" destructive to rich and diverse ecosystems. The numbers behind their alarm are staggering: approximately 9.6 lakh trees across 130 square kilometres of prehistoric tropical rainforest are slated for felling. Coral reefs, nesting grounds for giant leatherback turtles, and some of the world's last pristine island biospheres hang in the balance. When the Union Ministry of Environment defended the project before the National Green Tribunal in October 2025, it claimed full awareness of biodiversity impacts and a mitigation plan, but offered no satisfying answers as to what those mitigations actually entail. The human cost is no less troubling. The Shompen, one of India's most isolated and vulnerable indigenous communities, number fewer than 300 individuals. Their homeland lies directly within the project's footprint. The Nicobarese Tribal Council has alleged that community consent was falsely certified by authorities – a charge that, if true, would represent not just a legal violation but a moral failure on the part of the government. Experts warn that seismic tremors near the islands could signal volcanic activity. Great Nicobar sits in one of the most tectonically active zones on the planet - the same fault line that produced the catastrophic 2004 tsunami. Building a city intended to house hundreds of thousands of people atop this zone is not bold ambition. It is a recipe for disaster.

Nevertheless, the government's urgency is understandable. China's expanding naval reach and port investments across the Indian Ocean have understandably alarmed New Delhi.

What India must do is strike a balance: achieve its strategic objectives with minimal intervention, not an overhaul of the entire island. A genuinely independent environmental review, real and verifiable consent from the Shompen and Nicobarese communities, and a transparent assessment of seismic risk are the minimum conditions for the project to proceed. Great Nicobar's ecosystems, once destroyed, cannot be rebuilt. The island is a living system that the world cannot afford to lose.

Delhi courts Nepal's new political forces

By extending a warm reception to Lamichhane, New Delhi underscored its determination to maintain momentum in bilateral ties amid political transitions in Kathmandu and reset its relationship with the Himalayan nation



ASHOK K MEHTA

Two back-to-back visits from Nepal's top leaders last week demonstrated Delhi's proactive diplomacy. For Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP) Chairman Rabi Lamichhane, the visit was godsend, even if it was party-to-party, as he met top leaders. This is significant due to the uncertainty over Prime Minister Balen Shah's travels abroad during the first year of his tenure, which will be dedicated to 'domestic issues' of good governance and accountability. There were reports that he might go to the UNGA in New York and visit India either before or after it. But everything remains in the realm of speculation. Bhopdev Shah, the party general secretary and right-hand man, was known to have said in an interview to a Kathmandu portal that Balen was focused on achieving 100 goals in 100 days and would stay in the country for the first year.

This, and the fact that Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri's travel to Kathmandu in mid-May — with an invitation from Prime Minister Narendra Modi for Prime Minister Balen Shah to visit India — did not take place, confirmed that no visit from Shah should be expected this year. This will stir speculation that the Chinese might take advantage of the diplomatic vacuum, but the conversation in Kathmandu is mainly about which country Shah will visit first: India or China.

As part of India's Neighbourhood First policy, Delhi acted with great alacrity when Foreign Minister S Jaishankar was the first to arrive in Colombo within days of Anura Kumara Dissanayake becoming President, carrying an invitation to visit India. Delhi was therefore quick to avert widening the diplomatic gap with Nepal by getting BJP President Nitin Nabin to invite Lamichhane, which was immediately accepted, giving him a leg up over Balen, who has been hogging the spotlight, not always for the right reasons.

Lamichhane arrived in Delhi accompanied by his wife Nikita Poudel, Joint General Secretary Bipin Acharya, and Member of Parliament Deepak Bohara, along with a signed edit-page piece in Hindustan Times titled "How Can an Aspirational Nepal and a Rising India Reconnect?" He was received by BJP General Secretary and head of the Foreign Policy Cell and Diaspora, Vijay Chauthaiwale, who earned now-dubious fame when Arzu Rana, wife of then Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba, tied him a rakhi four years ago.

Lamichhane had a hectic programme, symbolised by the red-carpet welcome and, accord-



LAMICHHANE WILL BE RE-ELECTED CHAIRMAN OF HIS PARTY AT THE END OF JUNE IN HIS CHITWAN STRONGHOLD, BOOSTING HIS RATINGS AS A NATIONAL LEADER

The writer, a retired Major General, served as Commander, IPKF (South), Sri Lanka, and was a founder member of the Defence Planning Staff, now the Integrated Defence Staff

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ing to a trusted source in the RSP, the warmth and humility shown by Modi in his meeting with him. He acknowledged reading Lamichhane's article and expressed willingness to help in whatever way he could in resetting ties. He requested that his good wishes be conveyed to Prime Minister Balen Shah, to whom he had already sent an invitation to visit India.

According to Kathmandu Post, the border issue was not discussed, though it had created a political earthquake in Parliament when Balen Shah stated that Nepal too had occupied Indian territory. Overall, the Lamichhane visit was very productive, with a string of meetings with Home Minister Amit Shah, Foreign Minister Jaishankar, NSA Ajit Doval, and, pointedly, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, whose visit had to be called off. Including Misri was designed to underline the point that Balen Shah's newly designed diplomatic protocol required recalibration with India, which enjoys special and multifaceted relations with Nepal. Rabi's popularity among Nepalese in India could be gauged by the tumultuous welcome he received at the Pyarelal Auditorium, which was jam-packed. No one should forget that Lamichhane was one of the most famous television show anchors of a programme titled Seedha Kura Janata Sang (Straight Talk with the People). He gained national fame in 2013 by setting a world record in the Guinness Book for the longest television talk-show broadcast, running con-

tinuously for over 62 hours on News24.

From Delhi, Lamichhane proceeded to Lucknow and then to Ayodhya. The question Nepalese may be asking is whether he was showing deference to the Hindu Rashtra and monarchy at a time when the Royalist Rashtriya Prajatantra Party had been decimated by the RSP landslide and the party further divided. Incidentally, during the talks in Delhi, the RSS was conspicuously omitted.

Lamichhane returned to Kathmandu and received a hero's welcome from the media. They bombarded him with questions, which he was at pains to answer, given that the visit was merely to strengthen party-to-party relations and no specific issue was taken up for discussion, including the sensitive Kalapani dispute.

For that and other government-to-government matters, Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal arrived in Delhi on June 5, for a quick follow-up to Lamichhane's familiarisation with the Indian leadership. He was received by Additional Secretary (North) in the Foreign Ministry, Mannu Mahawar. Khanal had met Jaishankar last month during the India Foundation-helmed Indian Ocean Dialogue.

He has prioritised the bilateral issues Nepal has in mind, notably the central themes of development diplomacy and connectivity, which were at the heart of Lamichhane's article. This was Khanal's first official visit to India, during which he had frank and warm discussions with Jaishankar on the gamut of bilateral issues. These included linking borders through the 150-km Raxaul-Kathmandu railway line, for which the DPR has been completed; the thorny issue of direct flights from the China-constructed Pokhara and Bhairahawa/Lumbini international airports to destinations in India, which have not been operationalised due to Indian security concerns; a comprehensive list of Nepal's hydropower projects constituting the integrated energy market; and recent cross-border issues. The Lamichhane article recommended resetting relations to August 3, 2014, when Modi first visited Nepal as Prime Minister.

One other issue that has been pending for nearly five years is recruitment under the Agniveer scheme, which previous governments in Nepal had rejected. While Dhanraj Regmi, RSP MP and son of a soldier, has been actively canvassing for its resumption, Indian Army Nepali Gorkha veterans had also met Lamichhane seeking its revival. It is not known whether Khanal raised the issue last week.

After his successful confidence-building visit to Delhi, Lamichhane will be re-elected chairman of his party at the end of June in his Chitwan stronghold, boosting his ratings as a national leader. The other key actor in Nepal's development diplomacy taking off is balancing China — never easy.

The prejudices we still carry

as a woman, particularly since an elected representative would be expected to deal with all kinds of people, including unsavoury elements. The advice was given as practical wisdom. A few days later, I overheard a group of morning walkers discussing another resident. Their conversation was punctuated by loud laughter and knowing glances. The object of their amusement had stated that the apartment was in his wife's name and that she would cast her vote as she chose. What followed was not a discussion about voting rights or personal choice. The laughter was at the suggestion that a man who did not control his wife's decisions had somehow failed in his role. These were accomplished professionals occupying senior positions in their respective fields.

The conversations reminded me of an evening nearly twenty-five years ago during an official visit to another city. I was taken to a prestigious club frequented by prominent politicians from rival parties. The atmosphere was relaxed and cordial, with political differences seemingly suspended over drinks and conversation. What I remember most clearly, however, was the laughter that followed an extremely sexist remark about a female politician.

The incidents occurred in different places and at different times. But they seemed connected by a common thread.

We often measure social progress through visible indicators. More women occupy leadership positions today than ever before. By almost every measurable standard,

society has moved forward. Yet many old prejudices still survive in subtle forms - in assumptions disguised as concern, in jokes disguised as humour, and in opinions disguised as common sense. They appear when competence is acknowledged in principle but doubted in practice, when independence is celebrated publicly but mocked privately, and when equality is accepted as an idea but resisted as a lived reality. This is what makes such attitudes difficult to confront. Overt discrimination is easier to identify. Hidden prejudice often arrives wrapped in the language of realism, tradition, practicality, or experience. Those expressing it rarely see themselves as prejudiced at all.

Perhaps this is why legal and institutional measures, important though they may be, can only take society so far. Societies do not become truly equal when women are simply allowed to participate. They become equal when competence is judged independently of gender, when respect is extended without qualification, and when dignity is not contingent upon conformity to old expectations.

Progress, after all, is not measured only by what we claim to believe. It is measured by what we reveal about ourselves when we speak freely, laugh casually, and assume nobody is paying attention. The prejudices we fail to confront are often the ones we quietly pass on.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A new role for the Opposition

The Opposition's renewed call for unity must be carefully calibrated. Voters across states have grown weary of negative campaigns that focus solely on attacking the government without offering constructive alternatives. Electoral setbacks in several states have shown that excessive criticism, unaccompanied by a credible vision, often erodes public trust rather than strengthening Opposition ranks.

Instead of positioning themselves as obstructionists, Opposition parties should channel their collective energy into advancing governance agendas that address the concerns of ordinary citizens. Unity should not be limited to amplifying grievances; it should involve pressing the government to implement projects and policies that genuinely benefit the nation. By demanding accountability on development, employment, infrastructure, education and health-care, the Opposition can establish itself as a responsible and relevant force. A strategy rooted in constructive engagement is more likely to resonate with citizens than relentless criticism. It allows the Opposition to rebuild credibility, demonstrate political maturity and show that unity is about strengthening democratic institutions and promoting national progress.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

A wake-up call for political parties

A major rebellion is reportedly brewing within the Trinamool Congress (TMC), with several MPs said to be seeking recognition as a separate bloc and extending support to the ruling NDA. If true, this development could have significant implications for both West Bengal and national politics. Such political realignments raise important questions about internal party democracy, leadership accountability, and the mandate entrusted by voters. While elected representatives have every right to express dissent, any change in political allegiance must be transparent and consistent with constitutional provisions, including the Anti-Defection Law, to preserve public trust in democratic institutions.

The situation also highlights a wider challenge facing political parties across India: the need to address internal grievances, encourage dialogue, and remain connected to grassroots concerns. At a time when Parliament should focus on pressing issues such as inflation, unemployment, education, and economic growth, leaders must prioritise governance over political manoeuvring.

This episode serves as a reminder that democratic stability depends not only on electoral success but also on responsible leadership, institutional integrity, and respect for the people's mandate.

VIDYASAGAR REDDY KETHIRI | NEW DELHI

Turning literacy into opportunity

The Uttar Pradesh government's success in implementing the *Nav Bharat Saksharta Abhiyan* demonstrates that large-scale adult literacy is achievable when political will, administrative commitment, and grassroots infrastructure work together effectively. Reaching 11.68 lakh adults above the age of fifteen in just three years is a commendable achievement and a significant step towards inclusive development. The programme's objective extends beyond basic literacy. It seeks to promote awareness, self-reliance, and meaningful participation in economic and social life. Experience from states such as Kerala and Himachal Pradesh shows that literacy initiatives create lasting impact only when linked to livelihood opportunities, legal awareness, health education, banking access, and digital literacy.

The centrally sponsored programme offers valuable lessons for other states with large adult literacy burdens. However, its success ultimately depends on sincere and sustained implementation by local administrations. Whether this initiative becomes a genuine social transformation or remains merely an impressive statistic remains to be seen. One hopes the commitment endures beyond electoral cycles and continues empowering people at the grassroots level.

A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

PIC TALK



Father-son duo beat the heat under lawn sprinklers near India Gate as temperatures soars in New Delhi.

PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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TALENT NEEDS PATIENCE BEFORE REACHING CRICKET'S SUMMIT

There is no denying the talent that the young cricket prodigy, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, possesses. While excitement has surrounded his call-up for India in the T20 series, cricket would do well to distinguish between promise and preparedness. In sport, one must not confuse early brilliance with enduring greatness. History is filled with prodigious talents who attracted enormous attention but struggled to meet expectations. Sports fans remember players such as Freddy Adu, whose career never matched the hype generated during his teenage years. Excessive publicity and unrealistic expectations can place immense pressure on young athletes long before they are fully prepared for the demands of elite competition.

The exceptional few, such as Sachin Tendulkar, Lionel Messi, and Max Verstappen, combined

extraordinary talent with years of disciplined training, strong support systems, and progressively tougher challenges. Their success was not built on talent alone but on patience, resilience, and continuous development.

Within Indian cricket, Tendulkar emerged through the rigours of long-format cricket at a time when T20 did not dominate the sporting imagination. Others, including Vinod Kambli, faded early despite immense promise, highlighting the importance of temperament and sustained growth.

If Vaibhav is to serve Indian cricket over the long term, his development must remain anchored in the longer formats of the game. Otherwise, he risks becoming merely a short-format specialist, vulnerable to the next wave of fleeting talent.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Rising seas, stronger cyclones and the fight for our blue planet

The oceans — sustaining life, biodiversity, and oxygen production — face mounting threats. Rising sea levels, warming waters, coral bleaching, plastic pollution, and intensifying coastal disasters are pushing marine ecosystems towards a dangerous tipping point



SATENDRA SINGH | TANUSHREE

Every year the world comes together to observe World Ocean Day — a moment to reflect on how deeply our lives depend on the health of our seas. Oceans cover nearly 71 per cent of Earth’s surface, produce half the oxygen we breathe, regulate the global climate, and sustain the livelihoods of over three billion people. Yet today, these vast blue expanses face an unprecedented convergence of threats: climate change, pollution, habitat destruction, overfishing, and even the environmental fallout of armed conflict.

The theme of World Ocean Day 2026 — “Reimagine: Beyond the World We Know, A New Relationship with Our Ocean” — captures the urgency of this moment. It is a reminder that humanity’s fate is inseparable from the fate of the ocean, and that meaningful change demands more than awareness. It demands action. Central to this year’s campaign is the call for strong Marine Protected Areas and the urgent implementation of the global 30x30 Goal — the commitment to place at least 30 per cent of the planet’s lands, waters, and oceans under conservation protection by 2030.

The Ocean as Earth’s Life-Support System

The oceans are far more than a scenic backdrop to human civilisation. They absorb roughly 30 per cent of all carbon dioxide emissions and about 90 per cent of the excess heat generated by those emissions. Without this enormous buffering capacity, Earth’s surface temperatures would climb rapidly, rendering vast regions uninhabitable. In this sense, the ocean is not just the planet’s lungs — it is its most critical climate regulator. But this service comes at a cost. As oceans absorb more heat and carbon dioxide, they grow warmer and more acidic, making conditions increasingly hostile for marine life. The consequences are already visible: more frequent marine heatwaves, mass coral bleaching events, disrupted migration patterns among fish species, and the intensification of tropical storms. Ocean warming is not a problem of the distant future. It is one of the defining challenges of our time.

Rising seas and coastal peril

Global mean sea levels have already risen between 21 and 24 centimetres since 1880, driven by the thermal expansion of warming water and the accelerating melt of glaciers and ice sheets. The latest IPCC projections suggest sea levels could rise by anywhere between 30 centimetres and one metre by the end of this century, depending on future emissions.

The human stakes are immense. More than 680 million people currently live in low-lying coastal zones. Major cities — Mumbai, Kolkata, Shanghai, Bangkok, Jakarta, New York, and Miami — face growing flood risks. Entire small island nations risk being submerged, with their populations displaced. For India, with over 7,500 kilometres of coastline supporting ports, industries, fishing communities, and dense urban populations, the threat is particularly acute. Rising seas combined with growing coastal populations are creating a slow-moving disaster that will define the coming decades.

Corals: Ocean’s Vanishing Rainforests

Coral reefs occupy just one per cent of the ocean floor, yet they shelter approximately 25 per cent of all marine species. They sustain fisheries, provide livelihoods through tourism, and protect coastlines by absorbing wave energy. But they are also among the most climate-sensitive ecosystems on Earth. Warmer water triggers coral bleaching — corals expel the symbiotic algae they depend on for survival, and repeated bleaching leads to colony death. Scientists estimate that up to 50 per cent of the world’s coral reefs have already disappeared or severely degraded since 1950. A recent global bleaching event affected reefs in more than 80 countries. The loss ripples outward: declining fish stocks, diminished tourism, and coastlines vulnerable to storm surges.

Acidification and plastic: Twin silent crises

Ocean acidification — often called the “evil twin” of climate



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OCEAN WARMING IS ALSO FUELLING MORE POWERFUL TROPICAL CYCLONES. WHILE THE TOTAL NUMBER OF STORMS MAY NOT BE RISING DRAMATICALLY, A GROWING PROPORTION ARE REACHING EXTREME INTENSITY. CYCLONES FANI, AMPHAN, TAUKTAE, YAAS, BIPARJOY, REMAL, AND DANA HAVE ALL DEVASTATED COASTAL COMMUNITIES ACROSS THE INDIAN OCEAN REGION IN RECENT YEARS

Satendra Singh, IFS, former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management, GOI and Tanushree, Junior Faculty at FDDI, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, GOI

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change - receives far less attention than it deserves. Since the Industrial Revolution, ocean acidity has increased by 26 per cent. This threatens species that rely on calcium carbonate to build shells and skeletons, including corals, shellfish, and plankton. As these foundational organisms struggle, the effects cascade through entire marine food webs, ultimately threatening food security for coastal communities worldwide.

Meanwhile, plastic pollution has reached catastrophic proportions. Between 19 and 23 million tonnes of plastic waste enter the oceans every year. Plastic has been found in the deepest ocean trenches and in the most remote marine environments. Sea turtles mistake plastic bags for jellyfish. Seabirds feed plastic fragments to their chicks. Abandoned fishing gear entangles and kills marine animals. As larger plastic breaks down into microplastics, these particles have turned up in seafood, drinking water, human blood, and even placental tissue. If current trends continue, plastic entering the ocean could nearly triple by 2040.

Mangroves: Nature’s frontline defence

Among the most underappreciated coastal ecosystems are mangrove forests. These remarkable trees — thriving at the boundary between land and sea — serve as nurseries for fish, crabs, and prawns, improve water quality, and function as highly efficient carbon sinks, storing more carbon per unit area than many terrestrial forests. India has approximately 4,992 square kilometres of mangrove cover, including the Sundarbans, the world’s largest mangrove forest. Critically, mangroves provide natural disaster protection. Research shows that intact mangrove belts can reduce wave height by up to 66 per cent, significantly buffering the impact of cyclones, storm surges, and floods. Communities shielded by healthy mangroves during the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami and subsequent Bay of Bengal cyclones suffered considerably less damage than those where mangroves had been cleared. Despite this, mangroves continue to face destruction through urbanisation, aquaculture expansion, industrial development, and rising seas. Protecting and restoring them is one of the most cost-effective climate adaptation strategies available.

Cyclones, conflict, and the road ahead

Ocean warming is also fuelling more powerful tropical cyclones. While the total number of storms may not be rising dramatically, a growing proportion are reaching extreme intensity. Cyclones Fani, Amphan, Tauktae, Yaas, Biparjoy, Remal, and Dana have all devastated coastal communities across the Indian Ocean region in recent years.

When intensifying storms combine with rising sea levels, their destructive reach extends deeper inland — threatening deltas, agricultural zones, ports, and entire coastal economies. Less discussed, but equally serious, is the environmental damage caused by armed conflict. Warships, explosions, attacks on oil infrastructure, and the destruction of coastal facilities all contaminate marine ecosystems. Oil spills in strategic waterways such as those in West Asia can devastate coral reefs, mangroves, and fisheries for decades. Environmental protection must be integrated into conflict prevention and post-conflict reconstruction efforts.

A shared responsibility

The solutions are not a mystery. Governments must accelerate low-carbon transitions, expand Marine Protected Areas, restore coastal ecosystems, and strengthen environmental enforcement. Industry must reduce plastic production and embrace sustainable practices. Communities can cut plastic use, support sustainable fisheries, and participate in coastal restoration. Internationally, cooperation must deepen because oceans belong to no single nation. The ocean has sustained human civilisation for thousands of years. On this World Ocean Day, the call is clear: we must now sustain it in return.

Protecting children in the digital age



VIPUL GAUR

“Privacy is not an option, and it shouldn’t be the price we accept for just getting on the Internet.” - Gary Kovacs

Children today are entering the digital world at an early age. Smartphones, online gaming platforms, social media applications and virtual classrooms have become an inseparable part of childhood. The COVID-19 pandemic further accelerated this transition, pushing millions of students towards online learning and digital interaction. While technology has undoubtedly expanded access to education and communication, it has also exposed children to unprecedented risks in the digital sphere.

A growing number of children are unknowingly sharing personal information across gaming platforms, social media applications and educational websites. In many cases, neither children nor parents fully understand how such data is collected, stored and used. The rise of targeted advertising, behavioural tracking and online fraud has made children one of the most vulnerable groups in the data-driven economy. In this context, the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 assumes critical importance.

The DPDP Act, 2023 is India’s primary law governing how personal data is collected, stored and used in the digital space. Under this framework, a Data Principal refers to the individual whose data is being processed, while a Data Fiduciary is the entity (such as an app, platform, or organisation) that collects and uses that data.

Under Section 9 of the said Act, special safeguards are provided for children’s online data. It mandates that digital platforms and data handlers must obtain verifiable consent from a parent or lawful guardian before processing any personal data of a child. It also restricts practices such as behavioural tracking, targeted advertising, and any processing that may adversely impact a child’s well-being. In principle, these provisions aim to ensure that children are not reduced to data sources for commercial exploitation and are protected from manipulative digital practices.

While the intent of the DPDP Act, 2023 is clearly protective, its implementation in the context of children raises practical concerns. The idea of “verifiable parental consent” assumes a level of digital awareness and supervision that may not exist uniformly across households. In reality, many parents themselves are not fully aware of how digital platforms collect and use personal data, and consent is often given mechanically through quick approvals rather than informed understanding.

At the same time, children today are active users of online games, social media platforms, and EdTech applications, many of which are designed to encourage constant engagement. In such an environment, distinguishing between meaningful consent and routine digital acceptance becomes increasingly difficult. This creates a gap between the law’s intention and its real-world effectiveness.

A significant part of this challenge emerges from the rapid digitisation of education itself. Schools and EdTech platforms today rely heavily on digital tools for attendance tracking, assignments, assessments, and communication with parents. While these systems have improved access and efficiency, they have also led to the large-scale collection of children’s personal data, often without a clear understanding among students or even parents of how this information is stored or used.

Many educational applications collect behavioural data such as login patterns, time spent on tasks, performance analytics, and interaction history. In some cases, this data is used not just for academic tracking but also for product improvement and user engagement strategies. This raises an important concern: data generated in the classroom is increasingly becoming part of a broader digital ecosystem, where the boundaries between education and data profiling are becoming blurred.

Beyond education platforms, children’s digital exposure is also shaped heavily by social media applications and online gaming environments. These platforms are designed around engagement-driven algorithms that encourage prolonged usage, often by analysing user behaviour and preferences. For children, this translates into continuous exposure to content tailored to keep them engaged, sometimes without a clear understanding of how these systems operate.

In such ecosystems, behavioural tracking becomes routine. Every click, interaction, and viewing pattern contributes to a digital profile that can be used to predict and influence future behaviour. The DPDP Act, 2023 seeks to restrict targeted advertising and tracking for children; however, enforcing these boundaries in fast-moving digital environments remains a significant challenge. The result is a space where children are active participants, yet largely unaware subjects of extensive data collection. The challenge, therefore, is not merely about the existence of a robust legal framework such as the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, but about ensuring its meaningful implementation in a rapidly evolving digital ecosystem. Protecting children online cannot depend only on formal consent mechanisms; it must also be supported by greater digital literacy among parents, educators, and children themselves. Schools and educational institutions must be encouraged to adopt transparent data practices, while platforms must be held accountable for designing child-centric and privacy-respecting systems by default.

At the same time, awareness around digital footprints and data sharing must become an essential part of early education. Without these complementary measures, the idea of “verifiable consent” risks becoming a procedural formality rather than a genuine safeguard.

Safeguarding children’s digital presence requires a collective effort where law, education, and technology work in alignment. It is only then that India can ensure that its youngest internet users are not merely participants in the digital world but are also adequately protected within it.



The writer is a Post Graduate in Law (LLM) from NLSIU, Bangalore and pursuing PhD in Cyber Laws from RGNUL Patiala

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From waste to wealth: Why India must get serious about biogas



KUSHAN MITRA

instrument. All of that is true. But unless the government builds a sensible policy architecture and a financially viable market structure, biogas will remain a useful concept trapped in pilot projects, small installations and optimistic speeches. That would be a mistake. In a country that produces huge volumes of cattle manure, agricultural residue and municipal organic waste, biogas is one of the few energy options that can simultaneously address emissions, waste disposal and fuel import dependence. It is a rare case where environmental logic and energy security logic point in the same direction. The climate case is straightforward. Organic waste releases methane, a greenhouse gas far more potent than carbon dioxide over the short term. Capturing that methane reduces the emissions problem at source. In other words, biogas is not merely about producing a green fuel; it is about preventing a worse one from entering the atmosphere in the first place. That distinction

India has a habit of discovering useful ideas and then burying them under slogans. Biogas is one such idea. It is routinely described as a clean fuel, a rural livelihood generator, a waste-management solution and a climate

matters because India’s biogas debate is often framed too casually. Not all biofuels are equally defensible. Crop-based fuels can raise questions about land use, food security and water stress. Waste-based biogas does not carry the same moral and economic ambiguity.

When the feedstock is cattle dung, municipal organic waste or agricultural residue, the equation is cleaner: the country is turning a liability into an asset. I recently travelled to Banaskantha district in Gujarat, where I saw firsthand how this can work. A tripartite venture between Banas Dairy, the local district dairy union, the National Dairy Development Board and Suzuki Research and Development India has created facilities where about 100 tonnes of cow dung are converted into biogas every day. The operation is industrial in scale, even if still modest in the larger national context, and the gas is sold directly to local transport users outside the plant.

This example from Gujarat points to the promise of the model, but it also reveals its limits. Such projects are viable only when multiple revenue streams are available. Gas sales alone rarely support the full economics. Plants also depend on slurry sales, fertiliser value, carbon credits and, in some cases, waste-processing fees. That is not a weakness of the model; it is the model. The problem is that policy in India still tends to treat biogas as a single-product energy business rather than a multi-product circular-economy system. That is where the government must become more serious. If it wants biogas to scale, it must stop thinking in terms of announce-



ments and start thinking in terms of market design. A biogas plant needs assured feedstock, predictable offtake, stable regulation and a financing structure that reflects its real cash flows. None of those things happens automatically. At present, the sector suffers from a familiar Indian policy problem: enthusiasm at the top, fragmentation on the ground. Municipal waste systems remain uneven, even though good work on waste-to-gas has been showcased in places like Indore. Agricultural residue collection is inconsistent. The case for biogas becomes even stronger when viewed through energy security. India still relies heavily on imported natural gas, much of it arriving as LNG from external suppliers and exposed to international price volatility. That dependence is not merely an economic issue; it is a strategic vulnerability. Every unit of domestically produced biomethane reduces that exposure, however incrementally. Biogas will

not replace LNG imports, but it can narrow the gap and improve resilience. In fact, when the gas shortage induced by the West Asia crisis occurred, industrial users across India were informed of a cut in supplies. This included the Maruti-Suzuki plant at Hansalpur, Gujarat. Production of gas from the Banaskantha Biogas facilities was diverted to Hansalpur and made up over half the shortfall according to Maruti-Suzuki officials. This is why the biogas conversation should not be reduced to environmental idealism or rural romanticism. It should be treated as industrial policy. A serious biogas ecosystem can create local jobs, improve sanitation, generate organic fertiliser that can help restore soil health, reduce methane emissions and lower foreign exchange outgo on imported gas. Few policy areas offer so many dividends from the same tonne of waste. But these require a sustainable financial model. That means the government must create conditions under which private capital can actually underwrite projects. Feedstock aggregation must be systematised. Municipal bodies, dairies, farmer collectives and cooperatives must be integrated into collection networks. Offtake contracts must be bankable. By-product markets must be formalised. Digestate standards must be clear. And if carbon credits are to be part of the revenue stack, the rules around verification and monetisation must be credible. This is the unglamorous part of clean energy policy. It is much easier to announce a target than to build the supply chain, legal framework and revenue certainty that make the target real. There is also a larger governance

lesson here. India’s waste streams are not going away. Its livestock numbers are not going away. Its municipal waste burden is not going away. These will only increase as the country gets richer and more urban. Nor is its appetite for gas likely to disappear soon. A policy that treats these realities separately is less useful than one that connects them. Biogas links agriculture to energy, sanitation to industry and climate policy to import substitution. That is why the government should be more pragmatic. It should encourage decentralised plant construction where feedstock is available, but not imagine that every district will support the same business model. It should recognise that some feedstocks and locations are better than others and that commercial discipline is not a betrayal of public purpose but a precondition for it. The ideal outcome is not a sector dependent on permanent subsidy. It is a sector where the economics make sense because the policy has been designed sensibly. If that happens, biogas can become what it ought to be: not a boutique environmental project, but a mainstream part of India’s energy and waste infrastructure. Biogas is one of the few solutions that can deliver measurable gains on emissions, waste and fuel imports at the same time. But only if the government stops treating it as a niche idea and starts treating it as a national necessity.

The writer is Director and the Printer & Publisher of The Pioneer

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Delhi CM attack case: Court denies bail to accused

A court here has denied bail to a man accused in a case related to the assault of Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at a public meeting, saying the allegations against him were grave and supported by material collected during the investigation. Additional Sessions Judge Nishant Garg was hearing a bail plea filed by Tehsin Raza, who was accused of conspiring with co-accused Sakriya Rajeshbhai Khimjibhai to kill the chief minister.

In an order dated June 6, the court said, "Considering the nature and gravity of the offence, the possibility of the accused fleeing from justice cannot be ruled out. Accordingly, I do not consider it to be a fit case for the grant of bail. The bail application is accordingly dismissed."

According to the prosecution, the incident occurred on August 20, 2025, when the chief minister was conducting a 'Jan Sunvai' programme. The main accused allegedly attacked her, pulled her hair, threw her to the ground and attempted to strangle her before being apprehended on the spot, the prosecution said. The court noted that during the investigation, the main accused disclosed Raza's alleged involvement in the conspiracy and claimed that he had shared with him videos taken during a recee of the chief minister's residence. The prosecution further alleged that call detail records showed the two accused were in touch with each other and that Raza had transferred ₹2,000 to the co-accused.

Delhi court denies interim bail to Al-Falah chairman in ED case

A Delhi court on Tuesday rejected the interim bail plea of Al-Falah University chairman Jawad Ahmad Siddiqui, accused in a ₹493-crore money laundering case being investigated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), saying that he failed to show that his wife required his exclusive care during cancer treatment.

Additional Sessions Judge Sheetal Chaudhary Pradhan was hearing the plea filed by Siddiqui seeking six weeks' interim bail to look after his wife, who is suffering from stage-4 metastatic ovarian cancer.

In an order, the court said, "Applicant has failed to show that the wife is terminally ill or is unable to take care of her daily routine and requires constant support of the accused/applicant and further, that there is no other adult member or caregiver, who cannot be made available for the wife".



(PTI)



Arbitration facing procedural hurdles: CJI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that international arbitration is increasingly facing procedural hurdles, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said mediation is no longer an alternative but an essential instrument to achieve timely, amicable and lasting resolution of disputes. He was delivering a lecture on "Mediation, Arbitration and the Courts: Converging Trends in the Indian and English Approaches in Commercial Dispute Resolution" at the Supreme Court of the United Kingdom on Monday.

Calling for a fundamental shift in how global corporations and legal systems approach conflict, the CJI said, "The primary question for a modern corporation should no longer be where to litigate, but rather how to resolve." He said courts, arbitration and mediation should

not be viewed as competing mechanisms but as complementary institutions serving distinct functions within a broader justice ecosystem. "We must reject the archaic narrative that pits alternative dispute resolution against the majesty of formal courts," he said.

"Traditional courts must continue to remain the ultimate guardians of public legal standard-setting and constitutional accountability. Yet, where the court provides the architecture of certainty, mediation serves as the adaptive mechanism for private commercial harmony. The two systems do not diminish one another; they sustain each other," he said.

At the outset, the CJI dealt with arbitration, especially international arbitration, as one of the important alternative dispute resolution mechanisms and referred to the difficulties being faced across jurisdictions in getting disputes resolved through this.



"It is my earnest belief that as international arbitration has increasingly mirrored the very procedural complexities it was designed to escape, it is mediation that now emerges as the authentic frontier of commercial agility," he said.

"Over the last several decades, arbitration has indubitably come to be viewed across jurisdictions as a response to some of the perceived limitations of court-centric adjudication, particularly in matters involving speed, technical complexity, party autonomy, and cross-border commerce," he said.

Kant said that in India, the Arbitration and Conciliation Act came into being in 1996, and various judicial interpretations also advanced "a pro-arbitration approach", keeping in harmony with internationally accepted principles governing commercial

dispute resolution. Indian courts have repeatedly reaffirmed the principle of minimal judicial intervention for preserving the sanctity of arbitral proceedings, he said. "However, despite its virtues, arbitration seems to be on the verge of inheriting some of the very procedural burdens from which it originally sought to depart. At least within the Indian justice delivery system, arbitral proceedings have generated an expanding parallel layer of litigation, where nearly every stage of the arbitral process becomes susceptible to judicial challenge between contesting parties," he said.

The CJI said arbitration proceedings get delayed due to questions on the very validity of the agreement, the appointment of arbitrators, the determination of the juridical seat, the distinction between seat and venue, issues of jurisdiction, and challenges to

interim or final awards that frequently travel before courts at multiple stages.

"This, of course, is by no means a concern confined to the Indian judiciary alone. Jurisdictions across the world appear to be grappling with similar difficulties, whether in the context of domestic arbitration or complex cross-border commercial disputes," he said. The consequence is that disputes that were intended to be resolved with efficiency and expedition can, at times, become drawn into prolonged procedural contests, he said, adding that even the United Kingdom is witnessing such hurdles.

"It is my earnest belief that as international arbitration has increasingly mirrored the very procedural complexities it was designed to escape, it is mediation that now emerges as the authentic frontier of commercial agility," he said, stressing the need to go for mediation.

Delhi HC can hear service termination cases of CAPF personnel, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday held that the Delhi High Court can hear service termination cases of members of the Central Armed Police Forces, including the Border Security Force, even if the cause of action arose outside the national capital. A bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma passed the order while reviving a petition filed by a BSF constable who had challenged his dismissal without any pensionary benefits.

The constable was dismissed on the ground that he had entered into a second marriage during the subsistence of previous ones and without the permission of his first wife. A show-cause notice was issued to him at Narayanpur in West Bengal's Malda district, where he was posted. The constable failed to submit a reply within the stipulated period. Consequently, the commandant in 2022 dismissed him from service without any pensionary benefits.

Aggrieved by the order of dismissal, the constable filed a statutory petition seeking reinstatement in service, which was rejected. Challenging the orders of



dismissal from service and rejection of his statutory petition, the constable moved the Delhi High Court, which rejected his plea applying the doctrine of "forum non conveniens" (an inconvenient forum). The high court said it would not be the appropriate or convenient forum for entertaining the petition.

The constable had argued before the high court that the petition was filed before it, as the offices of the Director General, BSF and the Ministry of Home Affairs are situated in Delhi.

"We hold that in case any member of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF), and that includes the BSF, is aggrieved by any administrative order of termination of his service issued by the competent authority, notwithstanding that the cause of action arose outside, i.e., the said order was issued from a place beyond the territorial limits of the Delhi High Court or that the events which triggered such an order occurred outside its limits, etc., still the Delhi High Court would have territorial jurisdiction in light of situs of office of the Union of India and the Director General, BSF/the officer in whom is vested supervision and command of the other CAPF, as per clause (1) of Article 226," the Supreme Court bench said.

The top court, in its judgment, said the doctrine of "forum non conveniens" has been misapplied by the high court in the context of writ jurisdiction referable to Article 226 of the Constitution. "Such an article permits filing of a writ petition as per the situs of office of the respondent(s) and cause of action, which gives the right of action. Where the question of pursuing a constitutional remedy is involved, and invocation of writ jurisdiction is traceable to clause (1) of Article 226, the doctrine of forum non conveniens may rarely apply," the bench said.

SC urged to order CBI probe in Tamil Nadu horse-trading row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A plea has been filed in the Supreme Court seeking a CBI probe against the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) general secretary and four others, who joined the ruling party in Tamil Nadu after resigning as AIADMK MLAs, for alleged horse-trading to form the C Joseph Vijay-led Government in the State.

The plea filed by M Srinivasan sought a direction to the CBI to register a case against TVK general secretary N Anand alias Bussy N Anand and four former AIADMK MLAs K Maragatham Kumaravel (Maduranthakam Assembly constituency), S Jayakumar (Perundurai), P Sathyabama (Dharapuram) and Esakki Subaya (Ambasamudram), who resigned as MLAs and joined the TVK on May 25 and 26. The plea filed through advocate Achintya Tiwari sought a direction to the CBI to complete the investigation and file a report within a time fixed by the court.

It prayed to the court to exercise the plenary power under Article 142 of the Constitution to frame specific rules for preventing horse-trading after elections about candidates who have either



been disqualified by the Speaker or those who have resigned from the Assembly without any valid, material and justifiable reason.

The petitioner also prayed for the grant of an injunction against the four former AIADMK MLAs from contesting the by-elections either independently or with the support of any political parties till rules are framed by the court.

"Issue a Writ of Mandamus or any other appropriate writ, order or direction thereby directing the Respondent Number 3 (Central Bureau of Investigation) to register the case against the respondents Nos. 07 to 11 herein for allegedly indulging in the horse trading to prove the majority in the Tamil Nadu Assembly and further direct to conduct the investigation and to file a final report within the time fixed by this

Court," the plea said.

On May 10, actor-turned-politician C Joseph Vijay took oath as the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu with a pledge that "a new era of real, secular, social justice starts now". The ascent of Vijay to the top job marks a significant realignment and a historic political shift in the state after his TVK emerged as the single largest party with 108 seats in the recent elections, shattering the decades-long dominance of the DMK and AIADMK in the state. Although TVK on its own did not secure the majority in the 234-member Tamil Nadu Assembly, Vijay managed to get support from the Congress, VCK, CPI, CPI (M) and IUML to gather 120 MLAs and cross the 118 mark to form the government, an act seen as a demonstration of his political adaptability beyond his image as a popular actor.

Patna Court stays arrest of Khan Sir till further orders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

A Patna court on Tuesday stayed the arrest of educator Faisal Khan, popularly known as 'Khan Sir', till further orders, his lawyer said. Khan was named in an FIR related to a firing incident by his guards a week ago when his coaching institute was allegedly vandalised by a bunch of miscreants.

"The court has stayed his arrest till further orders, and ordered to present case diary and other antecedents on the next hearing," Khan Sir's lawyer Arvind Kumar Mouar told reporters here in Patna. The educator had filed a plea for anticipatory bail on Monday.

"All the facts have been put before the court in accordance with law. After examining the case diary, the court is expected to pass the final order," the lawyer said.

He said that the next date has not been decided yet.

The court also asked for the case diary and antecedents in connection with the two guards who were



detained by police on Thursday, Mouar said.

"Their case is scheduled for tomorrow. The hearing will take place after the case diary is presented before the court," the lawyer said. The educator has received "protection from coercive action" and will cooperate with investigating officers for whatever queries they may have. A group of 15-20 persons allegedly vandalised Khan Global Studies Institute in the State Capital Patna on June 2 night and pelted stones at its premises. Police had on Thursday detained two guards associated with Khan Sir's coaching institute for allegedly firing shots on June 2 night.

TMC leader Jahangir Khan remanded to five days police custody by court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Diamond Harbour (WB)

Trinamool Congress leader Jahangir Khan, arrested on "extortion" and other charges, was remanded to police custody for five days by a court here on Tuesday.

Khan was arrested near the India-Nepal border in North Bengal's Panitanki area on Monday. He had unsuccessfully contested the Falta assembly seat in the West Bengal assembly election, and had not been seen in the constituency in South 24 Parganas district since a couple of days before the repoll in the seat on May 21.

The Diamond Harbour subdivisional court remanded Khan to police custody for five days in connection with seven FIRs filed against him at Falta police station on the prosecution's request.

The Calcutta High Court



had on May 26 vacated an interim protection granted to Khan, against whom seven FIRs were registered at Falta police station in South 24 Parganas district.

The high court granted protection from coercive action on May 18, only for Khan to participate in the repoll at Falta on May 21, the result of which was declared on May 24. Though Khan had prayed for and received interim protection from the high court on May 18 to participate in the repoll process and campaign for it, the very next day, he publicly announced his withdrawal from the contest.

Khan was produced before the court with a huge police and central force deployment amid apprehensions of protests by the public who had earlier vented their ire on the TMC leader's party office in Falta.

Sapna Choudhary gets interim protection in domestic abuse case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday granted interim protection to singer and actor Sapna Choudhary in proceedings initiated under the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act against her husband, restraining him from contacting or approaching her until the next date of hearing.

Judicial Magistrate Nidhi Singh was hearing the plea filed by Choudhary through her counsel, advocate Preeti Singh, seeking interim relief in view of the imminent premiere of her film and her apprehension regarding personal safety and possible disruption of professional commitments.

In an order, the court said, "Respondent (Choudhary's husband) is restrained from approaching the petitioner in any manner till the next date of hearing. Respondent is restrained from contacting the petitioner in any



manner or visiting her place of residence or work and committing any act of domestic violence till the NDOH (next date of hearing)."

According to submissions made by Choudhary's counsel, denial of immediate relief could expose her to irreparable harm, adversely affect her dignity and safety, and interfere with her professional engagements, including her appearance at the film premiere.

After considering the petition, affidavit and material placed on record, including photographs of alleged injuries and electronic evidence, the court found sufficient grounds at the preliminary stage to issue a summons and grant interim relief. The court further directed the protection officer and the local station house officer (SHO) concerned to ensure compliance with its directions and provide necessary assistance to the petitioner.

SC flags 40-year delay by Allahabad HC in murder case, seeks solutions to judicial backlog

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has expressed concern over the extraordinary delay by the Allahabad High Court in disposing of a 40-year-old criminal appeal filed by a murder accused challenging his conviction.

A partial working day (PWD) bench comprising Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and AS Chandurkar, on Monday, described the situation as disturbing and questioned what innovative measures could be adopted to address the mounting pendency that continues to clog the justice delivery system in the Allahabad High Court.

The case pertained to Vijay Singh who was 28 years old when he was arrested in November 1983 for allegedly shooting his brother dead. A sessions court at Kanpur convicted him of murder and sentenced him to life imprisonment in December 1985.

Singh challenged the verdict before the Allahabad High Court. However, his appeal remained pending for nearly 41 years before being dismissed by the high court through a 20-page



judgment delivered on February 9 this year.

During the hearing, the top court noted that Singh had spent only about three months in custody and remained on bail for almost 43 years while awaiting the outcome of his appeal.

The court decided to continue his bail during the pendency of proceedings before it.

The bench voiced concern over the recurring issue of prolonged delays in the Allahabad High Court, observing that litigants frequently approach the top court seeking directions for expeditious hearings because of heavy

pendency. Justice Mishra sought suggestions from senior advocate Siddharth Dave and advocate Zoheb Hossain on possible measures to accelerate the disposal of old cases. Dave suggested that prosecution appeals pending for more than three decades could be dismissed to reduce the backlog.

The bench, however, rejected the idea, observing that fundamental principles of adjudication do not permit dismissal of cases solely on account of prolonged pendency. The bench cautioned that such an approach could adversely affect public interest

and deprive parties of an opportunity to present their case.

In his appeal before the top court, Singh highlighted the prolonged delay, stating that he is now 72 years old and has spent his youth, middle age and old age under the shadow of a criminal conviction.

"For over four decades, through youth, middle age, and now old age, he has lived under the shadow of that conviction," the plea said, adding that his criminal appeal had languished before the high court for 40 years before being finally heard and dismissed.

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NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | JUNE 10, 2026

BUSINESS11

Flipkart partners with Meta for creator-led shopping

E-commerce major Flipkart has announced a partnership with Meta to enable creator-led shopping across social media platforms. Under the collaboration, content creators will be able to discover and tag products from Flipkart and Myntra directly within their Facebook posts and reels. They will earn a commission on every sale, while consumers will be able to purchase products directly by tapping the product tags, the company said in a statement. The initiative will initially be launched on Facebook, with Instagram scheduled for the next phase rollout. "Two years ago, Flipkart recognised that Gen Z was rewriting the rules of Indian retail. That discovery was moving from search bars to social feeds, and that creators were becoming the new storefront. This partnership with Meta is a natural extension of that conviction," said Flipkart Group CFO Ravi Iyer. "It gives creators a direct path from influence to entrepreneurship, and offers brands a way to reach consumers through content that feels real, not advertised," he added.

(PTI)

India exports GI-tagged Tezpur Litchi to Dubai

India has exported one tonne of GI-tagged Tezpur Litchi from Assam to Dubai, marking a step forward in promoting the premium fruit, known for its exceptional sweetness, bright-red colour and distinctive aroma, in overseas markets, the Commerce Ministry said on Tuesday. The ministry is promoting exports of agri products from the North Eastern Region. It said that the Tezpur region cultivates several notable varieties of Litchi, including Bombaya, Bilati, Elaichi, Piyaji and Sahi. "The Geographical Indication (GI) status has strengthened the identity and market recognition of Tezpur Litchi, enhancing its appeal among international buyers and creating new opportunities for premium agricultural exports from Assam," it said.

(PTI)

Govt publishes rules for setting up of coal exchanges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The government on Tuesday said it has published rules for setting up coal exchanges, a move aimed at bringing transparency and efficiency to the country's coal trading ecosystem and modernising the supply chain.

Coal exchanges are expected to enable transparent, market-driven price discovery, boost efficiency and give coal producers — including commercial and captive miners — easier access to a wider pool of buyers.

Public sector players can also use the platform to increase market participation. "The recently enacted Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2025 introduced the concept of a mineral exchange and empowered the central government to promote transparent and efficient trading of minerals, including coal and its processed forms. In pursuance of the above, the Coal Exchange Rules, 2026 have been published by the Ministry of Coal in the Official Gazette on June 4," the coal ministry said in a statement. The ministry has already designated the Coal Controller Organisation (CCO) in December 2025 as the authority responsible for registering and regulating coal exchanges.

Geopolitical shifts to boost indigenous tech: Survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's defence sector is expected to witness accelerated adoption of indigenous technology and a five-fold jump in job creation over the next three years amid geopolitical shifts and rising security challenges, according to a survey.

The new survey by Nexgen Exhibitions Pvt Ltd (NEPL) highlighted that international developments are poised to propel indigenous technology adoption in the sector to \$36.45 billion over the next three years, a surge that could unlock a five-fold expansion in the nation's defence-tech workforce.

In its latest survey, NEPL gathered insights from over 1,500 defence experts, defence tech startups, technology innovators, and industry stakeholders across Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai,

Bengaluru, and Pune. Amid global geopolitical shifts and rising security challenges, India is accelerating its transformation into a hub of indigenous technology and innovation in defence, a statement said.

This momentum builds on recent trends as the formal hiring in India's defence technology sector has nearly

He referred to the Prime Minister's "5F vision" — "Farm to Fibre, Fibre to Factory, Factory to Fashion, and Fashion to Foreign" — as a key framework guiding the sector's growth.

During the session themed "Strengthening India's Position in Global Apparel Trade: Opportunities, Challenges and the Way Forward," Kaushal outlined major initiatives such as the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme, PM MITRA parks, Mega Textile Parks, the National Technical Textiles Mission and various export promotion measures.

"These efforts have strengthened India's textile value chain and enhanced

Fitch cuts FY27 growth projection to 6.4%; US-Iran war to slow down economy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Fitch Ratings on Tuesday lowered its GDP growth projections for the current fiscal to 6.4 per cent from the earlier estimate of 6.7 per cent, saying that the US-Iran war will slow down the economy in the September and December quarters.

Fitch said it expects a slowdown in economic growth in FY27 from the 7.4 per cent clocked in FY26 as rising prices erode real incomes and dampen consumer spending, amid a resilient

capital expenditure.

"We expect GDP growth to ease to 6.4 per cent in FY27, a downward revision of 0.3pp from March. Domestic demand will be the main driver of growth, but lower

imports in real terms imply positive contributions to growth from net external demand," Fitch Ratings said in its June Global Economic Outlook.

Last week, the RBI had cut its growth forecast for the current fiscal to 6.6 per cent and upped its inflation projection to 5.1 per cent.

The rating agency said the slowdown in the economy will be most apparent in the second and third quarter of FY27, as rising prices due to the US-Iran war erode real incomes and dampen consumer spending. Fuel prices

have both risen by 4-5 per cent in recent weeks.

For FY28, Fitch expects GDP growth to pick up as the energy shock unwinds, with stronger consumer spending and investment translating to a growth rate of 6.7 per cent for the full financial year, and ease towards trend growth of 6.4 per cent in FY29.

Fitch has also lowered its 2026 forecast for global growth by 0.2pp to 2.4 per cent as world growth prospects have been hurt by the oil crisis prompted by the US-Iran war.

‘Online buyers losing up to ₹28,000 cr annually to dark patterns’

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Indian consumers are losing an estimated ₹25,000 crore to ₹28,000 crore annually due to deceptive interface designs, commonly known as dark patterns, across online marketplaces, according to a report.

The 'Dark Patterns in India's Online Marketplaces' report, released by market research firm Datum Intelligence on Tuesday, said 88 per cent of the country's 304 million online buyers lose approximately ₹78 to ₹87 per month each to hidden charges, forced add-ons, drip pricing, false urgency rules and subscription traps.

"Existing regulatory interventions

have so far had limited success in curbing deceptive digital practices that continue to impact millions of consumers," the report noted.

The survey found that 63 per cent of online payment users now experience hidden charges or drip pricing-where

additional fees are revealed at the checkout stage. This marks an increase from the 52 per cent reported in 2024.

Furthermore, 73 per cent of the platforms assessed deploy forced action mechanisms, compelling users into actions they might not otherwise choose.

The study analysed 12 leading platforms across e-commerce, quick commerce and online travel.

The survey was conducted in the first quarter of 2026 among 2,590 consumers across 50 cities.

Among e-commerce platforms, Amazon emerged as the most trusted, with 50 per cent of users naming it their preferred choice.

L&T betting big on digital workers, says CFO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Larsen & Toubro is betting big on automation, robotics and technology-led solutions to scale up construction activities as increasing manpower alone may not be a viable option for growth, a top official of the company said.

"What we have been doing over the last 3-4 years in particular is to create automation to the level that we did not expect construction industry to engage. Our effort has been to automate as much as possible," said L&T chief financial officer R Shankar Raman at ICICI Securities India Investors Conference 2026.

He said the company's order book has increased to around ₹7.5 lakh crore from ₹3-3.5 lakh crore five years ago, while the workforce engaged in execution has grown from 1.5 lakh direct and indirect workers to about 4 lakh.

Raman said the company is focusing on automation to address execution challenges and reduce dependence on traditional labour-intensive construction methods. "Our effort has been to automate as much as possible. Make construction not so much of a site work. Make it a bit of a factory work by having prefabricated structures, modular structures. So, you

go to the site and bolt them," he said. He said the company is using robotics for activities such as welding, painting and plastering, and described technology-enabled systems as 'digital workers'.

"Today, we are having welders who are robots controlled by a programme. We don't need to run around for welding skill in the country. We

have painters. We have people who do the plastering. All of that is being done by robots. So, in a way, you can call them digital workers," Raman said.

Raman said labour availability has emerged as a key challenge for the construction sector as workers today have more employment choices. "Today, thanks to the way certain sectors have developed, people have got a little easier option than to go work in 40 degrees and 45 degrees and sit in a camp working for 6 months, 9 months a year. It's not a preferred option. They are quite happy to open the mall doors staying in an air-conditioned environment. And that's reality of life," he said.

He added that workforce continuity is also affected by seasonal migration, agricultural cycles and workers travelling back to their villages.

Rajesh Exports founder denies fund diversion in ACC Energy, says Sebi misread entries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rajesh Exports Chairman Rajesh Mehta on Tuesday denied any fund diversion in its subsidiary ACC Energy and promoter-controlled Elest Ltd, saying Sebi has not understood the accounting entries, even as the company faces potential removal from the ₹18,100-crore ACC Production-Linked Incentive scheme.

"First of all, Sebi has made observations. That has to be put in the right place first. Point number two, there is zero diversion of funds. They have not understood the accounting entries," Rajesh Exports founder said. The company is ready to clarify, he added.

The market regulator's June 3 interim order flagged a circular fund-routing scheme involving ACC Energy Storage and promoter-controlled Elest Pvt Ltd. After Elest acquired 49 per cent of ACC Energy in January 2025, it gave ₹147 crore to the subsidiary, which

returned Rs 112 crore on the same day. ACC Energy Storage also invested ₹262 crore in Elest without disclosing valuation details. The company's MD and CFO admitted that they were unaware of the transactions, according to the order.

32,000 people displaced by Philippines earthquake

JIM GOMEZ/JOEAL CALUPITAN
■ General Santos (Philippines)

Rescuers searched ruined buildings in the southern Philippines on Tuesday to ensure no one was still trapped a day after one of the strongest earthquakes to hit the country in a half-century killed at least 37 people and displaced more than 32,000.

Only four people were considered missing on official records in the southern provinces near where the 7.8 magnitude quake struck Monday morning, but the Office of Civil Defence acknowledged several collapsed and heavily damaged buildings must be thoroughly inspected for possible survivors or casualties.

The earthquake centred off Mindanao, the second most populous Philippine island, injured nearly 500 people and displaced more than 32,000, most of whom fled to emergency shelters.

Many people who left their homes feared a tsunami. Waves up to 1.4 meters (4.6 feet) above tide level were measured in the Philippines, but the only tsunami damage reported was to six shanties



on stilts in a coastal village. Smaller waves washed ashore in Indonesia and Palau, and as far away as southern Japan.

The earthquake left a trail of destruction, including in General Santos, a lively coastal city of more than 700,000 people known as the country's tuna capital, where at least 13 people were killed in collapsed buildings and due to falling debris.

At least 18 died in Sarangani province, mostly in a landslide that buried houses in the mountainside town of Glan, according to Rafaelito Alejandro of the Office of Civil Defence.

The other deaths were reported in the southern

provinces of South Cotabato and Davao Occidental, and on Balut Island, disaster response officials said.

About 2,500 houses and 117 Government buildings and facilities were damaged in several provinces, according to an initial Government damage assessment. The international airport in General Santos remained shut for a second day, forcing the cancellation of 63 domestic flights except for those on humanitarian missions.

About 6,000 public school buildings in quake-hit provinces must be assessed before classes can resume. The quake struck on the first day of classes nationwide after a two-month summer

break, and many who sustained injuries were young students who had gathered with excitement for morning flag-raising ceremonies.

Authorities have warned that buildings that sustained cracks could collapse due to aftershocks, some of them dangerously powerful.

"We cannot force the immediate reopening of schools because we have to ensure the integrity of the buildings," Alejandro said.

Monday's earthquake was centred at sea at a depth of 33 kilometres (20 miles), about 32 kilometres (20 miles) southwest of Maasim town in Sarangani province.

It was set off by movement in the Cotabato Trench and was the strongest since the same undersea depression triggered an 8.1-magnitude quake that whipped up tsunami waves on August 17, 1976, said Teresito Bacolcol, the director of the Philippine Institute of Volcanology and Seismology.

About 8,000 people died from that quake and tsunami waves of up to 8 to 10 meters (26 to 33 feet) that engulfed several towns and provinces, Bacolcol said. (AP)

Congo's Ebola deaths rise to 100 out of 550 cases

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bunia

At least 100 people have died from Ebola less than a month after authorities declared an outbreak of the disease in eastern Congo, authorities said.

Attacks on health workers from angry residents, scepticism among some locals and armed conflict in hot spots continue to challenge efforts to stop the outbreak declared on May 15.

Out of the 550 cases of the disease confirmed as of Sunday, there have been 101 deaths and 19 recoveries, according to the latest situation report late Monday.

The outbreak is concentrated in Congo's eastern province of Ituri, which

accounts for more than 90 per cent of the cases. Cases have also been recorded in the North Kivu and South Kivu provinces, and have spread across the border to Uganda.

The number of cases in Congo is believed to be higher because the outbreak was confirmed weeks late, and the response has been challenging due to the lack of an approved vaccine or treatment.

The latest Ebola disease outbreak is caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus, which does not have an approved vaccine or treatment, unlike the "Zaire virus," another name for the Ebola virus, responsible for most of Congo's past 16 outbreaks of the disease.



Indian envoy meets US tech leaders, discusses future of AI



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Washington

India's Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra held a series of meetings with top American technology leaders and discussed perspectives on the trajectory of advanced technologies, including Quantum, and the future of AI. Kwatra held separate meetings on Monday to discuss investment expansion, supply chain resilience, and emerging technologies. He met the President and CEO of Walmart and had a conversation on their investments in India, to discuss investment expansion, supply chain

resilience, and emerging technologies," Kwatra said in a post on X on Tuesday.

In June last year, the then leadership of Walmart Inc met Prime Minister Narendra Modi and discussed the US-based retail giant's growing partnership with India.

In another meeting, he met the President and CEO of the Special Competitive Studies Project (SCSP). "Insightful conversation with @Ylli_Bajraktari, President & CEO of @scsp_ai, ahead of his upcoming visit to New Delhi for the India-US Forum," Kwatra posted. "Exchanged perspectives on trajectory of advanced technologies, including Quantum, and the future of AI, including Physical AI and the expanding India-USA cooperation in tech space," the post on X said.

Pilots safe after US helicopter crash near Strait of Hormuz, says Trump

JON GAMBRELL/
MICHELLE L PRICE ■ Dubai

A US Army helicopter crashed near the Strait of Hormuz, but President Donald Trump said the two crew members aboard were not injured in the incident near the strategic waterway that Iran has effectively closed during the war.

What caused the crash remained unclear Tuesday morning in West Asia, which was still reeling after Iran and Israel exchanged fire the previous day in the biggest blow yet to the straining ceasefire in the Iran war. Iranian State television reported Tuesday that the Israeli attacks killed at least two members of the country's air defence units.

Since the US and Israel began striking Iran on February 28, the war has shaken the global economy, driven up energy prices around the world and made many basics, including food, more expensive. Officials have been unable to turn the April ceasefire into a deal to permanently end the conflict, particularly as Israel intensifies and expands its military campaign in Lebanon against the Iranian-backed militia Hezbollah.

Trump, speaking to journalists at John F Kennedy International Airport in New York after watching the NBA



Finals on Monday night, acknowledged the crash. "The pilots are fine. Yeah," Trump said. "Nobody injured. We are going to issue a report tomorrow. But the pilots are fine."

The New York Times first reported that a US Army Apache attack helicopter went down near the strait in unclear circumstances. The US military's Central Command and the Defence Department did not immediately respond to requests for comment from The Associated Press.

Apache helicopters have been a key asset for the American military as they enforce a blockade on Iranian crude oil shipments and tankers, seeking to pressure Tehran into reaching a deal. The helicopters have also been used by the United Arab Emirates to shoot down Iranian drones during the Iran war.

Trump also expressed

renewed optimism over negotiations with Iran.

"We have a good chance" of signing a deal in "two or three days," Trump said. But he didn't provide any details on why there was reason for new optimism. Trump has repeatedly predicted that a deal is near over the past two months since the US and Iran agreed to an initial ceasefire. "We're very close to having a very, very good, strong, powerful deal," the president said. "If we go and bomb - which we could do very easily if we want, and we spend another two or three weeks bombing - they'll have nothing left whatsoever. But you won't have the strait open for months."

He added, "If we do the bombing, you know, a lot of people are going to be killed. Who wants to do that? I don't." (AP)

Indian diaspora welcome court ruling striking down \$1,00,000 H-1B visa fee

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Indian diaspora organisations in the US have welcomed the federal court order of striking down the \$100,000 fee on H-1B visa applications, calling it a fair move to the employment-based immigration system.

On Monday, a federal judge ruled that the \$100,000 fee imposed by US President Donald Trump for H-1B applications was unlawful as it did not have the approval of Congress. The H-1B visa is a non-immigrant visa that allows US companies to employ foreign workers in speciality occupations that require theoretical or techni-

cal expertise. The technology companies depend on it to hire tens of thousands of employees each year from countries like India and China.

"We welcome the Massachusetts federal court's decision striking down the \$100,000 H-1B visa fee, which restores predictability and fairness to the employment-based immigration system," Khanderao Kand, Chief of Policy and Strategy at the Foundation for India and Indian Diaspora Studies (FIIDS), told PTI.

"All stakeholders connected with H-1B visas will heave a sigh of relief after the court order, but one wonders if this is truly the end of the matter," Sanjeev Joshipura, Executive



Director, Indiaspora, told PTI.

Kand said the court ruling was appropriate for preserving the US's competitive advantage in innovation, research, and entrepreneurship.

"Access to highly skilled global talent remains essential

for the continued growth of the US's technology, health-care, and advanced manufacturing sectors. The judgment reinforces the principle that major policy changes must be grounded in statutory authority and economic realities," he said.

Kand said FIIDS believes a balanced, merit-based immigration framework strengthens both US businesses and the broader economy.

Joshipura, however, struck a note of caution, saying the US administration might still create hurdles for H-1B visa holders through procedural matters that may not run afoul of the law.

"If the executive branch wishes to impose impediments on H-1B visa holders, as per the administration's stated policy preferences, then they might still be able to do so through procedural means that do not run afoul of US law," he said, citing the recent tussle between the administration and the judiciary. (PTI)

BSES

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE

Date: 10.06.2026

Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/ FK/CR/SI/1368	PROVIDING OF HYDRA CRANE UNDER FINANCIAL LEASE MODEL BASIS IN BRPL	1,60,000/-	23.06.2026. 15:30 HRS.	23.06.2026 16:00 HRS.

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/- (Non Refundable)

For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/ submission of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No: U40109DL2001PLC111527 Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER

PWD BUILDING

ASSAM:: GUWAHATI

No. CEB/CS/TB-IV(B)/08/2026/7

PRESS NOTICE

The Addl. Chief Engineer, PWD (Building). O/o the Chief Engineer. PWD (Building). Assam. Chandmari Guwahati-03 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites fresh bid for the work detailed in the (able below, from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal i.e.w www.assamtenders.gov.in

The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web portal www.assaintenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work (In Rs.)	Bid Security	Bid Processing Fee (In Rs.)	Completion period
1.	Construction of RCC(G+1) building for the District Commandant Office and Divisional Commandant Office - cum- Residence at home Guards UAD. Jorhat	1,03,66,912.00	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	2073.00	12 (Twelve) Months

(i) The value of work may change during uploading of DNIT for which no claim will be entertained

(ii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Building Documents.

Sd/-
The Addl. Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
O/o the Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03

DIPR/C/PIO/84/10-Jun-26



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Email-harcobank@harcobank.org.in

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

The e-tenders are hereby invited on behalf of Haryana State Cooperative Apex Bank Ltd under Three Envelope Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) Methodology for the following works to be carried out from the eligible parties as per details given below:-

Tender Ref. No.	Description of Item	EDP/2026-27/UPI/QCBS
	Request of Proposal for Selection of Single Technology Service Provider (TSP) for a UPI Acquiring Switch with end -to-end Merchant Lifecycle Platform (QR +Sound Box) on a hybrid CAPEX+OPEX (managed - services) model.	Rs. 100000/-
	Tender Fee (Non -refundable)	Rs. 1000/-+GST
	e-service Fees (Non - refundable)	Rs. 1000/-+GST
Start date and time of Bid preparation & submission on e - procurement portal		10.06.2026 10.00 A.İ
Last date and time for preparation & submission by bidders Bid		01.07.2026 03:00 PM
Date and time of Tender Opening (Eligibility Part -A)		02.07.2026 03.30 P.M
Date and time of Tender Opening (Technical & Financial Part-8 & C)	To be intimated to eligible bidders	
Last date and time for Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Bid submission		01.07.2026 03:00 P.M
Pre-bid meeting		19.06.2026 11:30 P.M

The complete bidding documents, fee details, technical specifications and key dates can be viewed / downloaded from the web sites <https://etenders.hry.nic.in/> and <https://harco.bank.in> Bid through any other mode shall not be entertained. Please note that Managing Director, HARCO Bank reserves the right to accept or reject the tendering process at any stage without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Managing Director
Haryana State Cooperative Apex Bank Ltd.

1184/11/108/2027/46040/C/27/7

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No.14846973M Hav/SHT Suradkar Santosh Ramesh, R/o- 11 Gut No. 27/01 Kamal Housing Society, Gofhne Tower, Bhavsingpura, PO/Teh/Dist- Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 431001, have changed my daughter's name from Aaradnya to Aaradnya Santosh Suradkar, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1308)C

I, Manisha Santosh Suradkar, W/o No.14846973M Hav/SHT Suradkar Santosh Ramesh, R/o- 11 Gut No. 27/01 Kamal Housing Society, Gofhne Tower, Pethenagar, Bhavsingpura, PO/Teh/Dist- Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 431001, have changed my name from Manisha Santosh Suradkar to Manisha S Suradkar, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1309)C

I, No.15432094W LNK Silambarasan A, R/o- 5/21 Nethaji Nagar, Reddiyur, Vaniyambadi, Dist- Vellore, Tamil Nadu- 635851, have changed my father's name in my service record from Ananthan to G Anandan, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1310)C

I, No.14688678F Nk Gohil Ramsinh Kachara Bhai, R/o- TO- Khandheri, TA- Veraval, PO- Lumbha, Dist- Gir Somnath, Gujarat- 362150, have changed my name from Rutawa to Gohil Ramsinh, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1311)C

I, Gan Gresh Thakur S/o Ramchander Thakur, R/o- KH-250, T-Huts, Chuna Bhatti, C B Industrial Area, Kirti Nagar, VTC: Ramesh Nagar H.O, West Delhi, Delhi- 110015, have changed my name from Gan Gresh Thakur to Gagaresh Thakur, for all purposes.

PD(1317)C

I, No.15432094W LNK Silambarasan A, R/o- 5/21 Nethaji Nagar, Reddiyur, Vaniyambadi, Dist- Vellore, Tamil Nadu- 635851, have changed my name from A S Jainish to Jainish S, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1318)C

I, Gohil Sumita Ramsinh, Wife of No.14688678F Nk Gohil Ramsinh Kachara Bhai, R/o- TO- Khandheri, TA- Veraval, PO- Lumbha, Dist- Gir Somnath, Gujarat- 362150, have changed my name from Gohil Sumita Ramsinh to Barad Sumitaben Kacharabhai, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1319)C

I, Rajat Chauhan S/O Vijay Pal R/O H.NO. 136, Khera Kalan, North West Delhi, Delhi-110082 declare that name of my father has been wrongly written as Vijaypal Chauhan in my all educational documents. The actual name of my father is Vijay Pal, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1320)C

I, No.1483758L NK, 236 ENGR Regt., Tourangbam Manitomba (ex-service man), a resident of Saiton Hleiyakon, P.O. Moirang, P.S. Phougakchao Ikhai, District: Bishnupur, Manipur, do hereby affirm that the correct names of my daughter and son are T. Christina Devi and Tourangbam Leisemba and their dates of birth are 24-02-2005 and 06-02-2010 respectively. The above names and dates of birth will be used in all future purposes.

PD(1321)C

I, S Jayasudha W/o- No. 15432094W LNK Silambarasan A, R/o- 5/21 Nethaji Nagar, Reddiyur, Vaniyambadi, Dist- Vellore, Tamil Nadu- 635851, have changed my name from S Jayasudha to Jayasudha N, vide affidavit dated 09/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1316)C

PROSPECT



CM Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma held discussions with BookMyShow Co-Founder & CEO Ashish Hemrajani and Naman Pugalia on expanding international events ecosystem of Assam and concert economy.



1st Amaravati FIDE Rating Chess Tournament Concludes at VIT-AP University

The VIT-AP 1st Amaravati FIDE Rating Chess Tournament, jointly organised by VIT-AP University and the Andhra Chess Association, concluded successfully on the evening of June 8, marking a significant milestone in the promotion of chess and intellectual sports in Andhra Pradesh. The eight-day tournament commenced on June 1, 2026, and witnessed an overwhelming response from the chess fraternity across India and abroad. A total of 943 players participated in the event, representing 21 states and 2 countries. Among them were 669 internationally rated players and 76 titled players, including International Masters, Candidate Masters, FIDE Masters, and other distinguished competitors. The tournament also showcased remarkable inclusivity, with participants ranging from 4 years of age to seasoned chess veterans. Winners in different categories were awarded with prize money and a trophy. A total cash prize to the tune of Rs 30 lakhs was rewarded to the winners of different categories. The championship attracted the attention of several eminent dignitaries and public representatives who visited the tournament during its course.

Assam, EU welcome launch of Blue Valley Cluster

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Government of Assam and the Delegation of the European Union to India on Tuesday welcomed the successful launch of the Blue Valley Cluster in Guwahati, focusing on Flavours, Fragrance and AYUSH. This initiative marks a significant step towards strengthening cooperation between Europe, Assam and the wider North-East region of India in developing ecosystems and value chains in sectors of mutual interest.

The Blue Valley Cluster (Flavours, Fragrance and AYUSH), led by the Assam Government, aligns with the priorities outlined in the EU-India Comprehensive Strategic Agenda agreed at the January 2026 EU-India Summit and, in particular with the Blue Valleys initiative. It represents an important milestone in translating the broader objectives of the India-EU partnership into practical cooperation at the regional and States level. It will serve as a catalyst for research, innovation, investment and industrial cooperation between European and Indian companies and entities.

The launch took place in



the presence of Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma; H.E. Hervé Delphin, Ambassador of the European Union to India; Sibi George, Secretary (West), Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India; H.E. Didier Vanderhasselt, Ambassador of the Kingdom of Belgium to India; senior representatives of the Government of Assam; members of the European diplomatic corps; representatives of the Federation of European Business in India (FEBI); industry leaders; institutional partners; and stakeholders from India and Europe.

The visit of a high-level Team Europe in Assam reflects the interest in turning opportunities into concrete cooperation with Assam and India's North-East, which is one of the fastest-growing economies in India. As India's gateway to the North-East and a bridge to wider regional markets, Assam is increasingly emerging as a strategic platform for advancing inter-national partnerships, strengthening sustainable value chains and fostering innovation-led industrial development.

A bilateral meeting between Assam Chief Minister

Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma and H.E. Hervé Delphin, Ambassador of the European Union to India, was held in the presence of Sibi George, Secretary (West), Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India.

The Chief Minister also hosted a roundtable luncheon interaction with members of the Federation of European Business in India (FEBI) and the European delegation, providing an opportunity for direct dialogue on investment prospects, industrial collaboration, technology partnerships, skilling initiatives and avenues for

strengthening business-to-business engagement between Assam and Europe.

HE Hervé Delphin, Ambassador of the European Union to India, said, "My visit in Assam is testament to our commitment to the Northeast Region, where we see immense potential in realising the priorities of the EU-India joint Comprehensive Strategic Agenda. Assam is blessed with natural resources and human talent. Its trailblazing spirit to embrace innovation in a sustainable and inclusive way and become a major economic hub and a connectivity gateway makes it a destination of choice for companies. The Blue Valleys initiative will serve as a corridor bringing together the European and Indian businesses. The objective is to build cooperation in value chains of common interest, while ensuring that it benefits the people and communities and ensure environmental sustainability."

Reflecting on the ongoing collaboration with Assam, he added, "From supporting CITIIS 2.0 in Guwahati to the Barak River Basin Management Action Plan, our collaboration with and in the State of Assam has been very positive, delivering tangible

results. Now, we're taking this cooperation to the next level: accelerating investment and industrial cooperation which can benefit the entire North-East and the region."

Assam Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma said, "Assam's partnership with the European Union reflects our shared vision of building resilient, sustainable, and innovation-driven economies that create opportunities for our people while strengthening India-Europe cooperation. We see immense potential for collaboration across strategic sectors including semiconductors and electronics, defence and aviation, tea, agarwood, organic foods, natural fragrances and flavours, and AYUSH-based wellness products, where Assam and the wider Northeast Region possess unique strengths and global market opportunities."

"Through initiatives such as the Blue Valleys platform, we aim to connect thousands of farmers, women-led self-help groups, startups, researchers, and industries with international value chains, enabling inclusive growth, technology transfer, quality employment, and sustainable prosperity across Assam and the Northeast," he added.

Meeting of National Level Policy Implementation and Monitoring Committee held in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

To strengthen and modernise the cooperative sector, the first meeting of the National Level Policy Implementation and Monitoring Committee constituted under the National Cooperation Policy-2025 was held on Tuesday at Atal Akshay Urja Bhawan, New Delhi.

The meeting was chaired by Dr Ashish Kumar Bhutani, Secretary, Ministry of Cooperation & Chairperson of the Committee. The Committee deliberated on the roadmap for the effective implementation of the National Cooperation Policy-2025, with special focus on institutional strengthening, coordinated action by Central Ministries, Departments, States and Union Territories, and National



Federation/Cooperatives for digital transformation, capacity building, membership expansion and cooperative-led inclusive and sustainable economic development.

The meeting was attended by Dilip Sanghani, Chairman, IFFCO; Siddharth Jain, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Cooperation; Anand Kumar Jha, Raman Kumar and Shiv Pal Singh, Joint Secretaries, Ministry of Cooperation; Vice-Chancellor, "Tribhuvan" Sahkari University, Chairman,

NABARD; and senior officers from various Central Ministries, national cooperative federations, cooperative institutions, States and Union Territories Governments.

Addressing the Committee, Dr. Bhutani called upon all stakeholders to work together to take the objectives of the National Cooperation Policy-2025 to the grassroots level. He said that strong, transparent and modern cooperative institutions will provide new energy to the rural economy and

make a significant contribution to the goal of Viksit Bharat @2047.

He underlined that the National Cooperation Policy-2025 provides a comprehensive framework to make cooperatives transparent, technology-enabled, professionally managed and member-centric economic institutions

During its deliberations, the Committee discussed the six strategic pillars of the National Cooperation Policy-2025, namely strengthening the foundation of the cooperative sector, making cooperatives vibrant and competitive, preparing cooperatives for the future, expanding inclusiveness and outreach, enhancing the role of cooperatives in new and emerging sectors, and connecting the younger generation with cooperative development.

CM Yogi directs officials to prepare new Uttar Pradesh Startup Policy-2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has directed officials to prepare the new Uttar Pradesh Startup Policy-2026 with the objective of making Uttar Pradesh the country's leading startup destination.

He said, "The state's young population, vast market, rapidly developing digital and industrial base, and investor-friendly environment have the potential to make Uttar Pradesh a national hub of innovation-driven economic growth. The new policy should empower the youth to become job creators rather than job seekers and give Uttar Pradesh a new



identity in the fields of startups and innovation."

During an important meeting on Sunday, the Chief Minister reviewed various provisions proposed under the Uttar Pradesh Startup Policy-2026. The Principal Secretary, IT and Electronics, informed the Chief Minister that the state has achieved significant success in developing its

startup ecosystem over the past few years. From being placed in the 'Aspiring Leader' category in 2018, Uttar Pradesh has progressed to the 'Top Performer' category in the Government of India's Startup Ranking 2025.

The Chief Minister said, "Startups in the state should receive the necessary support at every stage, from inception to expansion and global competitiveness."

He directed that provisions related to sustenance allowance, prototype grants, seed capital assistance, and incentives for patents and quality certifications should be made more effective in the new policy.

INNOV8 ADDS 100 SEATS AT ISBT CENTRE IN RAIPUR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

In a significant boost to Chhattisgarh's growing startup and innovation ecosystem, Innov8 has added an additional 100 seats workspace capacity at the ISBT Centre in Raipur in partnership with the Raipur Municipal Corporation.

The initiative is aimed at supporting the state government's vision of promoting entrepreneurship, digital innovation, and employment generation in emerging cities.

With this initiative, the total capacity has grown to 350 seats, with a growing number of startups, digital-first businesses, consulting firms, and independent professionals seeking flexible and professionally managed workspaces.

Speaking on the development, Ritesh Agarwal, Founder and CEO of PRISM (corporate parent of Innov8) said "Raipur represents the immense potential that India's emerging cities hold for the future of entrepreneurship and innovation. Through Innov8's expansion at the ISBT center, we are deepening our commitment to building world-class infrastructure as we believe the next generation of successful Indian companies will emerge not just from metros, but from ambitious cities like Raipur that are rapidly evolving into vibrant economic and innovation hubs."

DAILY SUDOKU

					3			
1		3	8				2	
9				3	2			1
		8	3		9			5
	1		6	8	5		7	
5			4		1	2		
3			7	6				2
	2				4	6		9
		5						

DIFFICULTY RATING:☆☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (9.6.26)

3	5	9	2	4	6	1	8	7
1	6	2	8	3	7	9	5	4
8	7	4	1	9	5	3	2	6
4	2	5	7	8	1	6	3	9
9	3	7	6	2	4	5	1	8
6	1	8	9	5	3	7	4	2
2	9	3	5	7	8	4	6	1
7	4	1	3	6	2	8	9	5
5	8	6	4	1	9	2	7	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

WEDNESDAY | JUNE 10, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
10						11	
				12			
13		14				15	16
17					18		
				19			
20	21					22	23
					25		
24							
				26			
27						28	
				29			
30							31

ACROSS

1 Gardening informant? (5)

6 Agitatedly paces the room (5)

9 Not much money for a half-hour with a horsey character (7)

10 Where there's not a Sassenach in sight? (5)

11 A vegetable container (5)

12 King who restyled his hair a lot (5)

13 An arrest made at Silverstone, say? (3,4)

15 Quietly do wrong, in a certain case (3)

17 God's is at the church (4)

18 City I named anew (6)

20 Persevered with the latest edition (6)

22 Beefy speculator? (4)

24 Still the old-fashioned typed heading (3)

25 On which to lie, being modest about something plucky! (7)

26 Soldier boy's forename? (5)

27 Pretend to be a cool-headed character (5)

28 Cilla's strange bloomer (5)

29 Ship a girl to town (7)

30 Beat Alf silly at the film centre! (5)

31 Certain material is sham to him (5)

DOWN

2 Curtis turned countryman (6)

3 English dialect some Scots use? (6)

4 Abolished tax on TV, say (3)

5 A long piece the band hasn't quite finished? (5)

6 Rags due for recycling in a tasteful coat (7)

7 Wild romp at the Albert Hall? (4)

8 Black stuff that's good for the car? (6)

12 What the optimist did when he'd got out of work (5)

13 Chummy, pig-headed mate (5)

14 Not quite the true way to have faith? (5)

15 Model for a mural? (3-2)

16 Well, we're out during the day, so hang around (5)

18 Fluid, methinks not writing fluid (5)

19 Incorrectly claimed to be curative (7)

21 It fulfils a signal need (6)

22 He made room at the top (6)

23 A glove mistaken for a food additive! (6)

25 Something to sit down and play (5)

26 Cinema version of "Soldier, Soldier" (4)

28 Cut and run, almost (3)

SOLUTION (9.6.26)

ACROSS

1. Len-O-an ear

6. E-lap-se

9. C-O-heres

10. Fits

13. No-ti-on

14. Di-sol-in

15. Twinkling

17. Merciless

18. Dog rose

19. Par-rot

20. Thai (tie)

23. Short-cake

25. With a Will

26. O-us-t

27. E-lap-se

32. Shake-down

34. Possessed

35. He-a-ten

36. Letter

37. Down

38. Retainers

39. Faith-less

DOWN

1. Ill-fated

2. Anything

3. Memo-rise

4. (The)ll-king

5. Misnomer

6. Tender-foot

7. Dr-astic

8. Stands-till

11. Er-a-s-e

16. Knotty

19. (R)IP-I-e

21. Hair restorer

22. Stops short

24. All-rounder

25. Wre (we)

28. Pen-a-lise

29. Ca-sh-e'd-in

30. Sudanese

31. Certain

33. A-part

34. Pu-t-o-ff

BRIEFLY

Saneeth enters Australian Open men’s singles main draw



India's Saneeth Dayanand advanced to the men's singles main draw of the Australian Open badminton tournament after winning his qualifying matches here on Tuesday. Dayanand, seeded fourth in the qualifying rounds, first eased past local hope Karono 21-17 21-15 before logging a 21-9 21-16 victory over Malaysia's Ming Hong Lim to make the cut. He will face China's Hu Zhe An in his opening main draw game. However, Manraj Singh lost his second qualification match, to Malaysia's Eugene Ewe 11-21 18-21, to bow out of the competition. In the men's doubles main draw, it was curtains for the Indian pair of Achutadiya Rao and P Arjun Reddy after they went down to the Australian combination of Kanki Igawa and Ooi Yi Hern 15-21 15-21 in their opening game. The tournament's main singles competition will get underway on Wednesday where India's challenge would be spearheaded by two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu. Sindhu, seeded third, will open against Peru's Ines Lucia Castillo and is likely to face the winner of the first-round clash between Isharani Barua, Han Qian Xi. (PTI)

Japan has high World Cup expectations: Wataru Endo



Wataru Endo made clear Monday night that Japan has very high expectations for the World Cup. "We will do our best with pride and passion to achieve something that we've never seen before in Japan's soccer history," Japan's captain said. The Liverpool defensive midfielder and his teammates spent nearly an hour at an open practice jogging around the pitch at GEODIS Park, home of Major League Soccer's Nashville club, after arriving earlier Monday. Nashville is home before Japan opens the World Cup on Sunday against the Netherlands in Arlington, Texas, in Group F. More than 5,000 fans were in the stands watching the open practice. While some traveled from Japan, others came from Michigan, Atlanta and even Austin, Texas, for a glimpse of the Samurai Blue. Japan wrapped up the nearly one-hour session with players taking turns tossing or handing gifts to fans. Takuru Kaya and his son, Yuhi, wore team gear after driving from North Carolina to support Japan. Kaya said his son's favorite player is Brighton & Hove Albion winger Kaoru Mitoma, who was left off the squad with an injured hamstring, but that his son was excited to see other players like midfielder Junya Ito. (AP)

Zverev’s French Open triumph receives muted reception in France due to off-court issues

SAMUEL PETREQUINAP ■ Paris

Alexander Zverev's victory at the French Open did not dominate the headlines in France on Monday as is normally expected for the men's singles champion.

Most noticeably, his win was reduced to a minor mention on the front page of sports daily L'Equipe, the country's main sports newspaper, which published an editorial highlighting accusations of domestic violence that the German player has faced.

Zverev won his first major title on Sunday in Paris when he defeated Flavio Cobolli in five sets.

L'Equipe instead dedicated its front page to handball team of Metz, which became



first French club to lift the Champions League women's trophy. There was just a small picture of Zverev on the top left corner of the main page, with the headline "Zverev, major at last."

In addition to its coverage of the final, L'Equipe published an op-ed headlined "To live with" that focused on past accusations against

US team settles into WC training base with gratitude for fan support

GREG BEACHAM
■ Irvine (California, USA)

The US national team already knew it was in for a once-in-a-lifetime experience this month as the home team in a World Cup. But when the 26 players took the field at Orange County's Great Park on Monday to the cheers of several thousand fans who had turned out just to watch a mere practice, they were given yet another reminder of just how special this opportunity will be if they seize it.

The Americans projected confidence and excitement as they settled into their training base for at least the next three weeks in Southern California. The team convened in Georgia last month before playing two friendlies in the past eight days.

All three of the Americans' World Cup group stage matches are on the West Coast, starting with their opener Friday night against Paraguay at SoFi Stadium, the palatial NFL arena about 50 miles away in Inglewood, California.

"I think the group is in a



really good place at the minute," US captain Tim Ream said. "We've all been, I wouldn't say overwhelmed, but pleasantly surprised by the excitement and the buzz around the team and in the stadiums. Pulling up here with 5,500 fans ready to watch a training session is incredible. I just think we're in a good place mentally right now. It's been a long two weeks, a hard two

weeks, but guys are in a great position mentally, physically and emotionally, and ready to get going."

The team was greeted in Irvine by rows of enthusiastic fans who won a multi-stage lottery among 32,000 applicants for the chance to watch practice and to get autographs at FIFA's Community Day event. US coach Mauricio Pochettino entertained the crowd and

got a "U-S-A!" chant going while his team was doing a brief gym workout before it got on the grass.

"The facilities are amazing," Pochettino said. "It's more than we expect, and not only the facilities, but the people who are here working. Great facilities and great people are an amazing combination. We are grateful, and I want to say a big thanks." (AP)

Gukesh can take inspiration from Praggs’ perseverance and script turnaround: Anand

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Legendary Viswanathan Anand hailed R Praggnanandhaa's highly competitive style of play, and urged the struggling world champion D Gukesh to take a leaf out of the book of newly-crowned Norway Chess champion to script a turnaround.

Praggnanandhaa recently became the first Indian chess player to annex the Norway title, but Gukesh finished sixth in the tournament.

"I am delighted that Praggnanandhaa has won Norway Chess in an impressive style. I am very happy at the spectacular turnaround (he made) in the last four rounds. He is playing the game with some amazingly impressive concepts and style," Anand said.

Anand advised Gukesh, who is scheduled to face Javokhir Sindarov in his title defence later this year, to take "inspiration" from Praggnanandhaa.



"At this moment, Praggnanandhaa is playing better than Gukesh but anything can change. I think there will be form swings repeatedly. Gukesh seems to be stuck a bit. I think he can take inspiration from Praggs."

"He can see that if you persist with hard work then at some point things will change," he added. Viswanathan Anand said Praggnanandhaa is always "ready for a fight" on the board, and the attitude helps him produce some interesting concepts while playing.

"Actually, it's the same Praggs in the last one and half years. Sometimes he plays hard and comes out with interesting concepts, and he is always ready for a fight. The results might not always work out."

"In fact, after the first six rounds, you can't see much difference from the last 8 or 9 months (as in how Praggnanandhaa plays). But then there was this great turnaround and that was really nice to see because he played very interesting chess," he noted. (PTI)

Ridhima Dilawari looks to continue dominance as Hero WPGT tees off

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mysuru

Ridhima Dilawari, who won three of the six events in the 2026 Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour, will look to continue her dominance as the seventh leg gets underway in Mysuru.

The tournament at the Jayachamaraja Wadiyar Golf Course heralds the start of the second half of the 2026 domestic season. The Par-70 course will play to just under 6000 yards.

Ridhima won the second, fourth and sixth legs of the Tour and holds a sizeable lead over the field on the Hero Order of Merit standings.

Of the remaining three events, Jasmine Shekar, Tvesa Malik and amateur Lavanya Gupta won once each. This week Jasmine and Lavanya are not participating.

Ridhima's best season



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tijuana (Mexico)

FIFA has revoked the ticket allocation for Iran fans at the team's three World Cup games in the United States, the national soccer federation claimed Tuesday.

Each federation for the 48 teams taking part is entitled to receive and distribute 8 per cent of stadium capacity at the World Cup, adding up to several thousands of tickets for each game.

Just days before Iran opens its World Cup — on June 15 at the Los Angeles Rams' stadium in Inglewood against New Zealand — the federation claimed in a statement

reported by semi-official state media that it was now unable to provide any tickets to its supporters.

FIFA was approached for comment.

The claim adds to the turmoil between Iranian soccer, FIFA and tournament co-host the U.S., which began military attacks on Iran on February 28.

Iran's team is now based in the Mexican border city of Tijuana instead of its pre-war plan to train in Tucson, Arizona. Some federation officials also have been denied visas to enter the US, where Iran also plays Belgium in Inglewood on June 21 and then Egypt in Seattle on June 26.



was in 2019, when she won five times in 12 starts and was second behind Gaurika Bishnoi in the Order of Merit.

She won only once in 2025, but has been in great form as she divides her time between the Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour, the AM Green IGPL Tour and the Ladies European Tour, where she is hoping to get a few starts.

Ridhima will be up against Vani Kapoor, one of the most successful players ever on the Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour.

Vani, the 2025 Hero Order of Merit winner with five wins, is looking to get her first win of 2026 after having played only three of the first six events this year.

The experienced Amandeep Drall, Tvesa Malik, the Hero supported player, Neha Tripathi, a resurgent Jahanvi Bakshi, Shweta Mansingh, Durga Nittur, Anvitha Narender, Sneha Singh and Khushi Khanijau too will be hoping to make a mark.

The strong field includes promising young professionals like Mannat Brar, Vidhatri Urs, Heena Kang and others.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of JATIN SHARMA to inform to the public at large that Smt. Shyam Lata who Sh. Radhey Shyam is the owner of ENTIRE BUILT UP PROPERTY BEARING NO. C-22, LAND AREA MEASURING 41.8 SQ. METERS EQUIVALENT TO 50 SQUARE YARDS, (SIZE 16 X 28) OUT OF KHASRA NO.102/5, (OLD KHASRA NO.2732/2153), GALI NO. 81 SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE MUNDKA, MORE KAMRUDDIN NAGAR, DELHI AND COLONY KNOWN AS AMAR COLONY, ON MAIN ROHTAK ROAD, NANGLOI, DELHI-110041 vide Regd. Gift Deed dated 03.06.2026, Doc. No. 2026/614460, SR-West Punjabi Bagh, Delhi which was executed by Sh. Radhey Shyam in her favour. Now, Sh. Jatin Sharma & Smt. Shyam Lata intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP A-161, Ground Floor, Sakra Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

Infantino targeted in fresh criminal complaint by his former boss Platini

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Geneva

FIFA president Gianni Infantino was targeted by a revived criminal complaint in France on Monday by his former boss Michel Platini, who seemed destined to lead FIFA until being implicated in a financial wrongdoing case in 2015.

French soccer great Platini — who was acquitted again last year after a second Swiss court trial — has asked lawyers in Paris to file a criminal complaint against Infantino and five other Swiss soccer and political prosecution officials. He alleges a conspiracy of false accusation and influence peddling to prevent him from becoming FIFA president a decade ago.

Lawyers also will file a civil lawsuit seeking damages from FIFA, a spokesman for Platini said in a statement about the allegations, which were previously made in 2022 directed at Swiss authorities. The fresh filings were announced three days before Infantino opens a World Cup being played across North America that has let him often share a political stage with US President Donald Trump.

FIFA was asked for comment about Platini's legal complaints.

Infantino was elected FIFA leader in 2016 as a surprise candidate from European soccer body UEFA, where he was the long-time general secre-



tary to its president Platini.

Platini was widely expected in soccer circles to become FIFA president and succeed his former mentor Sepp Blatter, who was leaving office in fallout from U.S. federal investigations of corruption among soccer officials that were unsealed in May 2015.

However, four months later, both Platini and Blatter were targeted in a separate Swiss investigation of a 2 million Swiss francs (\$2.5 million) payment to the Frenchman that would remove both from office early.

Both Platini and Blatter were acquitted twice on charges of defrauding FIFA when they jointly stood trial in Switzerland in 2022 and again last year on appeal by the federal prosecution office.

The five men also targeted by Platini's criminal complaint include Switzerland attorney general in 2015, Michael Lauber, and FIFA legal director at that time, Marco Villiger. (AP)

Somali World Cup referee who was denied US entry was set to make history history for his country

OMAR FARUK/GERALD IMRAY
■ Mogadishu (Somalia)

The World Cup referee from Somalia who was denied entry to the United States after arriving in Miami and subsequently dropped from the tournament by FIFA was set to make history for his country.

Omar Artan was due to be the first referee from Somalia to officiate at the World Cup after making FIFA's final list for the tournament, which was announced two months ago. He is one of Africa's top referees and was named the continent's best male referee in 2025 by the African soccer body.

He was denied entry at Miami International Airport on Saturday over "vetting concerns," US Customs and Border Protection said in a statement



without giving details of those concerns. Artan was issued a visa to travel to the US last week, according to the Somalia Embassy in Kenya that processed it. (AP)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, Sonipat (Tender Notice)

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

Tender No. 17-RCNK-OPN-TELE-2026 Dated: As Signed

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at:- Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No. 17-RCNK-OPN-TELE-2026

Name of Work and its location: Operation & Periodic maintenance services for Telecom Infrastructure & Public addressing System at Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat for 02 years (As per Scope of Work)

Approx Cost of work: Rs. 42,31,462.64/- including GST @18% (Rs. Forty-Two Lakh Thirty-One Thousand Four Hundred Sixty-Two and Sixty-Four Paisa only)

Earnest Money Rs. 84700.00/-

Completion period of work 24 months (02 YearS) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance

Cost of Tender document (In Rs) NIL

Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender: Up to 15:00 hrs on 01/07/2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day.

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen: Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

1971/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

BEFORE DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL -II, DELHI.

4th Floor Jeevan Tara Building Parliament Street New Delhi - 110001.

Notice under section 19(4) of the Recovery of Debts Due to Bank and Financial Institutions Act 1993 read with rule 12 & 13 of the Debts Recovery Tribunal (Procedure Rule) 1993) in the matter of

OA NO 621/2022 DATE: 01.01.2026

J C FLOWERS ASSET RECON. PVT LTD INSTEAD OF YES BANK APPLICANT

VERSUS RESPONDENT

THREE C PROPERTIES PVT LTD

To, DEFENDANT

D3. LOTUS GREENS LLP

Flat No 14 Ground Floor Pulphelad Pur DDAMIG Suraj Apartment New Delhi - 44

Whereas the above named applicant (s) has / have instituted a case for recovery of Rs. 48,17,14,972.79 1- (Rupee Forty Eight Crore Seventeen Lakh Forteen Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy Two And Seventy Nine Paise Only) against you and where as it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in the ordinary way therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance in the Tribunal on 09.06.2026 At 11.00 A.M.

Take notice that in default of your appearance on the day before the mentioned, the case will be heard and determined in your absence.

All the matters will be taken up through video Conferencing or physical and for that purpose:-

(I) (OAll the Advocates/Litigants shall download the "Cisco Webex" application/software:

(II) "Meeting ID" and Password for the date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/ Registrar shall be displayed in the daily cause list itself at DRT Official Portal i.e. drt.gov.in

(III) In any exigency the Advocate/Litigants can contact the concerned official at Ph. No. 23748478.

Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal this the 01st day of Jan, 2026

BY ORDE OF THE TRIBUNAL SECTY OFFICER DRT-II, DELHI

Red-ball cricket meant everything to me: Suthar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

For Manav Suthar, Test format is the “pinnacle” of cricket, and the India left-arm spinner revealed that he was practising with red-ball even during IPL 2026 to stay on top of his game.

The 23-year-old Suthar made a strong impression on his maiden outing, returning 6/33 and 1/29 along with a brisk knock to set up a heavy innings and 300-run victory over Afghanistan in their only Test.

“From the very first day I started playing and as I progressed through the ranks, red-ball cricket meant everything to me,” Suthar told JioHotstar.

“It is the pinnacle of the sport. So, whether I was playing U-19 cricket or the Ranji Trophy, the goal was always to play Test cricket for India. Kuldeep (Yadav) bhai’s speech while presenting me with the cap was very motivating. Everyone encouraged and motivated me a lot, so it felt really special.

“Gautam (Gambhir) sir and the skipper



(Shubman Gill) informed me that I would be making my debut. It was a very proud moment because, ever since I started playing, it had been my dream, my father’s dream, and everyone’s dream for me to play Test cricket for

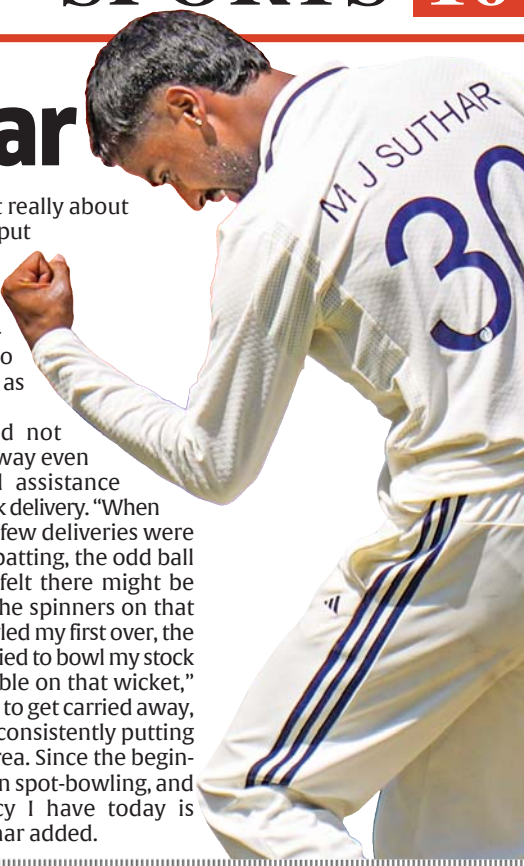
India,” Suthar added.

Suthar, who played for Gujarat Titans in this year’s IPL, said he wanted to be ready for the opportunity of playing Test cricket and practiced with the red ball during the league.

“When my name came up in the team, I was practising with the red ball during the IPL as well, thinking about how I would approach things if given the opportunity,” he said. “After coming here (Mullanpur), I had three or four long practice sessions.

With bowling, it’s not really about how many hours you put in. If you enjoy bowling, you can bowl 20-25 overs without even realising it so the key is to keep bowling as much as you can.”

Suthar said he did not want to get carried away even as the pitch offered assistance while bowling his stock delivery. “When they were bowling, a few deliveries were turning. When I was batting, the odd ball was holding up so I felt there might be some assistance for the spinners on that track. As soon as I bowled my first over, the ball was turning, so I tried to bowl my stock ball as much as possible on that wicket,” he said. “I didn’t want to get carried away, but my focus was on consistently putting the ball in the right area. Since the beginning, I have focused on spot-bowling, and whatever consistency I have today is because of that,” Suthar added.



We have crossed the line once and can do it again: Jemimah on upcoming T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India are not lacking in self-belief after their historic women’s ODI World Cup triumph last year and they are the “favourites” to win the upcoming T20 World Cup in England, says star batter Jemimah Rodrigues.

The women’s T20 World Cup begins on June 12, and India play their first match on Sunday against Pakistan in Birmingham. New Zealand are the defending champions while South Africa ended as runners-up in the last edition in 2024.

India are placed in the six-team Group A along with Australia, South Africa, Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Netherlands. Two teams from the group will qualify for semifinals.

“Everyone was a part of it (the ODI World Cup win); they know what pressure feels like and, at the same time, everyone knows that we’ve crossed the line once and can do it again. That belief rubs off,” Jemimah said on JioStar’s ‘Champions Huddle’.

“But when you win one, you don’t want to stop there. You want to make it two, three, however many you can. Our fans make us



feel at home wherever we go. So, yes, we are the favourites, no doubt about that.”

The 25-year-old Jemimah was one of the stars of India’s maiden ODI World Cup triumph in 2025 at home.

“Many times, we visualise success so much, but now we’ve actually lived it. That helps us believe even more that we can do it again. It’s great to have so many members from the 2025 World Cup squad in this team, along with a few more youngsters coming in. I think the energy will rub off on them. Everyone is going to share their experiences,” she said.

India captain Harmanpreet Kaur said the ODI World Cup win has boosted the team’s confidence of bagging more global events.

“Yeah, 100 per cent. I think everybody

will agree with me that life has completely changed after winning our first ODI World Cup. Hopefully, we’ll continue this run of winning trophies.

“This is what I want as a captain, and I think it’s what everyone in our team has been dreaming of. Hopefully, we’ll continue moving in this direction.”

India head coach Amol Muzumdar said his team wants to make winning a habit.

“There’s pressure in every tournament, and the players are used to it. They’ve been playing international cricket for some time now. We’ll be going in as ODI World Cup champions for the first time,” he said.

Siraj advised rest; Prasidh named replacement for Ireland, England tours

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

Mohammed Siraj has been rested as part of workload management, with Prasidh Krishna named as his replacement for Ireland and England tours, the BCCI said on Tuesday.

The Indian Cricket Board described the move as a “precautionary measure” to ensure quick recovery ahead of the long international season.

Siraj was named in the squad for the Ireland and England series consisting of two and five T20Is respectively.



tively but was not picked for the Asian Games in Japan.

“Fast bowler Mohammed Siraj has been withdrawn from India’s squads for the upcoming T20I series against Ireland and England,” the BCCI said in a statement.

“Following discussions between the BCCI Medical Team and the Team Management, Siraj has been advised a period of rest as

part of his workload management programme.

“The decision has been taken as a precautionary measure to ensure adequate recovery ahead of a long international season. The Men’s Selection Committee has named Prasidh Krishna as Siraj’s replacement for both T20I series,” the BCCI added.

Siraj was a late addition to the Indian squad in their last T20I assignment - the T20 World Cup - while he played in each of the 17 matches for Gujarat Titans in the IPL 2026, taking 19 wickets.

The right-arm pacer was also a part of the one-off Test against Afghanistan which ended inside three days on Monday.

Updated squad for Ireland and England tours

Shreyas Iyer (c), Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson (wk), Ishan Kishan (wk), Shivam Dube, Tilak Varma (vc), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Varun Chakravarthy, Ravi Bishnoi, Harshit Rana, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Prasidh Krishna.

Lord’s and Gaddafi Stadium pitches rated as unsatisfactory



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

The pitches used for the first Test between England and New Zealand at Lord’s in London and the third ODI between Pakistan and Australia at the Gaddafi Stadium in Lahore have been rated as “unsatisfactory” under the ICC Pitch and Outfield Monitoring Process.

The two venues have been handed one demerit point each after match referees Andy Pycroft (Lord’s) and Graeme La Brooy (Gaddafi Stadium) submitted their respective reports, highlighting concerns raised by match officials and captains.

Pycroft said the Lord’s pitch offered excessive seam movement throughout the Test and the ball also stayed extremely low on several occasions, resulting in variable bounce. “There was plenty of excessive seam movement throughout the Test and the ball also kept extremely low on several occasions. The bounce was variable throughout as 16 wickets fell on the first day and 17 on the second,” he said.

“There was simply an over-balance in favour of ball against bat caused by the pitch,” Pycroft said about the Lord’s pitch.

England defeated New Zealand by 115 runs on Day 4 of the first Test match at Lord’s. Set a target of 254 runs to win, the tourists were bowled out for 138 in their second innings, giving England a 1-0 lead in the three-match series.

On the Gaddafi Stadium surface, La Brooy said the pitch was slow and low, making it difficult for batters to score runs and unsuitable for a One-Day International. “It did not suit an ODI game as batters had to spend more time to settle in.

Hardik, Rohit get all-clear for ODI return from CoE

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

Star all-rounder Hardik Pandya and senior batter Rohit Sharma have been cleared by the Sports Science team of BCCI’s Centre of Excellence (CoE) to participate in the upcoming three-match ODI series against Afghanistan starting on Sunday in Dharamsala.

Both Pandya and Rohit missed quite a few IPL matches for Mumbai Indians due to their respective issues. While Pandya was battling back spasms, Rohit had a hamstring niggle. Hardik has been at the CoE in Bengaluru since June 2.

“Hardik was on a holiday abroad before he checked in at the CoE on June 2. Over the next five days, he did several match simulations and even bowled 10 overs,” a BCCI source said.

“There has been no discomfort and the information is that his fitness data for various parameters has been okayed by Strength and Conditioning coaches at the CoE,” the source added.

Former skipper Rohit was also



at the CoE to assess his hamstring niggle and he too has been given the go ahead after an examination.

On Monday, India’s assistant coach Sitanshu Kotak had said that although he doesn’t have an

update on Pandya’s fitness status, he believed the all-rounder was doing fine.

Pandya is an important cog in India’s white ball set up given the balance he lends to the side with his pace bowling and lusty hits

PANDYA IS AN IMPORTANT COG IN INDIA’S WHITE BALL SET UP GIVEN THE BALANCE HE LENDS TO THE SIDE WITH HIS PACE BOWLING AND LUSTY HITS DURING DEATH OVERS

during the death overs.

The most relieving aspect is that Pandya is bowling 10 overs in training session which means that he is ready for the rigours of 50-over cricket.

It is, however, not clear whether Pandya will join with the team in Chandigarh for a training session under lights or directly link up in Dharamsala which was the original plan.

Star batter Virat Kohli is already missing the series owing to a hamstring injury. Apart from Dharamsala, the rubber features games in Lucknow and Chennai on June 17 and June 20 respectively. (PTI)

Rain washes out the 3rd ODI between West Indies, Sri Lanka

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Kingston (Jamaica)

The third one-day cricket international between West Indies and Sri Lanka went the same way as the second and was washed out Monday without a ball being bowled. Umpires made the decision just after 6 p.m. local time to call off the match because the outfield couldn’t be made ready for play even if the rain abated.

Sri Lanka won the first match of the series by 41 runs for its first ODI win in the Caribbean in 13 years. The two subsequent washouts have given Sri Lanka a 1-0 series victory.



“We’re very happy to win the series,” Sri Lanka captain Kusal Mendis said. “We did really well in that one game in all three departments.

“There’s not a lot of matches ahead of next year’s World Cup and I’m happy with my first series victory as captain.”

The series win was also the first for Sri Lanka’s new coach, former South Africa star Gary Kirsten.

India A pull off a heist in Dambulla after Gaikwad’s hundred

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dambulla

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi’s first outing for India A in one-day cricket ended with a muted 14 but his team hung in there till the end against a self-destructing Sri Lanka A to pull off an eight-run win in the tri-series opener here on Tuesday.

Chasing 278, Sri Lanka A had the game in the bag after captain Sahan Arachchige made a sublime 74 off 72 balls. However, the inexplicable loss of last four wickets in 10 balls, including three in the final over from pacer Arshad Khan, gave India A a narrow win. The seasoned Rituraj Gaikwad made a composed 101 to lead India A to 277 for six. The spin duo of Ayush Badoni (2/46) and Anukul Roy (2/49) kept India in the game after the pacers, especial-



ly Anshul Kamboj, leaked runs early in Sri Lanka A’s chase.

Sahan, who has played international cricket, got his team on the cusp of victory before being bowled by a sharp yorker from Kamboj. Too many soft dismissals towards the end of the innings handed the Tilak Verma-led side

a sneaky win.

India A will next play Afghanistan A here on June 11.

The game also marked the comeback of Niroshan Dickwella (47 off 45) who shared an opening-wicket stand of 93 with another Sri Lankan international Avishka Fernando (45 off 59). Both the

Stokes, Atkinson risk being dropped from England team



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

England captain Ben Stokes and teammate Gus Atkinson are at risk of being dropped from the second test against New Zealand for breaching team protocols.

The England and Wales Cricket Board said on Monday the pair was involved in an incident in the early hours while celebrating beating New Zealand at Lord’s on Sunday.

“Ben Stokes and Gus

Atkinson were present at a nightclub in the early hours of Monday morning when an incident took place,” the ECB statement said.

“We are currently seeking further information, and an announcement regarding the squad for the second test will be made in due course.”

A curfew was reimposed on England in January following the humiliating Ashes tour of Australia, where England was accused of excessive drinking and unprofessionalism.

openers could not get their slog sweep right against Badoni to be caught.

Electing to bat, India A were pushed to a mini-crisis at 16 for two in five overs after early dismissals of Sooryavanshi and Prabhsimran Singh. But vice-captain Gaikwad, who fetched his 21st List A hundred in 112 balls, and skipper Tilak Varma (60, 97b) added 150 runs for the fourth wicket to steady India’s ship.

There were persistent strong winds across the ground, and the pitch too offered some assistance to the bowlers, making batting a rather tough proposition. But Gaikwad and Tilak summoned their years of experience in domestic cricket to resist Lanka’s charge after coming together at 69 for three.